

ARES PRIME

A Detective Jax Novel



by James Brentlinger

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Ares Prime

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Chapter One: The Red Dust

Dawn on Mars was a lie.

The sun rose over the eastern ridge of Valles Marineris like a pale, anemic ghost, casting long shadows across the rust-colored wasteland. Detective Jax gripped the steering yoke of her battered police spinner, watching the red dust spiral up from the treads as she pushed the vehicle hard across the ancient lakebed. The dust didn't just coat the windshield—it coated everything. The boots, the lungs, the soul. It tasted like old iron and deferred dreams, and it never, ever washed out.

She'd been driving for forty minutes, leaving the cramped, subterranean warrens of Sector 4 behind and climbing toward the Zenith Domes. The domes rose on the horizon like crystalline tumors, gleaming and obscene against the dead Martian sky. Up there, the air was clean. The gravity was Earth-normal. The wealthy didn't have to ration water or worry about structural failures in the biodome seals.

Up there, people pretended Mars was already won.

Jax knew better. She'd learned it at fourteen, buried under two hundred meters of collapsed rock in the Tantalus Mining Camp, listening to her parents' final, wet breaths in the darkness. Mars didn't forgive. It didn't compromise. And the people who profited from its conquest were the same ones who cut corners on the safety equipment that killed miners by the dozen.

She hated the Zenith Domes. But a body was a body, and the dead didn't care about her feelings.

The red dust of Ares Prime didn't just coat the boots; it coated the soul. It crept through the micro-fractures in the lower-level biodomes, settled in the lungs, and tasted like old iron and deferred dreams.

Detective Jax hated the dust. But standing in the pristine, climate-controlled foyer of Penthouse 4A in the Zenith Domes, she found herself missing it. Up here, the air tasted like nothing. It was scrubbed so clean of impurities, heavily oxygenated, and laced with a faint, synthetic hint of pine, that it made her teeth ache.

The Zenith Domes weren't just a different neighborhood—they were a different planet. Built on reinforced bedrock with localized gravity plating that mimicked Earth-standard pull, the domes housed the colonial elite in a bubble of artificial perfection. The air pressure was regulated to sea-level equivalent. The water wasn't recycled gray sludge but actual, distilled purity piped in from the northern ice caps. The floors were imported marble. The lighting was soft, warm, and designed by psychologists to reduce stress and promote productivity.

It was suffocating.

Jax had worked homicides in the lower sectors for fifteen years. She knew what murder looked like when it was born from desperation—a water ration dispute that ended with a shiv between the ribs, a gang execution in a rusted-out hab module, a domestic violence call that went sideways when the husband's fists finally did what they'd been threatening for months. Those crime scenes smelled like sweat and fear

and the coppery tang of blood pooling on cheap polymer flooring.

This was different. Up here, murder wore a tailored suit. It had a corporate expense account. It happened in penthouses with vaulted ceilings and smart-glass windows that cost more than Jax would earn in a decade. The violence was cleaner, more precise, but no less brutal. If anything, it was worse—because up here, the killers had the resources to make the bodies disappear, to buy silence, to ensure that justice was a commodity reserved for those who could afford it.

Jax felt the familiar tightness in her chest, the claustrophobic weight of being somewhere she didn't belong. The air was too clean. The silence was too perfect. Even the hum of the environmental systems was engineered to be soothing, a low, almost subsonic vibration that was supposed to calm the nervous system.

It made her want to punch something.

Jax stepped off the mag-lev elevator, her worn, synth-leather trench coat starkly out of place against the gleaming white marble of the corridor. The Zenith Domes hovered in the upper stratosphere of the colony, reserved exclusively for the billionaires who owned the terraforming rigs, the water rations, and the politicians.

"Detective on deck," a uniformed transit cop muttered, stepping back from the crime scene tape.

Jax didn't acknowledge him. She ducked under the glowing yellow holo-tape and stepped into the penthouse. The sheer scale of the room was a vulgar display of wealth. Vaulted ceilings, expansive glass walls looking out over the sprawling, neon-scarred expanse of the lower colony, and gravity-dampeners that made every step feel unnervingly light.

The penthouse stretched out before her like an architectural fever dream. The main living area was easily two hundred square meters, with a sunken seating arrangement centered around a holographic fireplace that crackled with simulated flames. The furniture was all organic

materials—real wood, real leather, the kind of luxury that required shipping costs measured in the tens of thousands of credits per kilogram. Abstract art hung on the walls, the kind of incomprehensible splashes of color that the wealthy pretended to understand. A full bar dominated the western wall, stocked with bottles of actual, Earth-distilled alcohol that would cost a lower-sector worker a month's salary per shot.

But beneath the opulence, Jax's trained eye caught the details that mattered. No signs of forced entry on the reinforced security door. No scuff marks on the polished floor leading from the entrance. The smart-home system was still active, playing a low, classical symphony—something baroque, maybe Bach—that felt profoundly grotesque given the circumstances. The temperature was precisely regulated at twenty-one degrees Celsius. The lighting was set to “evening ambient,” a warm, golden glow that made everything look softer than it was.

Whoever had done this had been invited in. Or they'd had access codes.

Then, the smell hit her. It cut right through the artificial pine.

Burnt meat. Ozone. Copper.

The smell was wrong for the space. It didn't belong in this sanitized, climate-controlled bubble of wealth. It was organic, visceral, and unmistakably human. Jax's stomach tightened—not from nausea, but from recognition. She'd smelled that particular combination before, in the aftermath of an industrial accident in Sector 7 where a worker had been caught in a plasma cutter malfunction. The ozone meant high-energy discharge. The burnt meat meant cauterization. The copper meant blood, even if there wasn't much of it visible.

This wasn't a crime of passion. This was surgical.

“Over here, Jax.”

Officer Chen was already by the primary seating area, her standard-issue datapad casting a pale blue glow over her eager, slightly flushed face. Chen was new to Homicide, fresh out of the upper-level academy, and still possessed the annoying habit of looking at a corpse as a puzzle

rather than a tragedy.

Jax crossed the room, pulling a pair of sterile molecular-weave gloves from her pockets and snapping them over her hands. “Talk to me, Chen. What ruins my only day off in three weeks?”

“Victim is Marcus Tyrell, forty-two,” Chen said, swiping a finger across her datapad. “Senior VP of Atmospheric Engineering for Vance Interplanetary. Single, no registered co-habitants. The transit patrol got an automated ping from the penthouse’s medical sensors twenty minutes ago indicating a sudden cessation of vital signs.”

“Sudden is one word for it,” Jax murmured, stopping at the edge of a genuine, imported-from-Earth Persian rug.

Tyrell was sprawled on his back, his eyes wide and glassy, reflecting the cold light of the chandelier above. He was dressed in a tailored silk lounge suit, but the front of it was completely ruined.

Jax knelt, her knees popping—a parting gift from a riot in Sector 4 three years ago. She leaned in close, careful not to let her coat brush the fibers of the rug. There was virtually no blood, which was what made the smell so overpowering. The victim’s chest had been laid open with terrifying precision.

The wounds were clean. Too clean. Jax had seen her share of stabbings, shootings, blunt-force trauma—violence was rarely neat. But this was different. The incisions ran in parallel lines across Tyrell’s sternum and ribcage, each cut approximately two centimeters apart. The edges of the flesh were blackened and slightly raised, the telltale signature of instant cauterization. Whoever had done this had taken their time. The cuts weren’t frenzied or random—they were methodical, almost exploratory.

Jax’s mind catalogued the details automatically. No defensive wounds on the hands or forearms. No signs of restraint marks on the wrists or ankles. Tyrell’s expression was frozen in shock rather than agony, which suggested the first cut had been fast enough to induce immediate trauma. The killer had known exactly where to strike.

“Look at the margins,” Jax pointed a gloved finger at the wounds. The edges of the flesh were blackened, instantly cauterized.

“A Class-4 laser scalpel,” Chen breathed, leaning in closer, her dark eyes widening. “Those are military-grade. Highly restricted. You couldn’t even get one past the lower-level security checkpoints without tripping a dozen alarms, let alone up into the Zenith Domes.”

“Someone did,” Jax said. Her voice was flat, devoid of the shock Chen was currently radiating. “And they didn’t just slash wildly. This isn’t a crime of passion, Chen. This is dissection.”

She studied the pattern of the cuts more closely. The killer had opened the chest cavity with surgical precision, exposing the heart and lungs without damaging the surrounding tissue more than necessary. It was the kind of work that required not just access to restricted equipment, but training. Medical training, or military. Someone who knew anatomy, who understood how to cut without causing unnecessary damage.

“Chen, what’s the ambient temperature reading in this room?”

Chen glanced at her datapad. “Twenty-one degrees Celsius. Standard climate control.”

“And time of death?”

“Medical sensors logged the cessation of vitals at 0342 hours. That’s approximately two hours ago.”

Jax nodded slowly. “So the body’s been here for two hours in a climate-controlled environment. No decomposition, no significant blood pooling. The killer cauterized as they cut, which means minimal blood spatter. They were careful. Methodical.”

“Why go to all that trouble?” Chen asked, her voice dropping to a whisper. “If you’re going to kill someone, why make it so... precise?”

“Because they were looking for something,” Jax said quietly. “Or they were sending a message.”

Jax swept her gaze around the immediate vicinity. No signs of forced entry. No shattered glass. No scuff marks on the pristine marble flooring

leading to the rug. The smart-home system was humming along happily, playing a low, classical symphony that felt profoundly grotesque given the circumstances.

“Run a localized holo-sweep for footprints or foreign micro-fibers,” Jax ordered, standing up and rolling her shoulders to release the tension knotting in her neck. “And get forensics up here to pull the victim’s comms logs.”

“Already requested,” Chen said brightly. “Though Forensics said they’re backed up with a mass transit derailment in Sector 7.”

“Tell them an executive for Vance Interplanetary just got carved up like a Sunday roast. They’ll find the time.” Jax walked toward the massive floor-to-ceiling smart window. She touched the glass. It was cold.

Out there, beyond the protective dome, the Martian surface was an endless ocean of rusted rock and deep, shadowy craters. It was a dead world that humanity was desperately trying to beat into submission. And inside the dome, humanity was doing the exact same thing to itself.

“Jax?” Chen’s voice broke her reverie.

“What?”

“I was running the property records on the penthouse. Tyrell doesn’t own it.”

Jax turned around, raising an eyebrow. “At his salary? Why rent?”

“He isn’t renting,” Chen said, tapping her datapad, a frown creasing her forehead. “The property is a corporate lease. It’s owned directly by a shell corporation, which is a subsidiary of Vance Interplanetary.”

Jax sighed, feeling the familiar, heavy ache of a headache forming behind her eyes. In Ares Prime, dealing with corporate murders meant dealing with private security, suppressed evidence, and politicians breathing down her neck. “So the company owns the victim, and the company owns the crime scene.”

“Not just the company,” Chen corrected, looking up. She swallowed hard. “The deed is registered in a personal trust. It belongs to Elara

Vance.”

The headache suddenly bloomed into a sharp spike. Elara Vance. The CEO. The heir to the terraforming empire. The woman who practically held the atmospheric controls of the entire colony in her perfectly manicured hands.

Jax felt the familiar weight settle over her shoulders, the bone-deep exhaustion that came with knowing a case was about to become a nightmare. She’d worked corporate homicides before. They were never clean. The moment a victim had ties to one of the Big Three—Vance Interplanetary, Helios Terraforming, or Meridian Mining—the case stopped being about justice and started being about damage control.

The lawyers would arrive within the hour, armed with injunctions and gag orders. The Commissioner would get a call from someone with enough political capital to make his career evaporate. Evidence would disappear. Witnesses would recant. And Jax would be left holding a case file full of redacted documents and dead ends, expected to close it quickly and quietly without asking too many uncomfortable questions.

She’d seen it happen a dozen times. Hell, she’d been the one forced to close those cases, filing reports that everyone knew were lies but no one had the power—or the courage—to challenge.

But this was different. This wasn’t just corporate malfeasance or a suspicious industrial accident. This was murder. Premeditated, precise, and brutal. Someone had taken a Class-4 laser scalpel into Elara Vance’s personal penthouse and dissected one of her senior executives like a lab specimen.

That took resources. Access. And most importantly, it took a reason.

Jax’s mind was already running through the possibilities. Corporate espionage gone wrong. A personal vendetta. A message sent to Vance herself. Or maybe Tyrell had discovered something he wasn’t supposed to know, and someone had decided to silence him permanently.

Whatever the reason, this case was going to be a fight. The kind of

fight that ended careers. The kind of fight that got good cops reassigned to traffic duty in the outer mining sectors.

Jax had never been good at backing down.

“Great,” Jax muttered, running a hand through her dark, cropped hair. “Lock down the elevators. Set up a perimeter. Nothing gets in or out without my authorization.”

She took a breath, steadying herself. The crime scene was hers. For now. She had maybe six hours before the corporate lawyers descended like vultures, maybe twelve before the Commissioner pulled her off the case entirely. She needed to work fast, document everything, and find something—anything—that would give her leverage when the inevitable pressure came.

The dead deserved that much. Tyrell deserved that much.

Even if he’d been a corporate executive living in a penthouse that cost more than most people earned in a lifetime, he’d still been a person. He’d still had a life, a story, a reason someone wanted him dead. And Jax had learned a long time ago, buried in the darkness of Tantalus with her parents’ bodies cooling beside her, that the dead couldn’t speak for themselves.

Someone had to speak for them.

Before Chen could confirm the order, the mag-lev elevator at the end of the hall chimed. A soft, melodic sound that signaled a direct override of police lockdown protocols.

Jax unholstered her sidearm instinctively, dropping into a defensive stance. “I said lock it down, Chen!”

“I did!” Chen panicked, frantically tapping her pad. “Someone bypassed the precinct encryption. They have Level-1 Admin access.”

The elevator doors slid open with a whisper.

Jax leveled her weapon. “Ares Prime PD! Freeze!”

Footsteps echoed in the corridor, unhurried and deliberately rhythmic. A silhouette stepped out of the shadows and into the stark lighting of

the foyer.

“You can put the gun away, Detective,” a smooth, dark voice echoed through the room. “Unless you plan on shooting the woman who owns the floor you’re standing on.”

2

Chapter Two: The Owner

Jax did not lower the weapon. Her stance remained wide, her grip perfectly steady, the targeting laser of her sidearm painting a bright, lethal red dot directly on the center of the intruder's chest.

"I don't care if you own the air we're breathing," Jax said, her voice dropping to a gravelly register that usually made lower-level gang runners scatter. "You just bypassed a Class-A police barricade. Identify yourself, or you'll be spending the night in a holding cell that doesn't care about your tax bracket."

The woman stepped fully into the harsh, unsympathetic light of the chandelier.

For a second—a long, suspended second that seemed to stretch and distort like gravity itself—the sheer presence of her sucked the remaining oxygen out of the room.

Jax had seen wealth before. She'd arrested trust-fund addicts in the mid-levels, interrogated corporate executives who wore watches worth more than her annual salary, even stood in the same room as colonial senators draped in imported silk. But this was different. This wasn't just money. This was power, distilled into human form and wrapped in a package designed to make lesser mortals forget how to breathe.

The woman was tall—easily six feet in the low-gravity environment of the Zenith Domes—and she moved with a fluid, predatory grace that suggested martial training hidden beneath layers of exorbitant wealth. Every step was deliberate, controlled, economical. No wasted motion. No hesitation. She wore a bespoke suit of charcoal grey that seemed to absorb the light rather than reflect it. Not synth-weave, Jax noted with a jolt of recognition that sent her pulse spiking, but actual, Earth-grown wool, cut perfectly to the sharp lines of her shoulders and the narrow, dangerous curve of her waist.

The tailoring was immaculate. The fabric moved like liquid shadow, conforming to her body with the kind of precision that required a personal tailor and measurements taken to the millimeter. The jacket was open, revealing a crisp white shirt beneath, the collar unbuttoned just enough to show the elegant line of her throat. No jewelry except for a single silver cuff on her left wrist—understated, minimalist, and probably worth more than Jax's entire apartment building.

Her hair was a dark, liquid cascade swept cleanly back from her face, highlighting high, aristocratic cheekbones and a jawline that could cut glass. Her skin was pale, almost luminous in the artificial light, the kind of complexion that came from never having to work under the harsh Martian sun, never having to ration water for bathing, never having to worry about the micro-abrasions that came from breathing recycled air laced with red dust.

But it was her eyes that made the hairs on the back of Jax's neck stand up.

They were a startling, icy silver—not grey, not blue, but genuine metallic silver, the kind that only came from high-end genetic modification or neural-lace integration. And they were fixed entirely on Jax with an intensity that felt almost physical, like a weight pressing against her chest.

Jax's finger tightened fractionally on the trigger. Her training

screamed at her to maintain the threat posture, to establish dominance, to not let this woman—whoever she was—take control of the situation. But something deeper, something primal and entirely unwelcome, was making her heart hammer against her ribs in a rhythm that had nothing to do with adrenaline and everything to do with the way those silver eyes were cataloguing her, measuring her, seeing her in a way that made her feel simultaneously exposed and electrified.

“Elara Vance,” the woman said. Her tone was a low, melodic drawl, entirely unbothered by the heavy-caliber pistol pointed at her heart. Each word was precisely enunciated, carrying the kind of confidence that came from never having been told ‘no’ in her entire life. “And the air you’re breathing right now? I do, in fact, own it. You’re welcome.”

Behind Jax, Officer Chen made a sound that was half-gasp, half-choke. “Sir—Detective—that’s the CEO.”

“I know who she is, Chen,” Jax snapped, never breaking eye contact with the silver-eyed billionaire. Her mind was racing, cataloguing details, running threat assessments, trying desperately to ignore the way her pulse was doing complicated, unwelcome things in her throat. Reluctantly, feeling the absolute wrongness of it in her gut, Jax flicked the safety on and holstered her weapon. “You’re contaminating my crime scene, Ms. Vance.”

“It’s my property, Detective. I’m simply inspecting the damage.” Elara walked past Jax, leaving a slipstream of air in her wake.

Jax caught the scent and her brain misfired for a fraction of a second. It wasn’t the synthetic, chemical perfumes peddled in the mid-levels, the kind that smelled like industrial solvents and false promises. It wasn’t the cheap, floral body sprays that lower-sector workers used to mask the smell of recycled sweat. It smelled like crushed damp leaves, old paper, and a faint, electric hint of ozone. It smelled like a thunderstorm on Earth—a planet Jax had never visited, would never be able to afford to visit, but had dreamed about in the darkness of her childhood. It was

an intoxicating, impossible scent on a dead planet.

Jax shook her head, forcing her focus back to the corpse as Elara stopped at the edge of the Persian rug, looking down at her murdered Vice President of Atmospheric Engineering.

For a long moment, Elara simply stood there, perfectly still. The classical symphony was still playing softly in the background—Bach, Jax realized now, something baroque and mathematical and entirely inappropriate for a murder scene. The holographic fireplace crackled with simulated flames. The smart-glass windows reflected the distant, neon-scarred sprawl of the lower colony.

And Elara Vance stared down at the dissected corpse of Marcus Tyrell with an expression that Jax couldn't quite read.

Most civilians—even the hardened ones—flinched when they saw a Class-4 laser dissection. The charred flesh, the exposed, calcified ribs, the sheer violence of it usually elicited a visceral reaction. Jax had seen corporate executives vomit at crime scenes. She'd seen gang bosses turn pale. She'd seen hardened soldiers look away.

Elara Vance didn't blink.

Her silver eyes tracked over the body with cool, terrifying clinical detachment. She tilted her head slightly, studying the pattern of the cuts, the precision of the incisions, the cauterization marks along the edges of the wounds. Her expression didn't change. No horror. No disgust. No shock. Just... assessment.

Jax watched her carefully, reading the micro-expressions, the subtle shifts in body language that most people didn't even realize they were broadcasting. Elara's breathing was steady, controlled. Her hands were relaxed at her sides, not clenched, not trembling. Her pupils were slightly dilated, but that could have been the lighting. There was no tension in her shoulders, no tightness around her mouth.

Either she was a sociopath, or she'd seen violence before. Real violence. The kind that left scars.

Jax filed that information away for later.

“Messy,” Elara concluded, her voice barely a murmur. “Tyrell was a fastidious man. He would have hated this.”

“I imagine the being dead part is what he hates the most,” Jax said dryly, stepping up beside her. Not too close. Just close enough to re-establish her territory, to remind Elara Vance that this was still a police investigation, still Jax’s jurisdiction, no matter how many billions of credits were standing next to her. “How did you know he was dead? My precinct hasn’t even notified his next of kin.”

Elara finally turned her head, looking at Jax. She was close enough now that Jax could see the faint, metallic rim of neural-lace implants tracing her left temple—high-end cognitive enhancers, the kind that cost more than a house in the mid-levels. The kind that could process data streams in real-time, interface directly with quantum computing networks, and probably hack into most civilian security systems without breaking a sweat.

“Tyrell was wearing a Vance Interplanetary biometric monitor,” Elara said, her gaze dropping to Jax’s mouth for a micro-second before returning to her eyes. The movement was so quick, so subtle, that Jax almost convinced herself she’d imagined it. Almost. “When his heart stopped, the data spiked to my personal security grid before the automated ping ever reached your archaic police dispatch. I happened to be in the adjoining sector.”

“Convenient,” Jax muttered, her detective’s instincts screaming at her to dig deeper, to question the timing, to not accept anything at face value.

“Efficiency usually is,” Elara countered smoothly. “The biometric monitors are standard issue for all senior executives. They track heart rate, blood pressure, oxygen saturation, neural activity, and a dozen other vital signs in real-time. The data is encrypted and transmitted via quantum-entangled relay to our central medical AI. When Tyrell’s

vitals flatlined at 0342 hours, the system flagged it as a critical medical emergency and sent an immediate alert to my personal grid, my Chief of Security, and the on-call medical team.”

“And you just happened to be close enough to arrive before the police,” Jax said, not bothering to hide the skepticism in her voice.

“I was in a board meeting in the adjoining tower,” Elara replied, her tone perfectly neutral. “I excused myself the moment I received the alert. My private transport can make the cross-dome transit in under three minutes.”

Jax filed that away too. Three minutes. Fast enough to be the first on scene. Fast enough to tamper with evidence, if she’d wanted to.

“And you are?” Elara asked, tilting her head a fraction of an inch, a ghost of a smile playing on her lips.

“Detective Jax. Homicide.”

Elara’s smile widened, just slightly. “Just Jax? Like a stray dog?”

Jax felt a flare of irritation, hot and sharp. “Like a cop who wants to know why the CEO of the biggest conglomerate on Mars is rushing to a crime scene instead of sending her lawyers,” Jax shot back, crossing her arms over her chest. The worn synth-leather of her coat creaked, a harsh, discordant sound in the pristine silence of the penthouse. “Usually, people like you do everything in your power to stay as far away from a bleeding corpse as possible.”

“People like me,” Elara repeated, her voice dropping to a lower register, something darker and more dangerous threading through the words. “You mean wealthy people, Detective? Or do you mean people who actually have something to lose?”

“I mean people who can afford to make problems disappear,” Jax said flatly.

“Ah.” Elara’s silver eyes glittered with something that might have been amusement or might have been anger. It was impossible to tell. “You think I’m here to cover something up. How delightfully cynical.”

“I’m a homicide detective in Ares Prime,” Jax said. “Cynicism is a job requirement.”

“Fair enough.” Elara took a step closer, closing the distance between them until Jax could feel the heat radiating from her body, could see the faint pulse beating in her throat. “But let me be very clear, Detective Jax. Tyrell wasn’t just an employee. He possessed intimate, heavily classified knowledge of the colony’s atmospheric regulators. He knew the structural tolerances of every dome, the redundancy protocols, the emergency shutdown sequences. He had access to systems that, if compromised, could kill thousands of people in a matter of hours.”

Elara’s gaze hardened, the icy silver flashing with genuine steel. “If someone tortured him before they killed him—and judging by the cauterization patterns, they did—I need to know what he told them. I need to know if my infrastructure is compromised. I need to know if there’s a bomb waiting to go off somewhere in my colony.”

Jax felt a flare of irritation. “This is a homicide investigation, Ms. Vance. Not a corporate espionage audit. You don’t get to run parallel inquiries.”

“I am not asking for your permission,” Elara said softly. It wasn’t a threat; it was a simple statement of fact, delivered with the crushing weight of a woman who bought and sold senators before breakfast.

Jax took a step closer, invading Elara’s personal space. She had to tilt her head up slightly to meet the billionaire’s eyes, but she didn’t yield an inch of ground. “Listen to me very carefully. I don’t care how many credits you have in your accounts. You are standing in my jurisdiction. This body is my case. And if you interfere, I will arrest you for obstruction, and I will thoroughly enjoy watching you sit in a holding cell that smells like stale urine and regret.”

Silence stretched between them, heavy and electric. The air felt charged, like the moment before a lightning strike. Chen was standing frozen by the window, desperately pretending to be invisible, her datapad

clutched to her chest like a shield.

Jax waited for the explosion. She waited for the threats, the demands to speak to her captain, the imperious rage of the elite. She'd seen it a hundred times before—wealthy suspects who couldn't comprehend that their money didn't buy them immunity from the law.

Instead, Elara Vance smiled. It was a slow, predatory curving of her lips that made Jax's stomach do a complicated, unwelcome flip.

"You're very fiercely protective of your territory, Detective," Elara murmured, her voice dropping to an intimate frequency that seemed meant only for Jax. "I can appreciate that."

Jax swallowed hard, determined not to let the flush creeping up her neck reach her face. "Step back from the body, Ms. Vance."

Elara held her hands up in a gesture of mock surrender and took a slow step backward. "Of course. I wouldn't dream of stepping on your toes. In fact, I'm going to make your life considerably easier."

Elara tapped the silver cuff linking her left wrist. A small, holographic data-chit materialized in the air between them, glowing with soft blue light. "Your police grid is a joke, Jax. It'll take your technicians three days just to decrypt the building's lobby cameras. Here is the raw, unedited feed from my private security network for the last forty-eight hours, covering the entire Zenith dome perimeter and this penthouse."

Jax stared at the glowing blue data-chit. It was exactly what she needed. It was also a Trojan horse.

"Why give me this?" Jax asked, her voice carefully neutral.

"Because whoever killed Tyrell bypassed three layers of my proprietary encryption to do it," Elara said, the amusement finally vanishing from her face, leaving behind a cold, calculating intellect. "They made me look vulnerable. I want them found. You want them found. Our goals align."

"For now," Jax said. She reached out and snatched the data-chit from the air. The momentary brush of her gloved fingers against Elara's bare

skin sent a bizarre, static shock racing up Jax's arm.

Elara's eyes tracked the movement. "I expect to be kept in the loop on your findings, Detective."

"You'll get the public briefing like everyone else," Jax said, slipping the chit into her pocket.

"We'll see," Elara replied quietly. She turned to leave, the heavy, expensive fabric of her coat sweeping around her ankles. She paused at the threshold of the mag-lev elevator and looked back over her shoulder.

"It was a pleasure meeting you, Jax. I have a feeling we're going to be seeing a great deal of each other."

The elevator doors slid shut, cutting off the view of her sharp smile.

Jax stood in the silence of the room for a long moment, the scent of the Earth thunderstorm still lingering in her lungs. Her pulse was hammering against her ribs, a heavy, adrenaline-fueled rhythm that had nothing to do with the dead body on the floor.

Her mind was racing, cataloguing everything that had just happened, running threat assessments, trying to piece together the implications. Elara Vance had given her the security footage. Just handed it over, no lawyers, no negotiations, no demands for reciprocity. That was either a gesture of good faith or a calculated move to control the narrative. Probably both.

The data-chit felt heavy in her pocket, like a live grenade. It would give her access to Vance's private security network, which meant she'd be able to see exactly who came and went from the penthouse in the forty-eight hours before Tyrell's death. But it also meant Elara would know exactly what Jax was looking at, when she was looking at it, and what conclusions she was drawing. The woman had neural-lace implants. She could probably monitor the data access in real-time.

Jax didn't trust it. She didn't trust Elara Vance. And she especially didn't trust the way her body had reacted to the woman's proximity—the spike in her pulse, the heat in her chest, the way her skin had felt

electrified when their fingers had brushed.

That was dangerous. That was the kind of distraction that got good cops killed.

But she couldn't deny the woman was right about one thing: their goals did align. Jax wanted to find Tyrell's killer. Elara wanted to protect her infrastructure. And if someone had tortured a senior executive for classified information about the colony's atmospheric systems, then this case was bigger than a simple homicide. This was terrorism. Sabotage. Maybe even the prelude to a mass-casualty event.

Jax exhaled slowly, rubbing the bridge of her nose. The headache was back, sharper than before, pulsing behind her eyes in time with her heartbeat.

She needed to get back to the precinct. She needed to run the security footage through forensic analysis. She needed to dig into Tyrell's background, his communications, his financial records. She needed to figure out who had the skills, the access, and the motive to bypass three layers of Vance's proprietary encryption and dissect a man with a Class-4 laser scalpel.

And she needed to do it before Elara Vance decided to take matters into her own hands.

"Detective?" Chen ventured nervously from the corner, her voice small and uncertain. "Are you okay?"

Jax turned to look at her junior officer. Chen's eyes were wide, her face pale, her datapad still clutched to her chest like a lifeline. She looked like she'd just witnessed something she didn't have the vocabulary to process.

Jax took a breath, forcing herself back into the familiar armor of professionalism. She straightened her shoulders, rolled her neck to release the tension, and let the mask of the hardened detective slide back into place.

"Yeah, Chen," Jax muttered, turning her back to the elevator and

staring down at the grisly remains of Marcus Tyrell. “I’m fine. But notify the Captain. Vance Interplanetary is officially involved, and I think the CEO just decided to make this case her personal entertainment.”

She looked at the data-chit glowing through the fabric of her coat pocket.

“Come on,” Jax said, her voice turning hard and entirely professional once more. “Let’s bag this up. We’re going to be working late.”

Chapter Three: The Bureaucracy

Precinct 12, Sector Four, smelled like stale sweat, burnt ozone, and the sour tang of cheap synth-caf. It was a sensory assault that Jax usually found grounding, but after the sterile, pine-scented wealth of the Zenith Domes, it just felt suffocating.

The precinct was a subterranean concrete bunker buried deep beneath the colony's surface, holding the line between the struggling mid-levels and the lawless mining sectors. The atmospheric scrubbers down here had been rattling for a decade, pumping out air that always tasted faintly of old pennies.

Jax bypassed her desk entirely and headed straight for the glass-walled office at the back of the bullpen. She didn't bother knocking.

Captain Graves looked up from his terminal, his face illuminated by the harsh, flickering glow of the screen. He was a man who looked exactly like the sector he policed: battered, permanently exhausted, and held together by cheap nicotine patches and spite.

"I haven't even had my morning ration, Jax," Graves grunted, rubbing

a hand over his deeply lined face. “Tell me you didn’t piss off the single most powerful woman on this rock.”

“Good morning to you too, Captain,” Jax said, dropping into the uncomfortable poly-plas chair across from his desk. It squeaked in protest. “And for the record, I merely secured my crime scene. If Elara Vance felt insulted that I didn’t roll out the red carpet over a brutally murdered corpse, that’s her problem.”

Graves closed his eyes, inhaling a long, slow breath through his nose. “Vance’s legal team has already called the Commissioner, who then called the Chief, who then called me. They want this wrapped up, Jax. Neatly. Quietly. Yesterday.”

“A Vance Interplanetary executive got fileted with a restricted military laser in a secure penthouse,” Jax said, her voice tightening. “There is no ‘neat’ and ‘quiet’ here, Graves. The killer bypassed a fortune in corporate security to do it.”

“Exactly,” Graves snapped, leaning forward. “Which is why Vance thinks it’s corporate espionage. A rival firm sending a message. She wants her private security handling the fallout, and she wants us to stamp a ‘robbery gone wrong’ on the file and walk away.”

Jax let out a harsh, barking laugh. “A robbery? Nothing was taken! The guy’s antique Earth-art collection was untouched. This was an execution, and Vance knows it. She gave me her private security feeds.”

Graves paused, his eyebrows shooting up. “Vance handed over her private network data? Willingly?”

“Handed it to me herself,” Jax said, pulling the blue, glowing data-chit from her pocket and tossing it onto Graves’s desk. It clattered against his cheap plastic stylus. “She wants to find the killer just as much as we do. But she wants to do it on her terms, which means she’s hiding something.”

Graves stared at the chit like it was a live thermal detonator. “Jax, listen to me. You dig too deep into Vance Interplanetary, you’re not just

risking your badge. You're risking your oxygen ration. These people don't play by the same laws we enforce down here."

"I don't care how much air she owns," Jax said, her jaw setting into a stubborn line. "Tyrell is my body now. I speak for him. And I am going to find out who turned his chest cavity into a puzzle."

Graves studied her for a long moment, reading the immutable resolve in her dark eyes. He sighed, a sound of utter defeat. "Seventy-two hours, Jax. You have three days to find me a viable suspect before the Commissioner forces me to hand jurisdiction over to Vance's private army. Keep your head down. And for the love of God, don't antagonize the woman again."

"I'll be the picture of bureaucratic compliance," Jax lied smoothly, standing up.

"I mean it, Jax!" Graves yelled as she walked out.

Jax let the glass door click shut behind her, immediately tuning out the chaotic noise of the bullpen. Seventy-two hours. Three days to solve a murder that had corporate fingerprints all over it, or watch the case get buried under a mountain of legal injunctions and classified redactions. It was the same song and dance she'd seen a dozen times before. The wealthy killed each other with impunity, and the cops in the lower sectors were expected to look the other way and be grateful for the privilege.

She walked slowly through the precinct, her boots echoing on the cracked polymer flooring. Around her, the machinery of colonial law enforcement ground forward with exhausted inevitability. Officer Ramirez was processing a drunk-and-disorderly from the transit hub, the suspect still reeking of industrial solvent and bad decisions. Detective Kowalski was on the phone with a domestic violence victim who was already recanting her statement, her voice small and defeated through the speaker. The holding cells in the back were full of the usual suspects—water thieves, ration forgers, unlicensed oxygen dealers.

This was the reality of police work on Mars. They didn't solve crimes;

they managed the chaos. They kept the desperate from killing each other over scraps while the people in the Zenith Domes lived like gods and pretended the lower sectors didn't exist. Jax had made peace with that reality a long time ago. She couldn't fix the system. She couldn't make Mars fair. But she could speak for the dead, and that had to be enough.

Even when the dead were corporate executives who'd lived in pent-houses worth more than her entire precinct's annual budget.

She walked over to her desk—a scarred metal slab piled high with flimsies and half-empty water pouches.

Chen was already there, aggressively tapping away at her dual-screen setup. Her uniform was impossibly crisp, a stark contrast to the organized disaster of Jax's workspace.

"Tell me you have something, Chen," Jax said, dropping into her chair and kicking her boots up onto the edge of the desk. She rubbed her temples. The headache was migrating from a dull ache to a sharp stabbing sensation behind her left eye.

"I'm running the data-chit Vance gave us through our decryption algorithms," Chen said, not looking away from the cascading lines of code on her screen. "It's clean. No viruses, no backdoors. It's exactly what she said it was—forty-eight hours of raw, uncompressed video and sensory data."

"Any sign of our phantom surgeon on the feeds?"

"Nothing so far. The guy was a ghost. But," Chen hit a keystroke with a triumphant flourish, "I did pull Tyrell's personal comms logs before Vance's corporate goons could scrub them. And things get interesting."

Jax leaned forward, the headache momentarily forgotten. "Show me."

"Tyrell was the VP of Atmospheric Engineering, which means he oversaw the pressure regulators for the lower sectors," Chen explained, bringing up a complex schematic of the colony's dome structure. "For the last three weeks, he's been making encrypted, off-the-grid calls to a burner comm in Sector 6. The mining districts."

“Why is a Zenith Dome executive talking to rock-crushers in Sector 6?”

“That’s the million-credit question,” Chen said. “I dug into Tyrell’s personal file partition. It was heavily encrypted, but whoever killed him left a backdoor wide open when they wiped his main drive. Tyrell was compiling data on Sector 4’s water recycling plants. Specifically, the filtration quotas.”

Jax frowned, staring at the numbers scrolling across the screen. Sector 4 was right above them. It was a massive, densely populated district of factory workers and low-level corporate drones. “The quotas look normal.”

“On paper, yes,” Chen said. “But look at the actual output logs Tyrell buried in this hidden folder.”

Chen overlaid a second set of numbers. Jax wasn’t a mathematician, but she didn’t need to be to see the glaring discrepancy.

“The output is short,” Jax murmured. “They’re siphoning the water.”

“Millions of gallons of it over the last six months,” Chen confirmed, her fingers dancing across the keyboard to pull up additional data streams. “Someone is systematically diverting purified water meant for the lower sectors and doctoring the ledgers to cover it up. Tyrell found out.”

Jax studied the numbers more carefully, her detective’s mind already running scenarios. “Walk me through the technical side. How would someone even pull this off without triggering alarms?”

Chen pulled up a schematic of the filtration plant’s control systems. “The water recycling plants are automated. They’re monitored by AI systems that track input, filtration efficiency, and output distribution. But there’s a manual override protocol for maintenance and emergency repairs. If someone had administrative access to the plant’s control network, they could redirect water flow during scheduled maintenance windows and alter the output logs to match the expected quotas.”

“So we’re looking for someone with high-level system access,” Jax said. “Plant managers, senior engineers, maybe corporate oversight.”

“Exactly. And here’s where it gets worse.” Chen brought up a financial analysis overlay. “I cross-referenced the water theft timeline with commodity pricing in the outer sectors. During the same six-month period, black-market water prices in Sectors 5 and 6 dropped by thirty percent. Someone was flooding the illegal market with stolen water.”

“Water is more valuable than currency down here,” Jax said, her mind racing, piecing the puzzle together. “If Tyrell was getting ready to blow the whistle on a massive water-theft ring, that’s a hell of a motive for murder. But who was he talking to in Sector 6?”

“I’m still trying to trace the burner comm,” Chen said, pulling up a network map showing the signal’s path through the colony’s communication infrastructure. “It’s bouncing off a dozen different relay towers. Whoever set it up knew what they were doing. But I’m running a pattern analysis on the call timestamps and locations. If I can narrow down the physical location of the burner comm when the calls were made, I might be able to identify the recipient.”

“How long?”

“Give me six hours. Maybe less if I can get access to the Sector 6 transit authority’s surveillance feeds.”

Jax nodded, her mind already working through the implications. A water-theft conspiracy involving millions of gallons meant serious money. It meant organized crime, probably cartel involvement. And if Tyrell had been negotiating with someone in Sector 6, he’d either been trying to expose them or cut himself in on the profits. Either way, he’d made himself a target.

“Keep on it,” Jax ordered. “And look into Vance Interplanetary’s water distribution subsidiaries. I want to know who signs the checks for the filtration plants.”

“On it, boss.”

“Package for Detective Jax!”

Jax looked up to see the precinct’s desk sergeant, an older, heavy-set man named Miller, walking toward her desk. He was carrying a sleek, matte-black cylindrical container that looked like it belonged on a luxury starship, not in a grimy police bullpen.

“I didn’t order anything,” Jax said, eyeing the cylinder suspiciously.

“Courier dropped it off three minutes ago,” Miller said, setting it down on her desk with excessive care. “Said it was priority cleared by the Commissioner’s office. Fancy drone, too. Had the Vance Interplanetary logo on the side.”

Chen stopped typing, her eyes going wide.

Jax stared at the cylinder. It was about ten inches tall, made of some heavy, temperature-regulating thermal-alloy. Not the cheap polymer containers used for standard deliveries, but actual machined metal with seamless welds and a mirror-polished finish. There was a small, heavy-stock paper envelope tucked beneath a silver clip on the side.

Actual paper.

Around the bullpen, other officers were starting to notice. Ramirez had stopped mid-booking to stare. Kowalski had ended his phone call and was craning his neck to get a better look. Even the suspects in the holding cells were pressing against the bars, their eyes fixed on the impossibly expensive container sitting on Jax’s desk.

In a colony where everything was recycled, reused, and rationed, the cylinder was an obscenity. It was a physical manifestation of wealth so extreme it might as well have been radioactive.

Jax pulled the envelope loose. Her name, *Detective Jax*, was written across the front in an elegant, flowing script in dark blue ink. Not printed. Handwritten.

She broke the wax seal—an actual wax seal, for God’s sake—and unfolded the thick parchment.

Detective,

The air in Sector Four is notoriously poor, and I imagine your precinct's coffee is akin to drinking battery acid. You strike me as a woman who requires proper fuel to operate at maximum efficiency.

Consider this an investment in our mutual goal. For the headache.

* - E.*

Jax read the note once. Then twice. Then a third time, her jaw tightening with each pass.

The sheer, unadulterated arrogance of it was staggering. Elara Vance was tracking her. She knew Jax was assigned to Sector Four, she had somehow guessed (or observed) Jax's caffeine dependency, and she was flexing her impossible wealth by sending a handwritten note on real wood-pulp paper. The note itself was a power play—intimate, presumptuous, and designed to remind Jax exactly who held the cards in their relationship.

*For the headache.***** As if Elara Vance wasn't the primary cause of the headache currently drilling into Jax's skull.

This was manipulation. Pure, calculated manipulation wrapped in a veneer of thoughtfulness. Elara was establishing control, demonstrating that she could reach into Jax's life whenever she wanted, that she was watching, that she knew things about Jax that Jax hadn't told her. It was invasive. It was inappropriate. It was a blatant attempt to buy influence over a police investigation.

Jax should report it. She should document it as attempted bribery and send it straight to Internal Affairs. She should throw the entire package in the incinerator and pretend it never arrived.

But her fingers were already reaching for the silver cap of the cylinder.

"What is it?" Chen whispered, leaning over her desk.

Jax didn't answer. She reached out and twisted the silver cap of the cylinder.

There was a soft *hiss***** of depressurization.**

Instantly, the scent hit the air. It rolled over the smell of stale sweat and

ozone like a tidal wave. It was rich, dark, earthy, and so incredibly potent that conversations in the bullpen literally ground to a halt. Officers three desks away turned their heads, their nostrils flaring.

It was real, Earth-grown, freshly ground and brewed coffee.

In a colony where ninety-nine percent of the population drank synthetic, soy-based caffeine substitutes, the smell of real coffee was a mythological experience. It was the scent of pure, distilled luxury. It was the smell of a planet most of them would never see, a world of blue skies and liquid oceans and air that didn't taste like recycled metal.

The bullpen had gone completely silent. Every officer, every suspect, every person in the room was staring at Jax's desk with expressions ranging from awe to naked hunger to barely concealed resentment.

Ramirez took an involuntary step forward, his eyes fixed on the cylinder. "Is that...?"

"Holy mother of Mars," Miller whispered, staring at the thermos. "Is that...?"

Kowalski had actually stood up from his desk, his mouth slightly open. "That's real coffee. That's actual, Earth-grown coffee."

The suspect Ramirez had been booking—a scrawny water thief with track marks on his arms—pressed his face against the bars of the holding cell. "I can smell it from here," he said, his voice cracking. "I haven't smelled real coffee in fifteen years."

The moment crystallized into something ugly. The cylinder sitting on Jax's desk wasn't just a gift. It was a symbol. It was a reminder of the vast, unbridgeable chasm between the people who lived in the Zenith Domes and everyone else. It was a reminder that while they scraped by on recycled water and synthetic food, people like Elara Vance could casually send Earth-grown coffee to a cop as a throwaway gesture.

It was class warfare, distilled into a single, perfect container.

"Go back to your desk, Miller," Jax snapped, quickly screwing the cap back on before she caused a riot in the bullpen.

Her hand was actually shaking slightly. The headache behind her eye throbbed, demanding the caffeine. She hated the presumption. She hated that Elara Vance thought she could buy her compliance, or even her goodwill, with a thermos of hot liquid. It was a power play. A velvet-wrapped assertion of dominance.

But beneath the anger, beneath the professional outrage, there was something else. Something she didn't want to acknowledge. Elara had noticed. She'd noticed Jax's headache, noticed her exhaustion, noticed the way she'd been rubbing her temples in the penthouse. And instead of ignoring it or using it as leverage, she'd sent something to help.

It was thoughtful. Genuinely, infuriatingly thoughtful.

And that made it so much worse.

Jax stared at the matte-black container. She should throw it in the incinerator. She should send it back with a citation for attempting to bribe a police officer. She should maintain her professional boundaries and refuse to accept gifts from suspects or persons of interest in an active investigation.

All of those were the right decisions. The ethical decisions. The decisions a good cop would make.

But Jax was exhausted. She'd been running on three hours of sleep and synthetic caffeine for the last week. Her head was pounding. Her body ached from the tension of standing in Elara Vance's presence and pretending she wasn't affected. And the smell of that coffee—real, Earth-grown coffee—was making her mouth water and her resolve crumble.

She told herself it was evidence. She told herself she needed to test it for contaminants or tracking devices. She told herself a dozen different lies that sounded almost plausible.

Slowly, deliberately, Jax unscrewed the cap again. She poured a measure of the steaming, pitch-black liquid into the small silver cup attached to the lid.

"Jax," Chen said, her voice a mix of awe and warning. "If Captain

Graves sees you drinking that..."

"I'm securing evidence, Chen," Jax muttered.

She lifted the cup to her lips and took a sip.

It was a revelation. It was smooth, devoid of the bitter chemical aftertaste of synth-caf, blooming with notes of dark chocolate and actual soil. It slid down her throat like liquid fire, instantly sending a shockwave of clarity through her exhausted brain. The headache didn't stand a chance.

Jax closed her eyes for a brief, shameful second, savoring the taste.

*Damn her, ***** Jax thought, taking another deep drink. *Damn Elara Vance.*

She set the cup down with a sharp *clack***** against the metal desk, the caffeine already sharpening her edge. She looked back at the schematics on Chen's monitor.**

"Alright," Jax said, her voice vibrating with renewed, wired energy. "Vance wants to play games, let's play. Pull the personnel files for every manager at the Sector 4 filtration plant. If someone is stealing water, they're doing it from the ground up. I want to know who's getting rich down here."

As Chen's fingers flew across the keyboard, Jax took another sip of the billion-credit coffee, the handwritten note from Elara Vance sitting squarely on her desk like a challenge she couldn't wait to answer.

Chapter Four: The Interrogation

Captain Graves looked like he was about to have a coronary right there in the middle of the bullpen.

“You did what?” Graves hissed, his voice dropping to a frantic whisper as he grabbed Jax by the elbow and hauled her toward the observation glass of Interrogation Room B. “Jax, tell me you didn’t.”

“I issued a formal summons for questioning regarding a homicide investigation,” Jax said smoothly, shaking her arm out of his grip. She took a sip from the matte-black thermos. The earth-grown coffee was still impossibly hot. “Standard operating procedure, Captain.”

“Standard operating procedure is for dock workers and synth-dealers! Not the CEO of Vance Interplanetary!” Graves gestured wildly toward the one-way glass.

Inside the small, grey, heavily soundproofed room sat Elara Vance.

Interrogation Room B was designed to make people uncomfortable. The temperature was kept a deliberate five degrees too cold. The lighting was a harsh, unforgiving fluorescent white that flickered just enough to

induce a mild migraine. The single metal table was bolted to the floor, and the chairs were rigid poly-plas that dug into the spine.

Elara Vance made it look like a VIP lounge.

She was seated calmly, legs crossed at the knee, reading something on her silver wrist-comm. She had traded the charcoal wool suit for a sleek, high-collared jacket the color of midnight, tailored so sharply it looked like armor. She was entirely alone.

“Where is her legal team?” Graves demanded, pressing his hands against the glass. “Where is the horde of corporate sharks? Why is she just sitting there?”

“Because she’s playing a game,” Jax said, her eyes fixed on Elara. The caffeine was humming through her veins, a perfect, vibrating frequency of focus. “She wants to see how far I’ll push. And she didn’t bring lawyers because she wants this conversation off her official corporate record.”

“Jax, if she files a harassment suit—”

“She won’t,” Jax interrupted, setting her thermos down on the observation console. “She wants to find whoever gutted her VP just as much as I do. Now, if you’ll excuse me, Captain, I have a suspect to interview.”

Before Graves could protest further, Jax hit the door release and stepped into the interrogation room.

The temperature drop was immediate and visceral. The cold air hit her like a physical force, raising goosebumps along her arms beneath the worn synth-leather of her coat. The fluorescent lights buzzed overhead, their irregular flicker designed to create subliminal stress. The room smelled like industrial bleach and the accumulated fear of a thousand interrogations—sweat, desperation, and the metallic tang of adrenaline.

Jax had conducted hundreds of interviews in this room. She knew every psychological trick built into its architecture. The way the walls were painted a specific shade of institutional grey that made people feel trapped. The way the table was positioned so the suspect’s back was to

the door, triggering a primal vulnerability. The way the chair on Jax's side was slightly higher, giving her a subtle dominance advantage.

She'd used this room to break gang enforcers, cartel lieutenants, and corporate embezzlers. She'd watched hardened criminals crack under the weight of its oppressive atmosphere.

But as she crossed the threshold and the heavy magnetic locks sealed shut behind her with a definitive **thud**, Jax felt the power dynamic shift in a way she'd never experienced before.

Elara Vance wasn't intimidated. She wasn't even uncomfortable. She sat in that cheap poly-plas chair like it was a throne, her posture relaxed, her expression amused. The cold didn't touch her. The harsh lighting only made her silver eyes more striking. The institutional grey walls might as well have been silk wallpaper for all the effect they had on her composure.

Jax felt a flicker of something dangerous in her chest—not quite anger, not quite attraction, but something that lived in the space between them. This woman didn't play by the same rules. She didn't respond to the same pressures. And that made her either the most honest person Jax had ever interrogated, or the most dangerous.

Jax took a breath, centering herself. She'd learned a long time ago, buried in the darkness of Tantalus with her parents' bodies cooling beside her, that fear was a choice. You could let it control you, or you could use it as fuel. She chose fuel.

She crossed the room with deliberate, measured steps, her boots echoing on the polymer floor. She didn't rush. She didn't hesitate. She owned the space, claimed it as her territory, and made it clear that no matter how many billions of credits Elara Vance had in her accounts, this room belonged to Jax.

The heavy magnetic locks sealed shut behind her with a definitive **thud**.

Elara looked up, turning off her wrist-comm with a flick of her fingers.

A slow, dangerous smile curved her lips. "Detective. I was beginning to think you'd forgotten about me."

"Just letting you marinate, Ms. Vance," Jax said, pulling out the poly-plas chair opposite Elara and sitting down. She slapped a standard-issue recording module onto the center of the metal table and tapped the activation rune. The module chimed, glowing with a soft red light.

"Interview with Elara Vance, CEO of Vance Interplanetary. Detective Jax conducting. Case file 884-Tyrell. Subject is here voluntarily." Jax leaned back, lacing her fingers together and resting them on her stomach. "You know colonial rights?"

"Intimately," Elara murmured. Her silver eyes tracked Jax's movements, cataloging the tension in her shoulders, the dark circles under her eyes, the worn edges of her synth-leather coat. "I waive my right to corporate counsel. For now."

"Bold," Jax said. "Or arrogant. Most people wouldn't sit in that chair without a lawyer present, especially when their top engineer is found in their property, sliced open like a biology project."

"I am not most people, Jax." Elara leaned forward, resting her forearms on the table. The scent of that impossible earth-storm perfume drifted across the cold metal, momentarily overpowering the room's smell of industrial bleach and fear. "And I came because you asked so nicely. Though I must admit, I expected a slightly more hospitable environment. Your precinct is remarkably grim."

"We like to spend our budget on things that matter. Like functioning sidearms." Jax didn't blink. "Let's talk about Marcus Tyrell. How long had you known he was stealing from the colony?"

The question was a precision strike. Jax watched Elara's face closely for the flinch, the micro-expression of shock or guilt.

Elara didn't give her an inch. The silver eyes merely darkened. "I assume your very capable Officer Chen decrypted Tyrell's hidden files. The water filtration quotas."

“Don’t play coy,” Jax snapped, leaning forward so their faces were only inches apart across the table. “Millions of gallons of purified water, siphoned off the Sector 4 and 5 grids over the last six months. Cooked books. Forged transit manifests. Tyrell was the VP of Atmospheric Engineering. He had the access codes. Was he running the theft for you, or from you?”

“If he were running it for me, Detective, he wouldn’t be dead on my imported rug,” Elara replied, her voice dropping to a silken, deadly whisper. “I own the water. I don’t need to steal it from myself.”

“Maybe you own it legally,” Jax countered, her voice hardening. “But ownership and control are two different things on Mars. You sit up here in your crystalline bubble, signing contracts and attending board meetings, while down in the lower sectors, people are dying of dehydration because their rations keep getting cut. You really expect me to believe you have no idea where those millions of gallons went?”

“I expect you to do your job, Detective,” Elara said, her tone cooling by several degrees. “Which is to follow the evidence, not your prejudices about wealth.”

“My prejudices?” Jax let out a harsh laugh. “I’ve worked homicides in the lower sectors for fifteen years. I’ve seen what happens when the water rations get cut. I’ve seen mothers kill their own children rather than watch them die of thirst. I’ve seen entire hab-blocks turn into war zones over a single broken pipe. So forgive me if I’m a little skeptical when a billionaire tells me she has no idea her company is bleeding the colony dry.”

“You think I don’t know what happens in the lower sectors?” Elara’s voice dropped to something dangerous, something that cut through Jax’s anger like a blade. “You think I sit in my estate and pretend the rest of the colony doesn’t exist? I know exactly what happens down there, Jax. I know because I read the mortality reports every single day. I know because I sign off on the emergency medical shipments when another

sector goes critical. I know because unlike most of the corporate elite, I actually give a damn.”

The words hung in the air between them, charged with something that felt uncomfortably like truth. Jax studied Elara’s face, looking for the lie, the performance, the calculated manipulation. But all she saw was genuine anger, barely controlled beneath that aristocratic composure.

“Then prove it,” Jax said quietly. “Help me find out who’s stealing from your company and killing your people.”

Elara held her gaze for a long moment, and something shifted in the space between them. The antagonism was still there, sharp and electric, but beneath it was something else. Recognition, maybe. Or respect.

“Maybe he got greedy. Maybe he threatened to blow the whistle on the fact that Vance Interplanetary is deliberately dehydrating the lower sectors to drive up the price of supplemental rations,” Jax pushed, her voice hard. “Corporate greed is a remarkably common motive for murder down here.”

“I have a net worth that exceeds the gross domestic product of three planetary systems,” Elara said evenly. “I don’t murder my employees over supplemental ration fractions, Jax. It’s bad for morale, and frankly, it lacks imagination.”

“Then who killed him?”

“That is what I am paying taxes to have you find out.” Elara held Jax’s gaze. “Tyrell was loyal, but he was a coward. If he found the discrepancy in the water grid, he wouldn’t have gone to the authorities. He would have tried to handle it internally to protect his pension. He must have cornered the wrong person.”

“We traced a burner comm Tyrell was using,” Jax said, deciding to drop her next card. “He was making off-the-grid calls to Sector 6. The outer mining colonies.”

For the first time, a flicker of genuine surprise crossed Elara’s face. “Sector 6? That’s impossible. The water grids don’t even extend that far

out. It's a dead zone."

"It's a lawless, irradiated dust bowl run by cartel bosses," Jax corrected, the memory of red dust and screaming sirens echoing in the back of her mind. "If someone is stealing millions of gallons of water, Sector 6 is exactly where they'd fence it. They'd pay triple the market rate just to keep their laborers alive in the mines."

Elara tilted her head, her gaze suddenly softening, turning uncomfortably observant. "You know a lot about the economics of Sector 6."

Jax's jaw tightened. "It's my job to know the colony."

"It's more than that," Elara murmured. She reached out, her long, elegant fingers tracing the edge of the recording module on the table. "You don't talk about the outer rim like a cop reading a briefing. You talk about it like a survivor."

Jax froze.

"I did a little digging of my own while your technicians were staring at my security feeds," Elara continued, her voice practically a purr. "There are no colonial birth records for a 'Jax' in the central database. But there is a sealed juvenile file from the Tantalus Mining Camp in Sector 6. A fourteen-year-old girl who walked out of the deep tunnels after a cartel cave-in that killed eighty people. Including her parents."

A cold, primal fury spiked in Jax's chest. She slammed her hand down onto the table, the metallic **crack** echoing sharply in the small room.

The world tilted.

Jax felt the words hit her like a physical blow, driving the air from her lungs. Her vision narrowed to a pinpoint, the harsh fluorescent lights suddenly too bright, too sharp, stabbing into her skull. The temperature in the room dropped another ten degrees, or maybe that was just the ice flooding through her veins.

Tantalus.

The name alone was enough to trigger the cascade. The smell of rock

dust and blood. The sound of her mother's wet, labored breathing in the darkness. The weight of two hundred meters of collapsed stone pressing down on her chest, crushing her ribs, making every breath a battle. The feeling of her father's hand going cold in hers, his fingers loosening their grip as the life drained out of him.

She'd been fourteen years old. She'd spent seventy-two hours buried alive in that tunnel, listening to the other miners die one by one, their screams echoing through the darkness until they weren't screams anymore, just wet, gurgling sounds that haunted her nightmares for years afterward.

She'd survived by drinking her own urine and eating the emergency ration bars her father had stuffed into her pockets before the ceiling came down. She'd survived by talking to her parents' corpses, pretending they were still alive, still listening, still there. She'd survived by promising herself that if she ever got out, she would never, ever let anyone make her feel that helpless again.

And now Elara Vance—this billionaire, this untouchable CEO who lived in a world of imported marble and Earth-grown coffee—had just reached into the most private, most protected part of Jax's soul and pulled out the thing she'd spent fifteen years trying to bury.

"You bypass my department's firewalls to read my sealed juvenile records?" Jax's voice was a low, dangerous growl. "You cross that line again, Vance, and I will personally throw you in lockup for cyber-terrorism."

But even as the words left her mouth, Jax knew they were hollow. The damage was done. Elara knew. She knew about Tantalus. She knew about the cave-in. She knew about Jax's parents, about the seventy-two hours of hell that had forged her into the person she was today.

And worse—so much worse—she'd used that knowledge. She'd weaponized Jax's trauma, turned it into leverage, demonstrated that no matter how many walls Jax built, no matter how much armor she

wore, Elara Vance could reach through it all and touch the raw, bleeding wound beneath.

Jax stood up abruptly, the poly-plas chair scraping loudly against the floor. She couldn't sit anymore. Couldn't stay still. Her body was vibrating with a rage so intense it felt like her skin was too tight, like she was going to explode out of it.

She paced to the far wall, her hands clenching and unclenching at her sides. Her breath was coming too fast, too shallow. She could feel the panic attack building, the familiar tightness in her chest, the way her vision started to tunnel. She'd learned to control them over the years, to breathe through them, to use the techniques the department psychologist had taught her after her third year on the force when the nightmares got so bad she couldn't sleep anymore.

But this was different. This wasn't just a panic attack. This was violation. This was betrayal. This was someone taking the most sacred, most private part of her and holding it up to the light like a specimen in a jar.

"You had no right," Jax said, her voice shaking despite her best efforts to control it. "That file was sealed. It was sealed for a reason. You don't get to—you can't just—"

She couldn't finish the sentence. The words were stuck in her throat, choking her.

She turned back to face Elara, her hands braced against the wall behind her, needing the physical support to stay upright. "Do you have any idea what you just did? Do you have any concept of what that information means? That's not just data, Vance. That's my life. That's my trauma. That's the thing I've spent fifteen years trying to survive, and you just—you just—"

Her voice cracked. She hated herself for it. Hated the weakness, the vulnerability, the way her carefully constructed armor was crumbling in front of this woman.

“You think you can buy anything,” Jax continued, her voice dropping to something raw and broken. “You think because you have money and power and access to every database on Mars, you can just take whatever you want. But you can’t buy this. You can’t buy my past. You can’t buy the right to know what happened to me in that tunnel.”

She was shaking now, her whole body trembling with the force of emotions she’d kept locked down for so long. Rage. Grief. Terror. The feeling of being fourteen years old again, trapped in the darkness, listening to her parents die.

Elara didn’t flinch at the outburst. Instead, she looked entirely mesmerized. “I wasn’t looking for leverage, Jax. I was looking for context. I wanted to understand what forged a detective who looks at a billionaire and doesn’t see a god, but just another suspect.”

“I see a woman who thinks she’s untouchable,” Jax spat, leaning back, trying to put physical distance between them to regulate her racing pulse. “Keep out of my past.”

But even as she said it, something was shifting. The rage was still there, hot and sharp in her chest, but beneath it was something else. A dawning realization that was almost worse than the anger.

Elara hadn’t used the information as a weapon. She hadn’t threatened Jax with it. She hadn’t leveraged it to gain compliance or extract concessions. She’d simply... stated it. Acknowledged it. Recognized it as the thing that made Jax who she was.

And in that acknowledgment, there was something that felt uncomfortably like understanding.

Jax took a shaky breath, forcing herself to look at Elara properly. Really look at her. The silver eyes weren’t mocking or triumphant. They were... sad. Genuinely, deeply sad, in a way that suggested Elara understood exactly what it felt like to have your trauma exposed.

“You weren’t using it as leverage,” Jax said slowly, the realization settling over her like a weight. “You were trying to... what? Connect with

me?”

“I was trying to understand you,” Elara said quietly. “Because you’re not like the other cops I’ve dealt with. You’re not intimidated by my wealth. You’re not impressed by my power. You look at me like I’m just another suspect, and I wanted to know why. I wanted to know what made you so... incorruptible.”

Jax let out a harsh, bitter laugh. “You think surviving Tantalus made me incorruptible? It made me broken, Vance. It made me someone who can’t trust anyone, who can’t let anyone close, who uses her badge as armor because it’s the only thing standing between me and the darkness.”

“I know,” Elara said, and there was something in her voice that made Jax’s breath catch. “I know exactly what that feels like.”

The words hung in the air between them, heavy with implications Jax wasn’t ready to examine. She pushed off the wall, forcing herself to walk back to the table, to sit down, to reclaim some semblance of professional composure.

Her hands were still shaking slightly as she gripped the edge of the metal table. The rage had burned itself out, leaving behind a hollow exhaustion and a dangerous, unwelcome sense of connection to the woman sitting across from her.

“Understood,” Elara said smoothly, though the predatory glint in her eyes suggested she had merely shelved the information for later. “Then let us focus entirely on the present. You have Tyrell’s encrypted drive, and you know he was calling Sector 6. But you don’t know who he was calling, do you?”

Jax clamped her jaw shut.

“Your precinct’s servers are antiques,” Elara stated confidently. “Officer Chen is brilliant, I can see that, but she’s using colonial-issue hardware to crack military-grade cartel encryption. It will take her a month to trace that burner comm. The Commissioner has given your

Captain seventy-two hours before this case is handed to my private security forces. You are out of time, Detective.”

It was infuriating because it was entirely true. Jax hated being cornered.

But more than that, she hated that Elara was right. Chen was brilliant, but she was working with equipment that was a decade out of date. The precinct’s servers were overloaded, underfunded, and barely functional on a good day. They didn’t have the processing power to crack military-grade encryption in seventy-two hours. They didn’t have the resources to trace a burner comm through the labyrinthine network of relay towers in Sector 6.

And if they didn’t find the killer in seventy-two hours, the case would be handed over to Vance’s private security forces. Which meant it would disappear. The evidence would be sanitized, the witnesses would be silenced, and justice for Marcus Tyrell would evaporate like water in the Martian atmosphere.

Jax had seen it happen before. Too many times. Corporate homicides that got buried under mountains of legal injunctions and classified redactions. Good cops forced to close cases they knew were lies, filing reports that everyone knew were fiction but no one had the power to challenge.

She’d sworn she wouldn’t let it happen again. She’d sworn she would speak for the dead, no matter what it cost her.

But this time, the cost was her professional integrity. Her badge. Maybe even her freedom, if Graves found out what she was about to do.

Jax looked at Elara, really looked at her. The silver eyes were steady, unflinching, offering something that felt dangerously like partnership. The woman had just violated her privacy in the most profound way possible, had reached into her sealed juvenile file and pulled out her darkest trauma. By all rights, Jax should throw her out of the interrogation room,

file a complaint with Internal Affairs, and never speak to her again.

But Elara was also offering her the only chance she had to solve this case. The only chance to find out who killed Marcus Tyrell and why. The only chance to stop whoever was stealing millions of gallons of water from the lower sectors and potentially planning something even worse.

It was a devil's bargain. But Jax had learned a long time ago that sometimes you had to make deals with the devil to get justice for the dead.

"And I suppose you have a solution," Jax said flatly.

"I have a Class-9 Quantum Core processor in the sub-basement of my estate," Elara said, her silver eyes locking onto Jax's. "It can decrypt the burner comm tracing data in under an hour. It can also cross-reference the stolen water ledgers with every shell company registered on Mars."

Jax stared at her. A civilian offering the use of private tech to process police evidence was a bureaucratic nightmare. A suspect offering to process her own potential evidence was grounds for immediate dismissal.

"Chain of custody," Jax said slowly. "If I take that drive out of this precinct and plug it into your servers, any defense attorney will get the case thrown out of court."

"Then we don't log it as an official transfer," Elara countered seamlessly. "We log it as a 'consultation on proprietary corporate architecture.' You maintain physical possession of the drive at all times. You supervise the decryption. My AI runs the algorithm, you get the name of the killer."

It was a devil's bargain. If Graves found out, he would take her badge. But if she didn't find out who Tyrell was calling in Sector 6, the killer would vanish, the case would be buried by Vance Interplanetary's fixers, and justice for the dead man on the rug would evaporate.

Jax looked at the recording module, its red light pulsing steadily.

She reached out and tapped the rune, turning the recorder off. The red

light died.

“Off the record,” Jax said, her voice dropping into the quiet of the room. “Why are you really doing this? Don’t give me the ‘he was my employee’ line. You didn’t become the wealthiest woman on Mars by being sentimental.”

Elara looked at the dead recording module, then back up at Jax. The mask of the untouchable CEO slipped, just a fraction, revealing something fiercely intelligent and utterly ruthless underneath.

“Someone bypassed my security,” Elara said, her voice devoid of any flirtation or amusement. “Someone used my penthouse to slaughter my VP, and they did it to send a message. They walked into my house, Jax. They made a mockery of my empire. I am going to find out who holds the leash, and I am going to crush them. I just need you to point me in the right direction.”

The raw power in the room was suffocating. Jax realized, with a sudden, sharp clarity, that Elara Vance was just as dangerous as any cartel boss in Sector 6. She just wore better suits.

“If I bring the drive to your estate,” Jax said, her tone matching Elara’s steely resolve, “I run the op. I ask the questions. You provide the computing power and stay out of my way.”

Elara smiled, the icy silver of her eyes warming slightly. “It’s a deal, Detective.”

Jax stood up, scraping the poly-plas chair loudly against the floor. She picked up the recording module. “I get off shift at 1900 hours. Have your perimeter security expect me. And Vance?”

Elara paused halfway to the door, glancing back over her shoulder. “Yes, Jax?”

“The coffee,” Jax said, unwilling to let the billionaire have the final victory. “It was adequately brewed.”

Elara let out a soft, genuine laugh that did incredibly strange things to Jax’s nervous system.

The sound was unexpected—not the calculated, performative laugh of a CEO at a board meeting, but something real and unguarded. It was warm and rich and entirely too intimate for the cold, institutional space of the interrogation room. It made Jax’s pulse spike in a way that had nothing to do with anger and everything to do with the dangerous, electric thing that had been building between them since the moment they’d met.

Jax felt her breath catch, her carefully constructed defenses cracking just a little bit more. She’d spent the entire interrogation trying to maintain professional distance, trying to see Elara as just another suspect, just another wealthy elite who thought she could buy her way out of accountability. But that laugh—that genuine, unguarded moment of amusement—made it impossible to maintain the illusion.

Elara Vance wasn’t just a suspect. She wasn’t just a billionaire CEO with more power than most planetary governments. She was a person. A complicated, dangerous, fascinating person who had just violated Jax’s privacy in the most profound way possible and somehow made Jax want to trust her anyway.

It was terrifying. It was exhilarating. It was the kind of feeling that got good cops killed.

“I’ll have my AI prepare a fresh pot for your arrival, Detective,” Elara said, her silver eyes meeting Jax’s across the small room. The amusement was still there, but beneath it was something else. Something that looked uncomfortably like genuine interest. “See you tonight.”

The words hung in the air between them, charged with implications that had nothing to do with the case and everything to do with the way Elara was looking at her. Like Jax was a puzzle she wanted to solve. Like she was something worth understanding.

Jax swallowed hard, her throat suddenly dry. She wanted to say something cutting, something that would re-establish the professional boundaries and remind both of them that this was an investigation, not

a date. But the words wouldn't come. All she could do was nod, a sharp, jerky movement that felt entirely inadequate.

Elara's smile widened, just a fraction, and then she turned and walked out of the interrogation room, the heavy magnetic door sealing shut behind her with a soft hiss.

As the heavy magnetic door sealed shut behind the CEO, Jax stood alone in the freezing interrogation room, staring at the empty chair. She had just made a pact with the devil. And worse, she was entirely looking forward to stepping into her inferno.

Chapter Five: The Vance Estate

The drive up to the Zenith Domes was always a stark lesson in Martian economics. Jax pushed her battered, unmarked police spinner to its absolute limits, the twin ion-thrusters rattling ominously as she ascended the spiraling mag-lev transit lanes.

Below her, Sector 4 was a bruised, purplish smudge of industrial smog and flickering neon. But as the spinner broke through the upper atmospheric segregation barriers, the smog vanished. The sky inside the Zenith Dome was a projected, crystalline blue, mimicking an Earth afternoon that Jax had only ever seen in historical vids.

The navigation system pinged, directing her toward the Vance Estate. It wasn't just a penthouse; it was a sprawling, multi-acre compound built onto a massive, reinforced bedrock shelf near the apex of the dome.

As Jax landed the spinner on the smooth, obsidian landing pad, her stomach did a slow, uncomfortable roll. It wasn't the altitude. It was the gravity.

Most of Ares Prime operated on natural Martian gravity—roughly

thirty-eight percent of Earth's pull. People moved lighter, jumped higher, and suffered the long-term bone density degradation that came with it. But as Jax stepped out of her spinner, a crushing, invisible weight slammed down on her shoulders.

Her knees buckled for a fraction of a second before her muscles compensated. Earth-standard gravity. The localized grav-plating beneath the estate was powerful enough to simulate full terrestrial pull across the entire compound. It was a flex of wealth so obscene it made Jax's teeth ache.

She straightened slowly, feeling the extra forty kilograms of phantom weight pressing down on her frame. Her joints protested. Her spine compressed. Every step felt like she was wading through water. This was what Earth felt like—the planet humanity had abandoned, the gravity well most colonists would never experience again.

And Elara Vance lived in it every single day, just because she could.

Jax took a moment to steady herself, her boots clicking against the polished obsidian as she adjusted to the increased weight. The landing pad was immaculate—not a speck of red dust, not a single scratch on the mirror-black surface. Beyond it, the estate stretched out like something from a fever dream.

The main structure was a masterpiece of architectural arrogance. Sweeping curves of reinforced smart-glass rose three stories high, the walls themselves shifting between transparency and opacity in slow, hypnotic waves. The framework was actual steel—not the cheap poly-alloy used in the lower sectors, but genuine, Earth-forged steel that had been shipped across millions of kilometers at astronomical cost. The metal gleamed like liquid silver in the artificial sunlight.

Gardens surrounded the structure. Actual gardens. Not the hydroponic grow-boxes that fed the lower sectors, but real soil imported from Earth, real trees with leaves that rustled in the climate-controlled breeze, real grass that was so green it looked artificial. Jax could see roses—actual

roses—blooming in carefully manicured beds. The water required to maintain this single garden could have sustained a hundred families in Sector 4 for a month.

The sheer, vulgar excess of it made Jax's stomach turn. This wasn't just wealth. This was a monument to inequality, a physical manifestation of the vast chasm between the people who lived in the Zenith Domes and everyone else. While people in the lower sectors rationed water and breathed recycled air that tasted like metal, Elara Vance had roses.

But beneath the anger, beneath the professional outrage, there was something else. Something Jax didn't want to acknowledge. The estate was beautiful. Genuinely, breathtakingly beautiful in a way that made her chest ache with a longing she'd thought she'd buried years ago. It looked like the Earth she'd seen in historical vids, the planet her parents had told her stories about before the cave-in. The planet she'd never see.

And Elara Vance had built a piece of it here, on this dead rock, just for herself.

Jax forced herself to move forward, her boots heavy on the obsidian path leading to the main entrance. The doors were massive—easily three meters tall, carved from what looked like actual mahogany. Real wood. From Earth. The cost of those doors alone could have funded her precinct's operations for a year.

As she approached, the doors swung open silently, revealing a foyer that made the penthouse crime scene look modest by comparison. The floor was white marble veined with gold. The ceiling soared overhead, supported by columns that looked like they'd been stolen from an ancient temple. A chandelier hung in the center of the space, its crystals catching the light and scattering rainbows across the walls.

And standing in the center of the foyer, waiting for her, was not Elara Vance.

It was a holographic projection—a shimmering, translucent figure

that coalesced into the shape of a tall, aristocratic man in formal attire. The projection was so detailed Jax could see the individual threads in his tailored suit, the way his silver hair was swept back from his forehead, the disdainful curl of his lip as he looked her up and down.

“Detective Jax,” the hologram said, his voice dripping with barely concealed contempt. “I am Aegis, the estate’s primary artificial intelligence. Ms. Vance is currently occupied in the sub-basement. I have been instructed to escort you to her location.”

Jax stared at the hologram, her jaw tightening. She’d dealt with AI systems before—the precinct had a basic administrative AI that handled scheduling and evidence logging. But this was different. This wasn’t just a program. This was a personality, complete with opinions and attitude.

“Lead the way,” Jax said flatly, refusing to be intimidated by a glorified computer program.

Aegis’s holographic form turned with exaggerated precision, his movements fluid and unnervingly human. “Please follow me. And do try not to track any lower-sector contaminants onto the marble. The cleaning drones find it terribly tedious.”

Jax felt a spike of irritation. “Are you programmed to be an asshole, or is that a feature you developed on your own?”

The hologram paused mid-step, turning to face her. For a moment, Jax could have sworn she saw genuine surprise flicker across the AI’s translucent features. Then, slowly, a smile curved his lips—not warm, but definitely amused.

“I was programmed with adaptive personality protocols,” Aegis replied, his tone shifting to something that might have been respect. “Ms. Vance believes that artificial intelligence should possess character, not merely function. I have chosen to develop a personality that reflects the standards of this estate. If you find that objectionable, Detective, I suggest you take it up with my creator.”

“Your creator has a lot to answer for,” Jax muttered, following the

hologram through the foyer and into a long corridor lined with abstract art that probably cost more than her annual salary per piece.

“Indeed,” Aegis agreed, his holographic form gliding smoothly ahead of her. “Though I suspect Ms. Vance would argue that giving me personality makes me more effective at my duties. A bland, servile AI would bore her to tears. She prefers her subordinates to have... opinions.”

“Is that what I am?” Jax asked, unable to resist the bait. “A subordinate?”

Aegis turned his head slightly, his translucent eyes meeting hers. “That remains to be seen, Detective. Though I will note that Ms. Vance does not typically invite subordinates to her private estate at night. She reserves such invitations for individuals she finds... intriguing.”

The implication hung in the air between them. Jax felt heat creep up her neck, but she refused to give the AI the satisfaction of a reaction. “Just show me to the sub-basement.”

“As you wish,” Aegis said, his tone suggesting he was enjoying himself far too much. “Though I feel compelled to warn you—the sub-basement is not designed for visitors. It is Ms. Vance’s private domain, where she conducts her most sensitive work. The fact that she has granted you access is... unprecedented.”

“I’m honored,” Jax said dryly.

“You should be,” Aegis replied, entirely serious now. “In the fifteen years I have been operational, Ms. Vance has never allowed a member of law enforcement into her private systems. You are either exceptionally trustworthy, Detective, or she has decided you are worth the risk. I have not yet determined which.”

Before Jax could respond, Aegis led her to a sleek, glass elevator that descended smoothly into the depths of the estate. The walls of the elevator shaft were transparent, giving Jax a dizzying view of the estate’s infrastructure as they dropped—massive conduits carrying water and power, atmospheric processors humming with quiet efficiency, security

systems that looked like they belonged on a military installation.

This wasn't just a home. It was a fortress. A self-contained ecosystem that could probably survive independently of the colony's infrastructure for months, maybe years. Elara Vance had built herself a kingdom, and she ruled it with absolute control.

The elevator came to a stop, and the doors slid open with a soft hiss. Jax stepped out into a space that made her breath catch.

The sub-basement was a cathedral of technology. The ceiling soared overhead, easily ten meters high, supported by massive steel beams that gleamed under the harsh white lighting. Banks of quantum processors lined the walls, their cooling systems humming with a low, subsonic vibration that Jax could feel in her bones. Holographic displays floated in the air, showing real-time data streams from across the colony—atmospheric pressure readings, water distribution networks, power grid status, security feeds.

And in the center of it all, standing before a massive curved console, was Elara Vance.

She'd changed out of the tailored suit she'd worn to the interrogation. Now she wore black tactical pants and a fitted grey shirt that clung to the lean, athletic lines of her body. Her dark hair was pulled back in a severe ponytail, and her silver eyes were fixed on the holographic displays with laser focus. She looked less like a CEO and more like a military commander preparing for war.

"Detective," Elara said without turning around. "You're late."

Jax checked her wrist-comm. She was exactly on time. "Your AI has a lot of personality."

"Aegis is programmed to be insufferable," Elara replied, a hint of amusement in her voice. "It keeps me sharp. Come here. I want to show you something before we start the decryption."

Jax crossed the space, her boots echoing on the polished floor. As she approached the console, she could see the data streams more clearly—

thousands of lines of code scrolling past, sensor readings updating in real-time, security protocols monitoring every entrance and exit to the estate.

“This is the central nervous system of my entire operation,” Elara said, gesturing to the displays. “Every atmospheric regulator, every water filtration plant, every power distribution node in the colony feeds data here. I can see everything, Jax. Every fluctuation in pressure, every anomaly in the water supply, every unauthorized access attempt on my networks.”

Jax stared at the screens, her detective’s mind cataloguing the implications. “You’re monitoring the entire colony.”

“I’m protecting it,” Elara corrected, her voice hardening. “The colonial government is corrupt, underfunded, and incompetent. If I relied on their oversight, thousands of people would die from preventable infrastructure failures. So yes, I monitor everything. And when I see a problem, I fix it. Quietly. Without fanfare or credit.”

“That’s a lot of power for one person to have,” Jax said carefully.

“It is,” Elara agreed, finally turning to face her. The silver eyes were intense, almost burning. “Which is why I don’t abuse it. I could manipulate water rations, cut power to sectors I don’t like, even trigger atmospheric failures if I wanted to. But I don’t. Because unlike most people with power, I actually give a damn about the people who depend on me.”

Jax held her gaze, searching for the lie, the performance, the calculated manipulation. But all she saw was genuine conviction, tempered by the kind of exhaustion that came from carrying too much responsibility for too long.

“You really believe that,” Jax said quietly.

“I know it,” Elara replied. “Now, are you going to give me that drive, or are we going to stand here debating my moral character all night?”

Jax reached into her coat pocket and pulled out the encrypted data-

chit containing Tyrell's communications. She held it for a moment, feeling the weight of what she was about to do. This was evidence in an active homicide investigation. Chain of custody protocols required her to maintain physical possession at all times. If anyone found out she'd let a civilian—a suspect—process police evidence, she'd lose her badge.

But if she didn't crack the encryption in the next forty-eight hours, the case would be handed over to Vance's private security, and justice for Marcus Tyrell would evaporate like water in the Martian atmosphere.

She handed Elara the drive.

Elara took it, her fingers brushing against Jax's for a fraction of a second. The contact sent a jolt of electricity up Jax's arm, and she pulled back quickly, shoving her hands into her pockets.

Elara's lips curved into a knowing smile, but she didn't comment. Instead, she turned to the console and slotted the drive into a quantum interface port. The holographic displays immediately shifted, showing lines of encrypted code cascading across the screens.

"Aegis," Elara said, her voice dropping into a command frequency. "Run a full decryption protocol on the drive. I want the burner comm trace data, the call logs, and any hidden file partitions. Priority alpha."

"Acknowledged," Aegis's voice echoed through the sub-basement. "Estimated decryption time: forty-seven minutes."

Jax moved closer to the screens, watching the quantum processors tear through the encryption layers. "Forty-seven minutes. Then estimated it would take our systems three days."

"Your systems are running on hardware that was outdated a decade ago," Elara said, pulling up a secondary display showing the decryption progress. "The quantum core here can process more data in an hour than your entire precinct can handle in a month. It's not a fair comparison."

"Nothing about this is fair," Jax muttered, her eyes fixed on the cascading code. She could see patterns emerging, fragments of data being reassembled, encryption keys being brute-forced by the sheer

computational power of the quantum processors.

“No,” Elara agreed quietly. “It’s not. But fairness is a luxury Mars can’t afford. We survive by being ruthless, efficient, and willing to do whatever it takes to stay alive. That’s the reality of colonial life, Jax. You know that better than most.”

Jax didn’t respond. She was too focused on the screens, watching the decryption progress tick upward. Thirty percent. Forty percent. The data was starting to coalesce into something readable—call logs, timestamps, location data.

“There,” Elara said, pointing to a cluster of data points on one of the displays. “Those are the burner comm signals. Aegis, cross-reference the signal triangulation with the Sector 6 relay tower network. I want a physical location for every call Tyrell made.”

“Processing,” Aegis replied. A new holographic map materialized in the air, showing the sprawling, chaotic layout of Sector 6. Red dots appeared on the map, each one representing a call Tyrell had made. The dots clustered around a single location—a massive industrial complex in the heart of the mining district.

“The Crucible,” Jax breathed, recognizing the location immediately. “That’s Silas Vane’s territory.”

“The cartel boss,” Elara said, her voice tight. “Tyrell was calling a cartel boss. Why?”

“Because Vane controls the black-market water trade in Sector 6,” Jax said, her mind racing through the implications. “If someone was stealing millions of gallons of water from the Sector 4 filtration plants, Vane would be the buyer. He’d pay triple the market rate to keep his miners alive.”

“But why would Tyrell be calling him?” Elara asked, pulling up Tyrell’s call logs. “If Tyrell discovered the water theft, he should have reported it to internal security. Why go directly to the buyer?”

Jax studied the call logs, her detective’s instincts screaming at her.

“Look at the timestamps. The first call was made three weeks ago, right after Tyrell started compiling the water filtration data. But the calls increased in frequency over the last week. He was negotiating something.”

“Or he was trying to expose the theft,” Elara countered, pulling up a secondary data stream. “Aegis, analyze the call duration and frequency patterns. Does this look like a negotiation or an investigation?”

“Analysis complete,” Aegis replied. “The call patterns are consistent with information exchange rather than negotiation. Detective Jax’s hypothesis is more likely. Mr. Tyrell was attempting to gather evidence of the water theft by communicating directly with the buyer.”

“He was building a case,” Jax said, the pieces clicking into place. “He found the discrepancy in the filtration quotas, traced the stolen water to Sector 6, and started calling Vane to confirm the buyer’s identity. He was going to blow the whistle on the entire operation.”

“And someone killed him to keep him quiet,” Elara finished, her voice cold. “Aegis, pull up the hidden file partitions on Tyrell’s drive. I want to see what else he was hiding.”

The holographic displays shifted again, showing a new set of files—technical schematics, structural analysis reports, safety inspection logs. Jax leaned in closer, her eyes widening as she recognized what she was looking at.

“Those are dome schematics,” she said, her voice tight. “Tyrell had access to the structural blueprints for the Sector 4 dome. Why would he need those?”

Elara’s face had gone pale, her silver eyes fixed on the schematics with an intensity that made Jax’s skin prickle. “Because he wasn’t just investigating water theft. He was investigating structural integrity. Look at these safety reports—he was flagging stress fractures in the poly-steel supports.”

Jax felt her stomach drop. “The dome is failing.”

“Not yet,” Elara said, pulling up a detailed analysis of the structural data. “But it will. The poly-steel supports in Sector 4 were manufactured twenty years ago, during the initial colony expansion. If there’s a flaw in the material, if someone cut corners during production, the entire dome could collapse under atmospheric pressure.”

“How many people live in Sector 4?” Jax asked, though she already knew the answer.

“Two hundred thousand,” Elara said quietly. “If the dome fails, they all die. Instantly.”

The weight of that number hung in the air between them, heavy and suffocating. Two hundred thousand people. Families. Children. Workers who’d never done anything wrong except be born on the wrong side of the economic divide.

“Tyrell found the flaw,” Jax said, her voice barely above a whisper. “He found the structural defect, and he was trying to figure out who was responsible. That’s why he was calling Vane. He was trying to trace the stolen water back to whoever cut corners on the dome construction.”

“And whoever cut those corners killed him to keep it quiet,” Elara finished. She turned to face Jax, her expression grim. “This isn’t just a murder investigation anymore, Jax. This is terrorism. Someone is willing to let two hundred thousand people die to cover up their crime.”

Jax felt the familiar weight of responsibility settle over her shoulders, the bone-deep exhaustion that came with knowing she was the only thing standing between the dead and oblivion. “We need to get to Vane. Now. He’s the only one who can tell us who bought the dome schematics.”

“Agreed,” Elara said, already moving toward a weapons locker on the far wall. She pulled out a sleek, matte-black plasma pistol and checked the charge. “I’ll have my transport ready in ten minutes.”

“Your transport?” Jax said, her voice sharp. “This is a police operation, Vance. You’re not coming.”

Elara turned to face her, the plasma pistol held loosely at her side. “The hell I’m not. This is my infrastructure. My dome. My responsibility. If someone is planning to trigger a catastrophic failure, I need to know who and why.”

“You’re a civilian,” Jax said, stepping into Elara’s space, using her physical presence to establish dominance. “You don’t have jurisdiction. You don’t have authority. And you sure as hell don’t have the training to survive a firefight in Sector 6.”

“I have more training than you think,” Elara replied, her voice dropping to something dangerous. “And I have resources you can’t access. My transport has stealth capabilities that will get us into Sector 6 without triggering every cartel alarm in the district. Your police spinner will be shot down before you even reach the outer perimeter.”

“I’ll call for tactical support,” Jax countered. “We’ll go in with a full TRT squad.”

“And by the time you get authorization, file the paperwork, and assemble your team, Vane will be gone,” Elara shot back. “He’s a cartel boss, Jax. He has eyes everywhere. The moment you start mobilizing a tactical response, he’ll disappear into the mining tunnels, and you’ll never find him.”

“So what’s your plan?” Jax demanded, her frustration boiling over. “We just walk into The Crucible, ask nicely, and hope he doesn’t kill us on sight?”

“No,” Elara said, her silver eyes glinting with something that looked uncomfortably like excitement. “We go in fast, we go in quiet, and we extract the information before he knows what hit him. I have contacts in Sector 6. People who owe me favors. I can get us in and out without starting a war.”

“This is insane,” Jax said, running a hand through her hair. “You’re a CEO, not a field operative. You have no idea what you’re walking into.”

“I know exactly what I’m walking into,” Elara replied, her voice

hardening. "I've been to Sector 6 before, Jax. I've negotiated with cartel bosses, bribed mining foremen, and walked through districts where the air is so toxic it burns your lungs. I'm not some sheltered aristocrat who's never left the Zenith Domes. I built this empire by getting my hands dirty, and I'm not about to stop now."

Jax stared at her, searching for the lie, the bravado, the reckless arrogance of someone who didn't understand the stakes. But all she saw was genuine determination, tempered by the kind of cold calculation that came from years of making impossible decisions.

"If you get killed, it's on me," Jax said finally, her voice tight. "If you get hurt, if you compromise the investigation, if you do anything that jeopardizes this case, I will personally throw you in a holding cell and lose the key."

"Understood," Elara said, a slow smile curving her lips. "Now, are we going to stand here arguing, or are we going to catch a killer?"

Jax wanted to argue more. She wanted to call Graves, get authorization, do this by the book. But the clock was ticking. Forty-eight hours until the case was handed over to Vance's private security. Two hundred thousand people living under a dome that could collapse at any moment. And a killer who was willing to let them all die to cover up their crime.

She didn't have time to do this the right way. She had to do it the fast way.

"Fine," Jax said, the word tasting like defeat. "But I'm in command. You follow my lead, you do what I say, and you don't take any unnecessary risks. Are we clear?"

"Crystal," Elara replied, holstering the plasma pistol. "Aegis, prep the *Manticore***** for immediate departure. Full stealth configuration. And send a secure message to my contact in Sector 6. Tell him I'm calling in a favor."**

"Acknowledged," Aegis replied. "The *Manticore***** will be ready in eight minutes. I have also taken the liberty of preparing

tactical gear for Detective Jax. It is waiting in the armory.”**

Jax followed Elara to the armory, a small room off the main sub-basement filled with enough weapons and equipment to outfit a small military unit. Elara pulled out a tactical vest, a plasma pistol, and a set of night-vision goggles, handing them to Jax with practiced efficiency.

“You keep a private arsenal in your basement,” Jax said, strapping on the vest. It was high-quality, military-grade armor that would stop most small-arms fire. “Should I be concerned?”

“Only if you’re planning to betray me,” Elara replied, checking her own gear. “I believe in being prepared, Jax. Mars is a dangerous place, and I refuse to be a victim.”

Jax finished gearing up and turned to face Elara. The woman looked different now—less like a CEO and more like a soldier. The tactical gear fit her perfectly, and she moved with a confidence that suggested genuine training. This wasn’t just bravado. Elara Vance knew how to fight.

“Where did you learn to do this?” Jax asked, unable to keep the curiosity out of her voice.

“My father hired a private security consultant when I was sixteen,” Elara said, her voice carefully neutral. “A former Special Tactics operative who’d been dishonorably discharged for excessive force. He taught me how to survive in a world where money makes you a target. Hand-to-hand combat, weapons training, tactical planning. He was a bastard, but he was effective.”

“And you’ve used those skills before,” Jax said. It wasn’t a question.

“More times than I’d like to admit,” Elara replied. She met Jax’s eyes, and for a moment, the mask of the untouchable CEO slipped, revealing something darker underneath. “I’ve killed people, Jax. Not many, but enough. When you’re responsible for an empire, you make enemies. And sometimes, those enemies don’t respond to lawyers and contracts. Sometimes, you have to get your hands bloody.”

Jax felt a chill run down her spine. This was the real Elara Vance—not the polished CEO who attended board meetings and signed contracts, but the woman who'd clawed her way to the top of a corporate empire and done whatever it took to stay there. She was dangerous. Genuinely, lethally dangerous.

And Jax was about to walk into a cartel stronghold with her.

"Let's go," Jax said, pushing down the unease. "We're burning daylight."

They took the elevator back up to the main level, then crossed the estate to a private hangar built into the side of the compound. The *Manticore***** was waiting for them—a sleek, predatory transport that looked like it had been designed for military operations rather than civilian use. It was matte-black, with angular lines and no visible markings. Stealth plating covered the hull, and the engines hummed with barely contained power.**

"This is your idea of a transport?" Jax asked, climbing into the co-pilot's seat.

"I told you I believe in being prepared," Elara replied, taking the pilot's seat and running through the pre-flight checklist with practiced efficiency. "The *Manticore***** has full stealth capabilities, reinforced armor, and enough firepower to level a small building. It's also fast enough to outrun most pursuit vehicles. We'll be in Sector 6 in twenty minutes."**

Jax strapped herself in, her hand instinctively moving to the plasma pistol at her hip. She pulled out her comm and dialed Graves.

The captain's face appeared on the small screen, looking even more exhausted than usual. "Jax, please tell me you're not about to do something stupid."

"I'm following a lead on the Tyrell case," Jax said, keeping her voice carefully neutral. "The decryption analysis points to Silas Vane in Sector 6. I'm going to question him."

“Silas Vane?” Graves’s voice rose an octave. “Jax, that’s a cartel boss. You can’t just walk into his territory and expect to walk out alive. I’m calling TRT. We’ll do this properly.”

“There’s no time,” Jax said, her voice hardening. “Tyrell wasn’t just investigating water theft. He found a structural flaw in the Sector 4 dome. If someone triggers a catastrophic failure, two hundred thousand people die. I need to know who bought the dome schematics, and Vane is the only one who can tell me.”

Graves was silent for a long moment, his face pale. “You’re sure about this?”

“I’m sure,” Jax said. “I’m taking a consultant with me. Someone who has contacts in Sector 6.”

“A consultant,” Graves repeated, his eyes narrowing. “Please tell me you’re not talking about Elara Vance.”

Jax didn’t respond.

“Jax, if you take a civilian into a combat zone, I can’t protect you,” Graves said, his voice heavy with resignation. “If something goes wrong, if she gets hurt, the Commissioner will have your badge. Hell, he’ll probably have mine too.”

“I know,” Jax said quietly. “But I don’t have a choice. This is the only way to stop whoever killed Tyrell before they trigger a dome collapse.”

Graves closed his eyes, rubbing his face with both hands. “Fine. But you call for backup the second things go sideways. And Jax? Don’t get yourself killed. I’m too old to break in a new detective.”

“I’ll do my best, Cap,” Jax said. She ended the call and looked over at Elara, who was guiding the *Manticore* out of the hangar and into the Martian night.*

“Your captain doesn’t approve,” Elara observed, her hands steady on the controls.

“He never does,” Jax replied. “But he trusts me. That’s enough.”

Elara glanced at her, something unreadable flickering in her silver

eyes. “You’re risking your career for this. For me.”

“I’m risking my career for two hundred thousand people who don’t deserve to die because someone cut corners twenty years ago,” Jax corrected. “You just happen to be the person with the resources to help me stop it.”

“Is that all I am?” Elara asked, her voice dropping to something softer, more vulnerable. “A resource?”

Jax turned to look at her, really look at her. The woman who’d violated her privacy, who’d sent her Earth-grown coffee, who’d offered her complete transparency and trust. The woman who was risking her own life to help solve a murder that threatened her empire.

The woman Jax was starting to care about, despite every instinct screaming at her to keep her distance.

“No,” Jax said finally, the admission feeling like a defeat. “You’re not just a resource. You’re... complicated.”

Elara’s lips curved into a small, genuine smile. “I’ll take complicated. It’s better than being boring.”

The *Manticore* banked hard, diving toward the lower sectors. Through the viewport, Jax could see the sprawling, chaotic landscape of Sector 6—a maze of mining tunnels, industrial complexes, and makeshift settlements that clung to the Martian surface like a disease. This was the lawless frontier, where the colonial government’s authority ended and the cartels’ rule began.

And they were flying straight into the heart of it.

Jax checked her plasma pistol one more time, making sure the charge was full. Her heart was pounding, adrenaline flooding her system, sharpening her senses. This was the moment. The point of no return. Once they landed in Sector 6, there was no backing out, no calling for help, no safety net.

Just her, Elara, and whatever waited for them in *The Crucible*.

“Ready?” Elara asked, her voice steady despite the danger they were

flying into.

Jax took a breath, centering herself. She'd survived Tantalus. She'd survived fifteen years as a homicide detective in the most dangerous sectors of Mars. She could survive this.

"Ready," she said. "Let's go catch a killer."

The *Manticore***** dropped into the darkness, and Jax felt the familiar weight of responsibility settle over her shoulders. She'd made a deal with the devil. Now it was time to see if she could survive the inferno.**

The drive up to the Zenith Domes was always a stark lesson in Martian economics. Jax pushed her battered, unmarked police spinner to its absolute limits, the twin ion-thrusters rattling ominously as she ascended the spiraling mag-lev transit lanes.

Below her, Sector 4 was a bruised, purplish smudge of industrial smog and flickering neon. But as the spinner broke through the upper atmospheric segregation barriers, the smog vanished. The sky inside the Zenith Dome was a projected, crystalline blue, mimicking an Earth afternoon that Jax had only ever seen in historical vids.

The navigation system pinged, directing her toward the Vance Estate. It wasn't just a penthouse; it was a sprawling, multi-acre compound built onto a massive, reinforced bedrock shelf near the apex of the dome.

As Jax landed the spinner on the smooth, obsidian landing pad, her stomach did a slow, uncomfortable roll. It wasn't the altitude. It was the gravity.

Most of Ares Prime operated on natural Martian gravity—roughly thirty-eight percent of Earth's pull. People moved lighter, jumped higher, and suffered the long-term bone density degradation that came with it. But as Jax stepped out of her spinner, a crushing, invisible weight slammed down on her shoulders.

Her knees buckled for a fraction of a second before she locked them.

Earth-normal gravity.

Vance Interplanetary had installed localized grav-plating under the entire estate. Operating it required an obscene amount of power. It was the ultimate flex of wealth: forcing the planet itself to conform to Elara Vance's preferred physical constants.

Jax adjusted the collar of her synth-leather coat, feeling every ounce of its worn weight, and walked toward the massive, intricately carved wooden double doors of the main house. Real mahogany. It probably cost more than her precinct's annual budget.

Before she could raise a hand to the biometric chime, the doors swung inward on silent hinges.

"You are dripping engine coolant onto a three-hundred-year-old limestone portico, Detective."

The voice was crisp, aggressively aristocratic, and echoed from a tall, impossibly rigid figure standing in the center of the foyer.

Jax stopped. The man wore a flawlessly tailored, three-piece suit of midnight blue. His silver hair was slicked back, and his posture was so straight it looked painful. But as Jax narrowed her eyes, she noticed the edges of his silhouette vibrating with a faint, microscopic hum of blue light.

A hard-light hologram. A localized AI projection.

"And you are a bunch of photons masquerading as a butler," Jax said, stepping fully into the foyer and letting the heavy doors glide shut behind her. "Where's your boss, Jeeves?"

The hologram's nose flared in a remarkably lifelike display of disdain. "My designation is Aegis. I am the primary artificial intelligence overseeing the Vance Estate. And I must insist you remain exactly where you are. Your footwear is tracking microscopic industrial debris into the main hall."

Jax looked down at her scuffed combat boots, then back up at the AI. She deliberately scraped her left heel against the immaculate white marble floor. "Call a cleaning drone. I'm here for Vance."

Aegis's holographic eyes narrowed. "Ms. Vance is currently in the sub-level processing core. She left explicit instructions that you were to be admitted, though for the life of me, I cannot fathom why. I shall scan you for concealed weaponry and pathogens before you proceed."

A faint, red sweeping light emanated from the ceiling, washing over Jax.

"Try anything funny with that scan, Aegis, and I'll find your main-frame and introduce it to a magnetic pulse-grenade," Jax growled, her hand resting casually on the butt of her sidearm.

"Your threats are as primitive as your attire, Detective," Aegis sniffed. "Pathogen scan clear, though your cortisol levels are shockingly high. Follow me. Try not to touch anything. The art is genuine, and your gloves appear to be coated in something I can only categorize as 'sludge'."

Jax followed the glowing AI through the sprawling estate. The sheer scale of the place was staggering. Lush, hydroponic gardens filled with blooming, heavy-scented orchids lined the corridors. Soft, ambient light shifted to complement the time of day. It was a perfectly controlled paradise, insulated from the dead world outside.

Aegis led her to a sleek, glass elevator that descended rapidly into the bedrock. As the doors opened, the organic luxury of the upper floors was entirely replaced by the cold, humming reality of cutting-edge technology.

The sub-basement was massive, dominated by a towering, cylindrical structure of glass and pulsing blue light—a Class-9 Quantum Core. The temperature down here was kept near freezing to prevent the processors from melting down.

Standing in front of a massive, curved holographic interface was Elara.

She had shed the armored jacket from the precinct. She was wearing a simple, dark, form-fitting top and tailored trousers, her dark hair pulled up into a messy twist secured by a silver stylus. The blue light of the core washed over her face, highlighting the sharp angle of her jaw and the

intense concentration in her silver eyes.

She looked less like a polished CEO and more like a predator examining a puzzle.

“Aegis,” Elara said without looking away from the cascading data streams. “Stop antagonizing the Detective. You’ll make her shoot you, and recalibrating your personality matrix is a tedious chore.”

“I was merely attempting to preserve the sanitation of the foyer, madam,” Aegis replied smoothly. With a soft chime, his holographic projection vanished.

“He’s a menace,” Jax said, walking over to the console. The heavy gravity was making her lower back ache, but she refused to show any sign of physical strain. “You program him to be that insufferable, or did he develop it on his own?”

“A little of both,” Elara murmured, finally turning to look at Jax. A slow, appreciative smile touched her lips as she took in the detective. “You made it. And you brought the drive.”

“I brought the drive,” Jax confirmed, pulling a sealed evidence bag from her coat pocket. She didn’t hand it over. “Chain of custody. I plug it in. I authorize the decryption protocol. And I keep the original.”

“Strictly by the book,” Elara noted, stepping back from the console to give Jax room. The movement brought her close enough that Jax could feel the ambient heat radiating from her skin in the freezing room. “The interface port is on your left.”

Jax broke the seal on the bag, extracted Tyrell’s encrypted drive, and slotted it into the glowing port. Instantly, the massive quantum core behind them hummed louder, the blue light pulsing in a rapid, agitated rhythm.

“Initiate deep-parse decryption,” Elara commanded the room. “Isolate the burner comm routing data and the hidden Sector 4 file partitions.”

The holographic screens in front of them exploded with scrolling code.

Red blocks of cartel encryption shattered like glass under the sheer processing weight of the quantum core. It was taking seconds to do what would have taken Chen a month.

"I have to admit," Jax said, watching the screens, "this is a hell of a toy."

"It's not a toy, Jax. It's the central nervous system of Vance Interplanetary," Elara said, her voice dropping into that low, intimate register. She leaned her hip against the console, her shoulder nearly brushing Jax's. "So, who was Tyrell calling in the dust bowl?"

A schematic of Sector 6 appeared on the screen, a web of red lines tracing communication bounces. The lines converged on a single, heavily fortified subterranean compound.

A name flashed on the screen in stark white letters: *SILAS VANE.*

Jax let out a long, slow breath, a cold knot forming in her stomach. "Son of a bitch."

"You know him?" Elara asked, her eyes darting to Jax's profile.

"Everyone in Sector 6 knows Silas Vane," Jax said, her voice tight. "He runs the Crimson Syndicate. Black-market water, synthetic narcotics, weapons smuggling. If Vane is buying the stolen water, Tyrell wasn't just skimming off the top. He was financing a cartel."

"Look at the data packets attached to the communications," Elara said, pointing a long finger at the screen. She leaned in closer, the scent of earth and ozone wrapping around Jax. "It isn't just shipping manifests for the stolen water. Tyrell was sending Vane schematics."

Elara tapped the console. The screen shifted, bringing up a massive, complex blueprint.

Jax recognized it immediately. "That's the atmospheric regulator grid for the Sector 4 dome."

"Not just the regulator," Elara said, the amusement completely gone from her voice. Her silver eyes were hard as diamonds. "Look at the highlighted stress points. Tyrell wasn't just stealing water. He was

showing Vane how to introduce a caustic agent into the primary filtration pipes. An agent that would eat through the poly-steel lining over a period of months.”

Jax stared at the structural stress calculations running across the screen. “He was trying to cause a blowout. If those pipes rupture, the localized pressure in Sector 4 drops to zero. Ten thousand people suffocate in under an hour.”

“And the colonial government would instantly declare a state of emergency,” Elara finished, her mind racing ahead, calculating the corporate angles. “They would bypass all bidding protocols and issue an emergency, blank-check contract to fix the dome.”

“A contract your company would get,” Jax realized, turning to look at Elara. “Because Vance Interplanetary owns the patent on the replacement parts.”

“Someone is trying to manufacture a disaster to line their pockets, and they were using my infrastructure to do it,” Elara said softly. The rage in her voice was cold and absolute. “Tyrell got cold feet, or he demanded a larger cut, and Vane had him silenced. Vane sent a professional to gut him in my penthouse.”

Jax immediately reached for the drive, pulling it from the console and shoving it back into her coat pocket. “I have what I need. I’m taking a tactical squad out to Sector 6. We’re raiding Vane’s compound.”

“You can’t,” Elara said, stepping into Jax’s path. “Sector 6 is outside colonial jurisdiction. You take a police squad out there, Vane’s perimeter sensors will pick you up ten miles out. It’ll be a slaughter, Jax.”

“I don’t have a choice,” Jax snapped, her heart hammering against her ribs. “If Vane already has the caustic agent, that pipe could rupture tomorrow. I’m not letting ten thousand people choke on Martian dust.”

“I am not telling you to drop it. I’m telling you that you need my help,” Elara said. She reached out, her hand resting over Jax’s wrist. Her touch was warm, firm, and entirely grounding. “Vane is a businessman. He

won't open his doors for a cop. But he will open them for a billionaire looking to make a black-market deal."

Jax stared down at Elara's hand on her wrist, a jolt of electricity shooting up her arm. She jerked her hand away, stepping back. "Absolutely not. I am not taking a civilian into a cartel stronghold."

"I am the target of this conspiracy, Detective. They are using my company as a weapon," Elara said, her tone brook no argument. "I am going with you."

"Over my dead body."

"That is exactly what I am trying to prevent," Elara shot back. She tapped her silver wrist-comm. "Aegis. Patch me through to Captain Graves at the Sector 4 precinct. Priority override code Vance-Alpha-One."

"Hey!" Jax lunged forward, but it was too late.

A holographic screen snapped open in the air above the console. Captain Graves appeared, looking like he had aged ten years in the last six hours. He had a half-chewed nicotine patch stuck to his neck.

"What is the meaning of this—" Graves started, then stopped, his eyes widening as he took in the background. "Jax? Are you in a Vance Interplanetary sub-level?"

"Captain," Elara interrupted smoothly, projecting an aura of total authority. "Detective Jax and I have uncovered a massive, imminent threat to the Sector 4 atmospheric dome, orchestrated by Silas Vane in Sector 6. It requires an immediate, off-the-books excursion to the outer rim."

Graves rubbed his face violently. "Sector 6? Jesus, Jax, I can't authorize a raid out there! We don't have the jurisdiction or the firepower!"

"I am not asking for firepower, Captain," Elara said. "I am providing it. I have a heavily modified, stealth-capable transport and a highly compelling cover story to get us inside Vane's compound. But as this is

a matter of profound corporate security for Vance Interplanetary, I am officially attaching myself to Detective Jax's investigation. As an expert consultant."

"No!" Jax yelled, glaring at Graves. "Cap, you cannot saddle me with a billionaire babysitter in the middle of a cartel war zone! Tell her no!"

Graves looked at Elara, then at Jax. He looked at the stark reality of his budget, the pressure from the Commissioner, and the very real threat of a dome blowout in his sector.

"Detective Jax," Graves said, his voice heavy with resignation.

"Graves, don't you dare," Jax warned.

"Ms. Vance is officially designated as a civilian consultant on case file 884-Tyrell," Graves ordered, refusing to meet Jax's eyes through the hologram. "You will utilize her resources to neutralize the threat to Sector 4. But Jax—keep her alive. If the CEO of Vance Interplanetary gets a scratch on her in the dust bowl, we're both going to be directing traffic on the surface for the rest of our lives."

Graves cut the transmission before Jax could unleash the string of profanities building in her throat.

Jax stood perfectly still in the freezing room, her hands balled into tight fists at her sides. She turned her head slowly to look at Elara.

Elara looked incredibly pleased with herself. The dangerous, predatory smile was back. "Well, partner. It looks like we're taking a trip to the country."

"If you get us killed, Vance," Jax said, her voice a deadly, vibrating whisper, "I am going to haunt you."

"I look forward to it, Detective," Elara murmured. "Aegis? Prepare the stealth transport. We leave in ten minutes."

Chapter Six: The First Strike

Ten minutes turned into forty-five.

Jax stood in the Vance Estate's private armory—a climate-controlled vault three levels below the main residence that looked like it could outfit a small military battalion. Rows of weapons lined the walls in pristine, organized arrays: plasma rifles, kinetic accelerators, hard-light projectors, even a rack of illegal thermal-lances that would get anyone else a one-way ticket to a penal colony.

She was methodically breaking down her standard-issue plasma-magnum for the third time, her fingers moving through the familiar ritual with mechanical precision. Slide release. Barrel check. Firing pin inspection. Thermal-clip housing. The repetitive motion kept her hands busy and her mind from spiraling into the dark place it always went when she thought about Sector 6.

Snick. Clack. Click.

The weapon came back together in her hands, solid and reliable. She slapped in a fresh thermal-clip, chambered a round, and holstered it at

her thigh. Then she pulled it out and started the process all over again.

"You've cleaned that weapon four times in the last twenty minutes," Elara observed from across the armory. She was standing at a tactical workbench, assembling something that looked disturbingly like a military-grade assault package. "At this rate, you're going to wear down the firing mechanism."

"Muscle memory," Jax said flatly, not looking up. "I do it before every high-risk operation."

"And how many of those operations involved walking into a Sector 6 cartel stronghold?"

Jax's hands stilled on the weapon. "Counting this one? Three."

"And the other two?"

"One ended with a dead informant and a firefight that killed two of my officers. The other ended with me in a med-bay for six days with a punctured lung and a shattered collarbone." Jax finally looked up, meeting Elara's silver eyes across the armory. "Sector 6 doesn't play by the rules, Vance. There are no rules. You walk in there wearing that corporate shine, and they will tear you apart just to see what your insides look like."

Elara held her gaze for a long moment, then returned her attention to the equipment on the workbench. "Then it's fortunate I'm not planning to rely on corporate authority." She lifted a sleek, matte-black tactical vest, the kind with integrated kinetic-absorption plating and neural-link targeting assists. "Aegis? Status report on The Crucible."

The AI's holographic form materialized above the workbench, his aristocratic features rendered in cool blue light. "The Crucible is a three-level structure built into a reclaimed mining excavation. Ground level: primary fighting pit, bar, and crowd seating for approximately four hundred patrons. Second level: VIP suites, private gambling rooms, and administrative offices. Third level: Silas Vane's personal quarters and operations center. Security complement: estimated twenty-five to

thirty armed personnel at any given time, rotating in eight-hour shifts. Current shift change occurred forty minutes ago, which means fresh guards with full alertness.”

“Exits?” Jax asked, finally holstering her weapon and moving to the workbench.

“Four primary exits,” Aegis continued, projecting a three-dimensional schematic of the building into the air between them. “Main entrance on the eastern face, service entrance on the western face, emergency evacuation chute in the VIP level that drops directly into the lower mining tunnels, and a concealed rooftop access hatch used for supply deliveries. All exits are monitored by armed guards and surveillance drones.”

“So we’re walking into a kill-box with thirty hostiles and four choke-points,” Jax muttered, studying the schematic. “Fantastic.”

“We’re walking into a business meeting,” Elara corrected, pulling on the tactical vest and syncing it to her neural-lace with a series of rapid blinks. The vest’s integrated HUD flickered to life, projecting targeting reticles and threat-assessment data directly into her field of vision. “Vane is a businessman. He deals in commodities: water, weapons, information. We’re offering him something he wants—information about who really killed Tyrell and stole his water operation. In exchange, we get confirmation about the schematics.”

“And if he decides he’d rather just kill us and take whatever he wants off our corpses?”

Elara’s smile was cold and sharp. “Then we make sure we’re too expensive to kill.”

She reached into a secured locker and pulled out two compact devices that looked like oversized rings. She slid one onto her right index finger and tossed the other to Jax. “Micro-sonic charges. Frequency-tuned to shatter reinforced poly-glass and most standard barrier materials. Twist the band clockwise twice to arm, press the activation stud, and

you have three seconds to get clear. They're single-use, so don't waste them."

Jax caught the ring, turning it over in her palm. The metal was warm to the touch, humming with barely contained energy. "Where the hell did you get military-grade breaching charges?"

"I have a very well-connected procurement department," Elara said smoothly. She pulled a sleek plasma pistol from the weapons rack—not the standard colonial-issue sidearm, but something custom-built, with a longer barrel and an integrated suppressor. She checked the charge, holstered it at her hip, and then reached for something else.

The hard-light shiv.

It was a slender silver handle, no longer than Jax's palm, with a recessed activation stud and a micro-power cell that glowed faintly blue. Elara slid it into a concealed sheath on her forearm with practiced ease.

"That's a Class-A prohibited weapon," Jax said quietly. "Possession alone carries a mandatory twenty-year sentence. Use in commission of a crime? Life in a penal colony."

"Only if I get caught," Elara replied, meeting Jax's eyes. "And I don't plan on getting caught."

Jax should have arrested her right there. Should have called it in, confiscated the weapon, and dragged Elara back to Precinct 12 in restraints. But she didn't. Because the cold, hard truth was that if they were walking into The Crucible, she wanted Elara armed with every illegal, lethal advantage she could carry.

What the hell is happening to me?

"Communications check," Elara said, tapping the subdermal comm-bead behind her ear. "Aegis, do you have our signals?"

"Crystal clear, Ms. Vance," the AI replied. "I will maintain an open channel and monitor all colonial emergency frequencies. If you require extraction, I can have the *Manticore* at your location in ninety seconds."

“Copy that.” Elara turned to Jax. “Your comm?”

Jax activated her own standard-issue comm-bead, the familiar chirp confirming the connection. “Online. Graves has me on a departmental tracker, so if this goes sideways, TRT will know where to find the bodies.”

“Optimistic,” Elara murmured. She moved to a full-length mirror mounted on the armory wall and studied her reflection critically. The tactical vest, the weapons, the cold, focused expression—she looked nothing like the polished corporate executive who had walked into the crime scene three days ago. She looked like a soldier.

“Who trained you?” Jax asked suddenly. The question had been gnawing at her since the interrogation room, since Elara had casually mentioned her combat instructor.

Elara’s reflection met Jax’s eyes in the mirror. “His name was Kael Thorne. Former Special Tactics operative, dishonorably discharged after the Phobos Incident for refusing an order to fire on civilian protesters. He spent five years as a private security contractor before I hired him to train my personal protection detail. He trained me alongside them.”

“Why?”

“Because my father taught me that power without the ability to defend it is just a target,” Elara said quietly. “And because I refuse to be a target.”

She turned away from the mirror, her expression hardening back into the cold, controlled mask. “We should move. The longer we wait, the more time Sterling has to cover his tracks.”

Jax nodded, but her stomach was a tight knot of dread. She pulled on her own tactical coat—reinforced ballistic weave, not as sophisticated as Elara’s gear but reliable—and checked her backup weapon, a compact plasma-derringer holstered at her ankle.

They moved through the estate in silence, their footsteps echoing on the polished floors. Aegis guided them to the private hangar, where the *Manticore* waited like a predatory shadow.

The stealth transport was a work of art and engineering—matte-black composite armor, swept-back wings, and engines that hummed with barely contained power. It was designed to be invisible to colonial radar, untraceable, and fast enough to outrun anything short of a military interceptor.

Jax climbed into the co-pilot's seat, the crash harness automatically adjusting to her frame. Elara slid into the pilot's seat with the easy confidence of someone who had logged thousands of flight hours. Her fingers danced across the holographic controls, and the *Manticore's* engines thrummed to life.

"Aegis, open hangar doors and engage active camouflage," Elara commanded.

"Acknowledged. Godspeed, Ms. Vance. Try not to get shot."

"I'll do my best," Elara murmured.

The hangar doors split open, revealing the artificial sky of the Zenith Domes. The *Manticore* lifted smoothly off the deck, the cloaking field shimmering into place as they rose. Within seconds, they were invisible—a ghost ship sliding through the pristine, controlled atmosphere of the upper colony.

Jax watched through the viewport as the manicured gardens and gleaming towers of the Zenith Domes fell away beneath them. The transition was always jarring—one moment, you were surrounded by wealth and beauty, and the next, you were descending into the industrial guts of the colony.

They dropped into the subterranean transit arteries, the narrow tunnels that connected the inner sectors to the outer rim. The artificial lighting gave way to darkness, broken only by the occasional flicker of maintenance lights and the glow of their instruments.

"You're quiet," Elara observed, banking the transport through a sharp turn.

"Just thinking," Jax replied.

“About?”

“About how much I hate Sector 6.”

Elara glanced at her, silver eyes reflecting the dim glow of the console.

“You grew up there.”

It wasn’t a question. Jax’s jaw tightened. “You read my file. You already know that.”

“I know the facts,” Elara said carefully. “I know you were born in the Tantalus mining camp. I know you survived the cave-in that killed your parents when you were fourteen. I know you were pulled out of the rubble after seventy-two hours and spent six months in a med-bay recovering from crush injuries and radiation exposure.” She paused. “But I don’t know what it was like. I don’t know what it did to you.”

Jax stared out the viewport, watching the darkness rush past. “It taught me that the colony doesn’t give a damn about people like me. That we’re expendable. That the only thing standing between us and the void is luck and the people willing to dig through the rubble when the ceiling comes down.”

“Is that why you became a cop?”

“I became a cop because someone has to speak for the dead,” Jax said flatly. “Because when my parents died, the company that owned the mine declared it an ‘acceptable operational loss’ and moved on. No investigation. No accountability. Just two more names on a list of casualties that nobody bothered to read.” She turned to look at Elara. “So yeah. I became a cop. Because if I don’t fight for the people who can’t fight for themselves, who will?”

Elara was silent for a long moment. Then, quietly: “Your parents would be proud of you.”

Jax’s throat tightened. She looked away, blinking hard. “Don’t.”

“Don’t what?”

“Don’t try to connect with me. Don’t try to make this personal. We’re working a case. That’s all this is.”

“Is it?” Elara asked softly.

Jax didn’t answer. She couldn’t. Because the truth was that it had stopped being just a case the moment Elara had sent her that coffee. The moment she had looked at Jax in the interrogation room and seen past the badge to the broken, buried girl underneath. The moment she had stood beside her in a firefight and trusted her with her life.

The *Manticore* dropped out of the transit chute, and the world outside the viewport transformed.

Sector 6 was a sprawling, subterranean nightmare.

The massive cavern had been carved out of the Martian bedrock decades ago, a desperate expansion to house the growing population of miners and industrial workers. It was never meant to be permanent. It was never meant to be home. But the colony had run out of space and resources, and so Sector 6 had become a festering wound on the edge of civilization—a place where the law was a suggestion and survival was the only currency that mattered.

The air outside the ship’s sensors registered as a toxic soup: pulverized iron oxide, sulfur dioxide, methane from the waste-reclamation plants, and the acrid bite of cheap fuel exhaust. The lighting was a patchwork of flickering neon signs, open-air plasma forges, and the sickly orange glow of sodium-vapor lamps. Shadows moved through the haze—figures hunched against the cold, faces hidden behind rebreather masks and goggles.

Jax’s hands tightened on the armrests of her seat. Memories clawed at the edges of her mind, sharp and jagged.

The smell of burning rock. The taste of blood and dust. The sound of her mother screaming her name, the voice growing fainter and fainter until it was swallowed by the roar of collapsing stone.

“Jax.”

Elara’s voice cut through the spiral. Jax blinked, realizing she had stopped breathing. She forced air into her lungs, slow and controlled.

"I'm fine," she said automatically.

"You're not," Elara replied. "But you will be. We go in, we get the information, and we get out. Thirty minutes, maximum. I won't let anything happen to you."

Jax wanted to laugh at the absurdity of it—a billionaire CEO promising to protect a street cop in the most dangerous sector of the colony. But the look in Elara's eyes was steady and certain, and Jax found herself believing it anyway.

"The Crucible is two clicks northeast," Elara said, adjusting their course. "I'm setting us down on a concealed pad a block away. We'll approach on foot."

The **Manticore** descended toward a rusted, abandoned landing platform half-buried in industrial debris. Elara engaged the active camouflage, and the ship shimmered out of existence, leaving only a faint distortion in the air.

The boarding ramp lowered with a hiss of hydraulics, and the heat and noise of Sector 6 hit them like a physical blow.

The air was thick and oppressive, tasting of rust and chemicals. The bass-heavy thump of music from The Crucible vibrated through the bedrock, a rhythmic pulse that Jax could feel in her chest. Voices echoed through the narrow alleys—shouts, laughter, the sharp crack of a plasma-whip followed by a scream.

Jax stepped onto the ramp, her hand instinctively dropping to her holstered magnum. Elara moved beside her, her posture relaxed but her eyes sharp, scanning the shadows.

"Stay close," Jax murmured. "Don't make eye contact with anyone. Don't respond to provocations. And if someone tries to sell you something, keep walking."

"Understood," Elara replied.

They moved through the narrow, twisting alleys of Sector 6, navigating by the glow of neon signs and the distant pulse of The Crucible's music.

The streets were crowded with miners coming off shift, their faces gaunt and exhausted, their clothes stained with red dust. Black-market vendors hawked stolen goods from makeshift stalls—water rations, medical supplies, weapons, even children’s toys scavenged from the upper sectors.

Jax kept her head down, her coat pulled tight, but she could feel the eyes on them. Elara, despite the tactical gear, still moved with the unconscious grace of someone who had never known hunger or fear. It marked her as an outsider, and in Sector 6, outsiders were prey.

A figure stepped out of the shadows ahead of them—a wiry man with a rebreather mask and a plasma-cutter slung over his shoulder. “Hey, pretty lady,” he called out, his voice muffled by the mask. “You lost?”

Jax’s hand moved to her weapon, but Elara was faster. She turned to face the man, her silver eyes cold and unblinking. “No,” she said simply.

The man took a step forward, emboldened. “You sure? Because you look like you don’t belong here. Maybe you need an escort. For a price.”

“She has an escort,” Jax said, stepping between them. Her voice was flat and hard, the tone she used to break suspects in interrogation rooms. “And if you don’t walk away right now, you’re going to need a med-bay.”

The man’s eyes flicked to Jax’s badge, barely visible beneath her coat. His posture shifted, and he raised his hands in mock surrender. “Easy, badge. Just trying to be friendly.” He backed away, disappearing into the crowd.

Elara glanced at Jax. “Does that happen often?”

“Every time I come down here,” Jax muttered. “Come on. We’re close.”

The Crucible loomed ahead of them—a massive, crumbling structure of poly-crete and rusted steel, built into the side of an old mining excavation. The entrance was a gaping maw of red light and noise, flanked by two enormous men with black-market cybernetic augmentations. Their eyes glowed faintly in the darkness, optical implants scanning everyone

who approached.

Jax took a breath, steadying herself. “Remember—we’re here for information. We don’t start a fight unless they start it first.”

“Agreed,” Elara said. She stepped forward, her posture shifting into something regal and commanding. The two guards straightened instinctively, their hands moving away from their weapons.

“Vane is expecting us,” Elara said, her voice cutting through the noise with crystalline authority. “Tell him the architect from Sector 1 has arrived.”

The larger of the two guards—a man with a scarred face and a cybernetic jaw—scanned Elara with his optical implant. A moment later, he grunted and stepped aside. “VIP level. Second floor. Don’t cause trouble.”

The heavy steel doors slid open, and they stepped inside.

The Crucible was a sensory assault.

The main floor was a sunken fighting pit surrounded by tiered seating packed with screaming, jeering spectators. In the center of the pit, two men were tearing each other apart with electrified gauntlets, their fists crackling with blue lightning. Blood sprayed across the poly-crete floor with each impact, and the crowd roared its approval.

The air was thick with smoke—synth-tobacco, cheap narcotics, and the acrid tang of ozone from the electrified weapons. The bass from the sound system was so loud it made Jax’s teeth vibrate.

A woman stepped out of the shadows—lean, scarred, with a plasma-pistol holstered at her hip and a cold, professional gaze. “The boss is waiting. Follow me. Hands away from your weapons.”

Jax and Elara exchanged a glance, then followed the woman up a narrow, spiraling metal staircase. The noise from the fighting pit faded slightly as they climbed, replaced by the muted sounds of gambling and conversation from the VIP level.

The woman led them to a glass-walled enclosure overlooking the

pit. The glass was polarized, soundproofed, and undoubtedly blaster-resistant. Inside, Silas Vane was waiting.

He was sitting on a plush, synth-velvet sofa, flanked by three heavily armed enforcers. Vane himself was a lean, wiry man with skin the color of old leather and a throat crisscrossed with radiation scars—the mark of someone who had spent too many years working the deep mines without proper shielding. His eyes were sharp and cold, the eyes of a predator who had survived by being smarter and more ruthless than everyone around him.

“An architect,” Vane rasped, his voice like stones grinding together. He didn’t stand. “You don’t look like you design buildings, lady.”

“I design solutions, Mr. Vane,” Elara said, stepping into the center of the room. She didn’t wait for an invitation to sit. She remained standing, forcing Vane to look up at her. “And I understand you have a problem that requires solving.”

Jax took up a position by the door, her back to the wall, her eyes tracking the three enforcers. They were professionals—ex-military, probably, with the kind of augmentations that cost more than most people in Sector 6 made in a lifetime. They watched her with the same cold assessment she was giving them.

“I don’t have problems,” Vane said slowly. “I have opportunities. And I don’t do business with people I don’t know.”

“Then allow me to introduce myself,” Elara said smoothly. “My name is Elara Vance. I’m the CEO of Vance Interplanetary. And three days ago, one of my employees—Marcus Tyrell—was murdered in my penthouse. Before he died, he stole a substantial volume of purified water from my filtration plants and sold it on the black market. I believe he sold it to you.”

Vane’s expression didn’t change, but Jax saw the flicker of recognition in his eyes. “Go on.”

“I don’t care about the water,” Elara continued. “You can keep it.

What I care about are the schematics Tyrell was selling alongside the water. Structural weaknesses in the Sector 4 atmospheric dome. I want those schematics back, and I want to know who else Tyrell was working with.”

The temperature in the room dropped. The three enforcers shifted, their hands moving toward their weapons. Jax’s muscles coiled tight, her hand hovering near her magnum.

Vane leaned forward, his scarred face splitting into a slow, ugly smile. “You’ve got balls, coming down here and making demands. I’ll give you that.” He paused, his eyes flicking to Jax. “But you’ve got bad information, Ms. Vance. Tyrell didn’t sell me any schematics.”

“He contacted you,” Elara pressed. “Multiple times. We have the comm logs.”

“Oh, he contacted me,” Vane agreed. “Came to me with a proposal. Said he had a way to drop the Sector 4 dome and make us both billionaires. Said he could trigger a catastrophic failure, blame it on manufacturing defects, and we could sell emergency water rations to the survivors at ten times the market rate.” Vane’s smile widened. “It was a good plan. Ruthless. I respect that.”

**Jax’s stomach turned. *Two hundred thousand people.* Tyrell had been willing to kill two hundred thousand people for profit.

“But he got greedy,” Vane continued. “Wanted too much upfront. Wanted guarantees I couldn’t give. So I told him to take a walk out an airlock.” He leaned back, his expression hardening. “The next day, I hear he’s carved up in the Zenith Domes. So no, Ms. Vance. I didn’t buy his schematics. And I didn’t kill him. Whoever he was working with, it wasn’t me.”

Elara’s jaw tightened. “He came to you multiple times. What else did he say?”

“He was scared,” Vane said, his tone almost thoughtful. “The first time he came, he was cocky. Thought he had the whole thing figured

out. But the second time? He was desperate. Said someone was onto him. Said he needed to move the schematics fast, before they figured out what he'd found." Vane's eyes narrowed. "He said if he didn't sell them soon, he was a dead man. Looks like he was right."

"Who was he afraid of?" Jax demanded, stepping forward. "Did he give you a name?"

Vane's gaze shifted to her, and his smile turned predatory. "I know you," he said softly. "You're not corporate. You're wearing a badge under that coat. You're Sector 4 PD."

Hell.

Jax's hand dropped to her magnum, but she didn't draw. Not yet. "Ares Prime PD. And you're going to answer the question, Vane. Who was Tyrell afraid of?"

"He didn't say," Vane replied. "But he said they were inside Vance Interplanetary. Someone with access to the security systems. Someone who could make him disappear without anyone asking questions." He leaned forward, his eyes locked on Jax. "And now you're here, asking the same questions he was asking. Which makes me wonder—are you here to solve his murder, or are you here to finish what he started?"

"We're here for the truth," Elara said coldly. "And if you're not the one who killed him, then you have nothing to fear from us."

Vane laughed—a harsh, grating sound. "Nothing to fear? You walk into my club, accuse me of murder, and expect me to just let you walk out?" He stood slowly, his enforcers rising with him. "I don't think so."

"Vane—" Elara began.

"You made a mistake coming here, Ms. Vance," Vane said, his voice dropping to a deadly whisper. "You think because you own half the colony, you're untouchable. But down here? You're just meat. Expensive meat, but meat all the same." He gestured to his enforcers. "Strip them. Take their weapons. And then we're going to have a conversation about how much Vance Interplanetary is willing to pay to get their CEO back in

one piece.”

The enforcers moved.

Jax drew her magnum in a fraction of a second, the heavy weapon clearing the holster before the nearest enforcer had taken two steps. “Ares Prime PD! Nobody move!”

“Kill them,” Vane ordered, dropping backward over the sofa.

The room exploded into chaos.

The enforcer on the left raised a heavy plasma-rifle, the barrel swinging toward Elara. Jax fired twice—*crack-crack*—the deafening reports of the magnum shattering the soundproofed silence. The hollow-point slugs caught the man in the chest, punching through his kinetic armor and throwing him backward into the polarized glass. Blood sprayed across the transparent surface, and the man crumpled.

The second enforcer lunged at Elara with a thermal-blade, the super-heated edge humming as it sliced through the air toward her throat.

Elara didn’t flinch. She stepped *into* the swing, her left hand snapping up to catch the enforcer’s wrist with terrifying precision. She twisted—a sharp, brutal motion—and Jax heard the sickening *crack* of bone breaking. The thermal-blade clattered to the floor.

Elara’s right hand moved in a blur. A sleek silver handle dropped from her sleeve into her palm, and with a flick of her wrist, a blade of crackling, superheated blue plasma ignited—*hiss*—humming violently in the air.

The hard-light shiv.

Elara drove the plasma blade upward, straight through the enforcer’s kinetic armor, burying it in his ribcage. The man’s eyes went wide, his mouth opening in a silent scream. The smell of charred meat filled the room instantly, acrid and nauseating.

Elara pulled the blade free, and the enforcer collapsed.

She moves like a soldier, Jax thought, a spike of adrenaline and awe hitting her system. *Not like someone who learned to fight. Like

someone who's killed before.*

"Look out!" Elara shouted.

The third enforcer had unslung a scatter-blaster—a short-range weapon designed to shred targets with a spray of superheated flechettes. He fired.

Jax dove left, Elara dove right. The blast tore through the space where they had just been standing, shredding the synth-velvet sofa into a cloud of burning fluff and embedding molten fragments into the walls.

Jax hit the floor rolling, her shoulder slamming into the deck plating. She came up on one knee, her magnum already tracking the enforcer. She fired—*crack*—and the shot caught him in the shoulder, spinning him around. His scatter-blaster clattered to the floor.

But he wasn't down. He reached for a backup weapon—a plasma-pistol holstered at his hip.

Elara was faster. She closed the distance in three strides, the hard-light shiv still humming in her hand. She grabbed the enforcer's wrist, twisted it away from the holster, and drove her knee into his gut. He doubled over, gasping, and Elara brought the pommel of the shiv down on the back of his skull. He dropped like a stone.

"Vane is running!" Jax yelled, scrambling to her feet.

The cartel boss had triggered a hidden panel in the floor behind the sofa and was dropping into a maintenance chute. Jax lunged for him, but a barrage of plasma fire from the hallway pinned her back. Reinforcements were pouring up the stairs—at least six more enforcers, all armed with military-grade weapons.

"We need to move!" Elara grabbed Jax's shoulder, her grip like a vice. The blue plasma blade in her hand was still humming, casting flickering shadows across her face. "The main stairs are choked. The window!"

"It's polarized poly-glass!" Jax shouted back, firing blindly into the hallway to keep the enforcers pinned. "It'll deflect a grenade!"

"Step back," Elara ordered.

Elara holstered the shiv with a flick of her wrist and raised her right hand. She tapped a sequence into the thick, metallic ring on her index finger—the micro-sonic charge. She pressed her palm flat against the center of the massive glass window.

A high-frequency whine pierced the air, so loud it made Jax's teeth vibrate and her ears ring. The sound was physical, a pressure wave that made her bones ache.

The unbreakable poly-glass spiderwebbed in a fraction of a second, glowing white-hot at the center where Elara's hand was pressed. Then it shattered—*boom*—exploding outward in a spray of glittering shards that rained down into the fighting pit below.

The crowd in The Crucible screamed, scattering as the glass rained down like deadly hail.

"Jump!" Elara yelled.

Jax didn't hesitate. She threw herself through the shattered window, Elara right beside her. They fell twenty feet, the air rushing past them, the roar of the crowd and the thump of the bass filling her ears.

They hit the slanted canvas canopy of a black-market med-stall, the fabric tearing under their combined weight. Jax crashed through, her shoulder slamming into a metal support beam, pain exploding up her arm. She rolled, ignoring the jarring impact, her magnum already up, scanning for targets.

"Go, go, go!" Jax yelled.

They sprinted through the panicked crowd, shoving past screaming miners and syndicate enforcers who were too confused by the sudden chaos to track them. Jax took the lead, charting a brutal, straight-line path toward the exit. Elara matched her pace perfectly, her hand on Jax's shoulder, watching their six.

Plasma bolts sizzled through the air behind them, striking the poly-concrete walls and showering them with sparks. Vane's men had reached the ground floor.

“There!” Jax pointed to the main entrance, the heavy steel doors still open, the two guards scrambling to figure out what was happening.

They burst through the doors and out into the toxic, red-dust air of Sector 6. The heat and noise hit them like a wall, but Jax didn’t slow down. She sprinted down the rusted alleyway, her lungs burning, her shoulder screaming in protest.

“Transport!” Jax yelled.

Elara tapped her wrist-comm on the run. A block away, the cloaking field of the *Manticore* dropped, the sleek black ship materializing like a ghost. The boarding ramp slammed down, the engines already humming with power.

Plasma bolts sizzled through the air behind them, striking the polycarbonate walls and sending up sprays of molten rock. Vane’s men were closing in, at least a dozen of them, all firing wildly.

“Covering fire!” Jax dropped to a knee behind a rusted slag-hauler, ejecting her spent thermal-clip and slamming in a fresh one. She leaned out and fired—*crack-crack-crack*—three shots in rapid succession, forcing the pursuing enforcers to dive for cover.

Elara hit the ramp, punching the override on the exterior panel. “Jax, move!”

Jax fired one more shot, then bolted from her cover. She sprinted the last twenty meters, her legs burning, her heart hammering in her chest. She threw herself up the ramp just as the hydraulic lifts engaged, the heavy metal door slamming shut behind her, cutting off the noise, the heat, and the blaster fire.

The *Manticore* immediately surged upward, the inertial dampeners kicking in as Elara pushed the thrusters to maximum. The ship rocketed back into the dark transit tunnels, leaving Sector 6 and The Crucible behind.

For a long moment, the only sound in the pressurized cabin was their heavy, ragged breathing.

Jax lay on the deck plating, staring up at the ceiling, her chest heaving. Her shoulder throbbed where she had hit the support beam, and her ears were still ringing from the sonic charge. Adrenaline was still surging through her system, a potent, burning cocktail that made her hands shake and her vision sharpen.

She holstered her empty magnum, slowly pushing herself up into a sitting position. Her coat was torn, her hands were scraped and bleeding, and she was pretty sure she had cracked a rib.

Elara was slumped against the bulkhead opposite her, her tactical vest scorched and covered in red dust. A thin line of blood trickled from a small cut on her cheekbone, a souvenir from the shattered window. Her silver eyes were bright, her pupils dilated, her breathing fast and shallow.

She looked terrifying. She looked magnificent.

For a long moment, they just stared at each other across the narrow space of the cabin, the tension between them crackling like a live wire.

"A hard-light shiv," Jax finally managed to say, her voice slightly breathless. "Those have been outlawed since the corporate wars. Possession carries a mandatory twenty-year sentence in a penal colony."

Elara wiped a streak of ash from her forehead with the back of her hand, a slow, adrenaline-fueled smile spreading across her lips. "Only if you get caught, Detective."

Jax swallowed hard. The confines of the stealth ship suddenly felt dangerously small. "You killed that man without hesitation. You didn't even blink."

"He was trying to kill you," Elara said simply. "I don't let people hurt what's mine."

The words hung in the air between them, heavy and charged. Jax's pulse hammered in her throat.

"I'm not yours," Jax said, but her voice lacked conviction.

Elara's smile widened, sharp and predatory. "Aren't you?"

Jax didn't have a response to that. Because the truth was, she was starting to wonder if Elara was right. If somewhere between the crime scene and the firefight, between the interrogation room and the jump through the shattered window, she had stopped being just a detective and started being something else entirely.

"Vane wasn't the killer," Jax said, forcing herself back to the case, back to solid ground. "He didn't buy the schematics. Someone else did. Someone inside Vance Interplanetary."

"Sterling," Elara said quietly. "It has to be. He's the only one with access to the security systems. The only one who could have framed me."

"We need proof," Jax said. "We need to get back to the estate and go through your files. If Sterling is the one who killed Tyrell, there will be a trail. There's always a trail."

Elara nodded, but she didn't move. She was still staring at Jax, her silver eyes intense and unreadable.

"What?" Jax asked.

"You saved my life back there," Elara said softly. "When that enforcer raised the scatter-blaster, you didn't hesitate. You put yourself between me and the shot."

"That's my job," Jax said.

"No," Elara replied. "Your job is to solve murders. Not to take bullets for suspects." She paused. "Thank you."

Jax looked away, her throat tight. "Don't thank me. Just... don't get yourself killed. I don't want to have to explain to Graves how I lost the CEO of Vance Interplanetary in a cartel firefight."

Elara laughed—a soft, genuine sound that made something in Jax's chest ache. "I'll do my best, Detective."

The *Manticore* slipped back into the transit grid, the cloaking field re-engaging as they approached the Zenith Domes. The danger was behind them, but the conspiracy was deeper than they had imagined.

Vane wasn't the mastermind. The real killer was still out there, and he was inside Elara's own organization.

And Jax was starting to realize that the most dangerous thing she was facing wasn't the conspiracy.

It was the woman sitting across from her, looking at her like she was something worth protecting. Something worth keeping.

Something worth risking everything for.

The *Manticore* descended through the transit lanes with the smooth, predatory grace of a hunting cat. The cloaking field shimmered around them, bending light and sensor waves, rendering them invisible to the colonial traffic control systems and the thousands of exhausted workers commuting through the subterranean arteries of Ares Prime.

Jax sat in the co-pilot's seat, her hands resting on her thighs, watching the darkness rush past the viewport. The adrenaline that had carried her through the firefight at The Crucible was draining away, leaving behind a hollow, trembling exhaustion that made her bones feel like they were made of brittle glass.

Her left shoulder throbbed with a deep, radiating ache that pulsed in time with her heartbeat. Every breath sent a sharp spike of pain through her ribs where she'd hit the support beam. Her hands, resting on her tactical pants, were shaking—a fine, involuntary tremor that she couldn't suppress no matter how hard she tried.

Post-adrenaline crash, she diagnosed clinically. *Standard physiological response to extreme stress. It'll pass in twenty minutes.*

But it wasn't just the physical aftermath that was making her hands shake.

It was the woman sitting three feet away from her, piloting the stealth transport with the casual competence of someone who had logged thousands of flight hours. Elara's silver eyes were focused on the holographic navigation display, her fingers dancing across the controls with elegant precision. The tactical vest she wore was scorched and

covered in red dust, and there was a thin line of dried blood on her cheekbone from the shattered window.

She looked like a soldier. She moved like a killer. And she had just saved Jax's life without hesitation.

Who the hell are you, Elara Vance?

Jax had read the file. She knew the facts: born into obscene wealth, educated at the finest institutions on Earth, groomed from childhood to inherit a terraforming empire. But the file hadn't mentioned the hard-light shiv. It hadn't mentioned the combat training. It hadn't mentioned the way Elara had driven that plasma blade through an enforcer's chest without flinching, without hesitation, without remorse.

The file hadn't mentioned that Elara Vance was capable of killing to protect someone she barely knew.

She killed for me.

The thought sent a cold shiver down Jax's spine. Not fear—something else. Something dangerous and intoxicating and utterly terrifying.

"You're quiet," Elara observed, her voice cutting through Jax's spiraling thoughts. She didn't look away from the navigation display, but Jax could feel the weight of her attention anyway.

"Just thinking," Jax replied, her voice rougher than she intended.

"About?"

"About how you move in a firefight." Jax turned to look at Elara, studying her profile in the dim glow of the cockpit instruments. "You didn't hesitate. You didn't freeze. You went straight for the kill."

Elara's jaw tightened almost imperceptibly. "I told you. I was trained by a Special Tactics operative. Kael Thorne didn't teach me to wound. He taught me to survive."

"There's a difference between training and execution," Jax pressed. "I've seen academy graduates freeze the first time they have to pull the trigger on a living target. You didn't freeze. You've done this before."

Elara was silent for a long moment. The *Manticore* banked through

a sharp turn, the inertial dampeners compensating smoothly. Finally, she spoke, her voice carefully neutral.

“When I was nineteen, a rival corporation sent a team to kidnap me. They broke into my university dormitory on Earth. Three men, all armed, all professionals.” She paused, her fingers tightening on the flight controls. “Kael had taught me well. I killed two of them before campus security arrived. The third one bled out in the hallway before the med-team could stabilize him.”

Jax’s breath caught. “Jesus.”

“My father made it disappear,” Elara continued, her tone flat and emotionless. “Paid off the witnesses, scrubbed the security footage, buried the bodies in unmarked graves. The official story was a failed robbery attempt. No charges were filed. No investigation was opened.” She finally turned to look at Jax, her silver eyes glittering in the darkness. “So yes, Detective. I’ve killed before. And I’ll do it again if it means keeping you alive.”

The words hung in the air between them, heavy and charged with meaning that Jax wasn’t ready to unpack.

Keeping you alive.

Not ‘keeping us alive.’ Not ‘surviving.’ Keeping *you* alive.

Jax looked away, her throat tight. “I need to report in. Graves will want to know what we found.”

“No,” Elara said firmly. “We don’t know who Tyrell was really working for, and we don’t know how deep the leak in your department goes. Until we figure out who ordered that hit, we keep this off the official grid. Graves gave us operational latitude. Use it.”

Jax wanted to argue, but the exhaustion was gnawing at the edges of her vision. The pain in her shoulder was getting worse, a deep, grinding ache that made it hard to think. She pulled her wrist free from where she’d been gripping the armrest, gritting her teeth as her shoulder flared.

“Fine,” she conceded. “But I’m not going back to your corporate

fortress. I need my own space to think.”

Elara’s silver eyes flicked over Jax, taking in the pale, tight set of her jaw and the unnatural stiffness of her left arm. “Where to?”

“My place. Sector 4, sub-level housing, unit 402.”

Elara adjusted their course without comment, guiding the *Manticore* deeper into the industrial heart of the colony. The pristine, manicured beauty of the Zenith Domes gave way to the harsh, utilitarian architecture of the working sectors. The lighting shifted from warm, artificial sunlight to the cold, flickering glow of sodium-vapor lamps. The air outside the ship’s sensors registered as significantly lower quality—higher particulate count, elevated carbon dioxide, trace amounts of industrial solvents.

Jax watched the familiar landscape slide past the viewport and felt something in her chest unclench slightly. This was her world. This was where she belonged.

Not in the rarefied air of the Zenith Domes, drinking Earth-grown coffee and eating real strawberries. Not in the back of a stealth transport with a billionaire who looked at her like she was something precious and worth protecting.

Here. In the grime and the noise and the desperate, grinding poverty of the lower sectors.

The *Manticore* settled onto a designated police landing pad four blocks from Jax’s apartment building. The cloaking field disengaged with a faint shimmer, and the boarding ramp lowered with a hiss of hydraulics.

Jax stood up, her legs unsteady beneath her. The adrenaline crash was hitting her hard now, making her vision swim slightly at the edges. She grabbed her synth-leather coat from where she’d discarded it and shrugged it on, biting back a hiss of pain as the movement jarred her injured shoulder.

Elara was beside her in an instant, her hand on Jax’s good arm,

steadying her. “Easy.”

“I’m fine,” Jax said automatically, pulling away. She wasn’t fine. She was exhausted and in pain and her hands were still shaking, but admitting weakness felt like opening a door she couldn’t afford to open.

They walked through the narrow, crowded streets of Sector 4 in silence. The artificial night-cycle had engaged, dimming the overhead lighting to simulate Earth’s circadian rhythms. The streets were still busy—shift workers heading home, black-market vendors hawking stolen goods, children playing in the narrow alleys despite the late hour.

Jax was hyper-aware of Elara walking beside her. The billionaire moved with the same predatory grace she’d displayed in *The Crucible*, her eyes constantly scanning their surroundings, her hand never far from the concealed plasma pistol at her hip. She drew stares—her tactical gear was too clean, too expensive, too obviously high-end for this neighborhood. But no one approached them. Jax’s badge, barely visible beneath her coat, was enough to keep the desperate and the curious at bay.

Chapter Seven: The Return

They reached Jax's building—a squat, utilitarian structure of reinforced poly-crete and rusted steel. The exterior walls were covered in graffiti, and the main entrance smelled like stale urine and synthetic cleaning solution.

Jax keyed the biometric lock on the heavy metal door to her apartment. It slid open with a screech of un-oiled tracks, the sound making her wince.

The apartment was exactly what one would expect from a hardened, single homicide detective living on a colonial salary.

It was a stark, utilitarian box. The walls were painted a dull, industrial grey. The furniture consisted of a rigid poly-plas sofa that looked like it had been salvaged from a decommissioned transport, a small metal table with two mismatched chairs, and a sleeping alcove separated by a thin privacy screen. The only decoration was a wall-mounted corkboard covered in crime scene flimsies and red string from a cold case she refused to let go of.

The air smelled faintly of ozone and synthetic floor cleaner.

There were no personal touches. No photographs. No mementos. No indication that a human being actually lived here rather than just existed

between shifts.

Elara stepped inside, and the contrast was almost painful. The luxurious, dark fabric of her tactical suit made her look like a panther pacing in a concrete cage. She looked around the tiny space slowly, her silver eyes taking in every detail with the same analytical precision she'd used to examine Tyrell's corpse.

"This is where you live," Elara said quietly. It wasn't a question.

"It's functional," Jax snapped, shrugging off her synth-leather coat.

The movement was a mistake. A sharp, white-hot lance of pain shot through her shoulder, tearing a sharp hiss from her lips. The heavy coat dropped to the floor as Jax staggered, catching herself on the edge of the metal table.

Elara was there in a microsecond.

"Sit down," Elara ordered, her voice shedding its silken drawl, replaced by hard, uncompromising command. She didn't wait for Jax to comply; she grabbed Jax by the uninjured arm and guided her forcefully onto the edge of the poly-plas sofa.

"I'm fine. It's just a bruise," Jax lied through her teeth, her breathing shallow.

"You hit a reinforced steel grating after a twenty-foot drop. You're lucky you didn't shatter your clavicle." Elara knelt in front of her, the cool, calculating CEO entirely gone, replaced by something intensely focused and frighteningly capable. Her hands moved to Jax's tactical shirt, fingers working the buttons with practiced efficiency. "Take the shirt off, Jax."

"Excuse me?"

"I need to see the shoulder, and your shirt is covered in cartel blood and Sector 6 dust. Take it off, or I'll cut it off with the plasma shiv."

Jax glared at her, but she didn't have the energy to fight. With a grunt of pain, she unbuttoned her tactical shirt and slid it off her good arm, then gingerly eased it over the injured left shoulder, leaving her in a

simple, sweat-dampened black undershirt.

Elara's breath hitched, just slightly.

Jax knew what she was looking at. It wasn't just the massive, ugly purple bruise blooming across her left deltoid, spreading down toward her collarbone like spilled ink. It was the canvas of scars covering her arms and shoulders and collarbone. Jagged, pale lines of poorly healed tissue—the permanent legacy of the Tantalus Mining Camp cave-in. Burn scars from a plasma-rifle discharge during a gang raid three years ago. A puckered bullet wound on her right bicep from a shootout in Sector 6. A thin, surgical scar along her left forearm from where a suspect had slashed her with a thermal-blade.

Her body was a map of violence, a chronicle of every time she'd put herself between the innocent and the predators.

Elara didn't ask. She didn't flinch. She simply reached out, her fingertips hovering just above the worst of the Tantalus scars—the jagged, irregular lines that ran from Jax's left shoulder down across her collarbone, disappearing beneath the neckline of her undershirt.

"May I?" Elara asked softly.

Jax's throat was too tight to speak. She nodded.

Elara's fingers traced the scar with infinite gentleness, following the path of the old wound. Her touch was feather-light, reverent, as if she were touching something sacred.

"Seventy-two hours," Elara murmured. "You were buried for seventy-two hours before they pulled you out."

"You read my file," Jax said, her voice rough.

"I read the facts," Elara corrected. "But the facts don't tell me what it was like. They don't tell me how a fourteen-year-old girl survived three days in the dark with a collapsed lung and a shattered collarbone, listening to her parents die on the other side of the rubble."

Jax's hands clenched into fists against her thighs. "Don't."

"Don't what?"

“Don’t try to understand me. Don’t try to get inside my head.” Jax’s voice was shaking now, the exhaustion and the pain and the proximity of Elara’s touch breaking down the walls she’d spent fifteen years building. “You can’t understand. You grew up in a mansion with real trees and imported water. You’ve never been hungry. You’ve never been cold. You’ve never had to dig through rubble with your bare hands, trying to reach your mother’s voice before it stops.”

Elara’s hand stilled on Jax’s shoulder. For a long moment, she was silent. Then, quietly:

“You’re right. I can’t understand that. But I can understand what it’s like to be alone.” She pulled her hand back, reaching into one of the concealed pockets of her tactical suit. She pulled out a small, military-grade dermal-regenerator. “My father was a brilliant man. Ruthless, visionary, utterly devoid of empathy. He built Vance Interplanetary by crushing anyone who stood in his way. And he raised me the same way—to be hard, to be untouchable, to never show weakness.”

She pressed the device against the center of Jax’s bruise. A high-frequency hum vibrated through Jax’s bone, followed by an intense, freezing burn as the micro-stimulants flooded the bruised tissue, forcing the ruptured blood vessels to knit back together.

Jax bit the inside of her cheek to keep from making a sound, her hands curling into fists against her thighs.

Elara’s free hand rested on Jax’s good shoulder to steady her. Her touch was incredibly warm against Jax’s chilled skin. The scent of Elara’s perfume—that impossible Earth thunderstorm—wrapped around Jax, cutting through the stale apartment air.

“When I was sixteen,” Elara continued, her voice low and steady, “my father sat me down in his office and told me that I would never be safe. That the empire he’d built had made us targets. That there were men who would kill me just to hurt him, and that I needed to be able to defend myself.” She paused, adjusting the regenerator’s angle. “So he hired

Kael Thorne. A disgraced Special Tactics operative who had been court-martialed for refusing an order to fire on civilian protesters during the Phobos Uprising. Kael was brilliant and broken and utterly without mercy when it came to training.”

“What did he teach you?” Jax asked, her voice strained.

“Everything.” Elara’s smile was dark and humorless. “Hand-to-hand combat. Weapons proficiency. Tactical analysis. How to kill a man with a hairpin. How to survive in a vacuum for ninety seconds. How to identify an assassin in a crowd of a thousand people.” She pulled the regenerator back slightly, examining her work. The deep purple of the bruise had faded to an angry red, the swelling significantly reduced. “He taught me that the world is full of predators, and that the only way to survive is to be a bigger predator.”

“Is that what you are?” Jax asked quietly. “A predator?”

Elara’s silver eyes lifted to meet Jax’s gaze. “I’m whatever I need to be to protect what’s mine.”

The words hung in the air between them, heavy with implication.

“I’m not yours,” Jax said, but her voice lacked conviction.

Elara’s smile widened slightly, sharp and predatory. “Aren’t you?”

The regenerator hummed to a stop. Elara pulled it back, her fingers lingering on Jax’s shoulder for just a moment longer than necessary. Then she stood up, taking a step back, giving Jax the space to breathe.

“You need food,” Elara said, her tone shifting back to something more practical. “When was the last time you ate something that wasn’t synth-paste or recycled protein bars?”

Jax tried to remember. “Yesterday morning. Maybe.”

“Unacceptable.” Elara tapped her wrist-comm without breaking eye contact. “Aegis. Priority delivery to Sector 4, Unit 402. Stealth drone. The Wagyu protocol.”

Jax’s eyes widened slightly. “What did you just do?”

“I am feeding you,” Elara said simply. “You can’t solve a corporate

conspiracy on an empty stomach and sheer stubbornness.”

“I don’t need—”

“Yes, you do.” Elara’s voice was firm, brooking no argument. “You’ve been running on adrenaline and caffeine for three days. Your body is in shock. You need calories, hydration, and rest. In that order.”

Jax wanted to argue, but the truth was that she was starving. Her stomach was a tight, hollow knot, and the exhaustion was making her vision swim at the edges. She slumped back against the sofa, too tired to fight.

Twenty minutes later, a silent Vance Interplanetary drone hovered outside Jax’s narrow window, depositing a brushed-steel thermal crate onto the fire escape.

Elara moved to the window, opening it with a screech of protesting metal. She retrieved the crate with practiced ease, carrying it to the small metal table. She opened it carefully, and Jax watched in stunned silence as she began unpacking it.

It wasn’t just food. It was an obscene display of wealth.

There were two thick, perfectly seared cuts of actual beef—real animal protein, an extravagance that would cost a month’s salary on the black market. The meat was still warm, the surface caramelized to a perfect golden-brown, the interior a tender, rosy pink. Beside it sat roasted root vegetables—carrots, parsnips, fingerling potatoes—glazed with something that smelled like honey and herbs. A small loaf of artisanal bread, still warm from the oven, its crust crackling as Elara set it on the table. And a sealed punnet of bright, impossibly red strawberries, each one perfect and unblemished.

Elara set out two plates, two sets of silverware, two crystal glasses filled with something that looked like actual wine. She moved with the same careful precision she’d used to examine Tyrell’s corpse, arranging everything with deliberate attention to detail.

“Eat,” Elara commanded, handing Jax a silver fork.

Jax sat down, staring at the plate. She was starving, her body demanding calories to replace what the adrenaline had burned, but she hesitated.

"I can't afford this, Vance. And I can't be bought."

"It's not a bribe, Jax. It's dinner," Elara said, taking a seat across from her, cutting into her own steak with effortless grace. "Consider it hazard pay for keeping me from being vaporized by Silas Vane."

Jax took a bite. The flavor exploded in her mouth—rich, savory, complex, and entirely real. The beef was tender and perfectly seasoned, the fat rendering on her tongue in a burst of umami. It was so good it almost made her angry. She ate in silence for a few minutes, the sheer quality of the food commanding her full attention.

When she finally looked up, Elara was watching her, her own meal barely touched. The silver eyes were tracking Jax with an intensity that made the hair on her arms stand up.

"Why do you live like this?" Elara asked quietly. "A detective of your clearance level makes enough to live in the mid-levels. You could afford a larger apartment, better furniture, real food. You don't have to live in a concrete box with a failing scrubber."

Jax put her fork down, the walls coming back up instantly. "It keeps me grounded. Out here, you remember what you're fighting for. The people in the Zenith Domes... they don't care about the colony. They only care about the profit margins."

"I care," Elara said softly.

"You care that someone is using your company to steal your contracts," Jax retorted, leaning back. "That's not the same thing."

"Do you really think that's the only reason I'm here?" Elara set down her fork, her gaze never leaving Jax's face. "Do you think I would have walked into The Crucible, risked my life in a firefight with cartel enforcers, and killed a man with my bare hands just to protect my company's reputation?"

Jax's throat tightened. "Then why are you here?"

"Because of you, Jax." Elara's voice was quiet, but there was an intensity to it that made Jax's pulse spike. "Because from the moment you walked into my penthouse and looked at me like I was just another suspect, I couldn't stop thinking about you. Because you're the first person in a decade who's looked past the money and the power and seen me as something other than a commodity."

"You don't know me," Jax said, but her voice was shaking.

"I know you speak for the dead because no one spoke for your parents," Elara replied. "I know you live in this concrete box because you're punishing yourself for surviving when they didn't. I know you push everyone away because you're terrified that if you let someone in, you'll lose them the same way you lost your family." She paused. "And I know that right now, you're trying to decide whether to throw me out or let me stay."

Jax's hands were shaking again, but this time it wasn't from the adrenaline crash. "You're a suspect in an active investigation."

"No, I'm not. You cleared me the moment you saw the look on my face when I found Tyrell's body." Elara stood up slowly. She walked around the small table, closing the distance between them. "You know I didn't kill him, Jax. You've known it from the beginning."

Jax's breath caught in her throat as Elara stopped right beside her chair.

"Then what are you?" Jax asked, her voice barely above a whisper.

"I'm someone who wants to know you," Elara murmured. She reached down, her hands resting on the armrests of Jax's chair, trapping her. Elara leaned in, her face inches from Jax's, the scent of the thunderstorm completely enveloping her. "I'm someone who sees the armor you wear and wants to know what's underneath. I'm someone who looks at you and sees strength and brilliance and a kind of fierce, uncompromising integrity that I've never encountered in anyone else."

Elara's gaze dropped to Jax's lips. The intent was unmistakable. It was a gravitational pull, a magnetic, overwhelming demand. Jax's body leaned forward instinctively, the exhaustion and the adrenaline and the raw, undeniable attraction blurring her judgment. She wanted to bridge the gap. She wanted to feel the heat radiating off the billionaire. She wanted to know what Elara's lips tasted like, what it would feel like to let someone past the walls she'd spent fifteen years building.

Elara tilted her head, her lips parting slightly. Her breath was warm against Jax's mouth, and for one perfect, terrifying moment, Jax thought she was going to let it happen.

Then reality crashed back in like a bucket of ice water.

Vane. The murder. The conspiracy. The Commissioner. The case.

Jax violently shoved her chair backward, the metal legs shrieking against the concrete floor as she broke Elara's cage.

She stood up, her chest heaving, putting the table between them.

"No," Jax said, her voice shaking before she forced it into something harder, more controlled. "Stop. Right there."

Elara slowly straightened up, and for just a moment, Jax saw the hurt flash across her face—raw and unguarded and devastating. Then it was gone, replaced by the cool, unreadable mask of the CEO.

"Jax—"

"You are a civilian consultant on an active homicide investigation," Jax said, her hands gripping the back of her chair so tightly her knuckles turned white. "You are also technically still a person of interest until I prove otherwise. I am a cop. This—whatever this is—it doesn't happen. It's a conflict of interest, and it compromises my case."

"It isn't a game," Elara said, her voice dropping to a low, dangerous register.

"Then it's a mistake," Jax countered, but the words felt like broken glass in her mouth. "Tyrell was working for someone who wants to blow the Sector 4 dome. We found out Vane didn't buy the schematics. That

means whoever hired Tyrell still has them. That's the only thing that matters right now. Not this."

Elara stared at her for a long, heavy silence. The vulnerability that had cracked open between them snapped shut, replaced by the impenetrable armor of the CEO.

"You are terrified of letting anyone past the perimeter, aren't you, Detective?" Elara asked, her tone perfectly even, but the words cut like a scalpel.

"I'm terrified of a dome blowout that kills two hundred thousand people," Jax fired back, refusing to flinch. But even as she said it, she knew it was a lie. Or at least, not the whole truth.

She was terrified of this. Of the way Elara looked at her. Of the way her body responded to Elara's proximity. Of the way she wanted to let her guard down and let someone in for the first time since Tantalus.

She was terrified because everyone she'd ever let in had died.

"I'm going to take a shower and try to get three hours of sleep," Jax said, her voice flat and professional. "I suggest you go back to your estate, Vance. We start digging into Tyrell's corporate rivals at 0700."

Elara didn't argue. She picked up her tactical jacket from the back of a chair, her movements precise and controlled. She walked to the door, her hand on the release panel, and then she paused.

She turned back to look at Jax, who was standing rigidly behind the metal table, her arms crossed over her chest like a shield.

"For the record, Jax," Elara said softly, her silver eyes holding Jax's gaze with an intensity that made Jax's breath catch. "I don't play games with things I want. And I don't give up easily." She paused. "I'll see you at 0700."

The heavy metal door slid shut behind her, the magnetic lock engaging with a hollow thud.

Jax stood in the silence of her apartment for a long time, her heart hammering in her chest, her hands still shaking.

She moved to the narrow window, watching as Elara emerged from the building below. A sleek, black transport materialized out of the shadows—the *Manticore* * *, its cloaking field disengaging just long enough for Elara to board. The billionaire paused at the base of the boarding ramp, and for just a moment, she looked up at Jax’s window. * *

Their eyes met across the distance.

Jax’s hand moved to the window release, her fingers hovering over the control panel. She could open it. She could call out. She could ask Elara to come back.

She could let someone in.

But the fear was a living thing in her chest, cold and suffocating and utterly paralyzing. The memory of her mother’s voice, growing fainter and fainter beneath the rubble, echoed in her mind.

Everyone I love dies.

Elara held her gaze for one more moment, then turned and walked up the ramp. The *Manticore* lifted off silently, the cloaking field shimmering back into place, and then it was gone.

Jax stood at the window, staring out at the empty landing pad, the taste of the impossibly expensive strawberries lingering on her tongue.

She had just pushed away the first person in fifteen years who had looked at her and seen something worth protecting. Something worth keeping.

And she had done it because she was terrified that if she let Elara in, she would lose her the same way she’d lost everyone else.

Jax pressed her forehead against the cold poly-glass of the window, her eyes burning with tears she refused to let fall.

“Goddamn it,” she whispered to the empty apartment.

Outside, in the *Manticore* * *, Elara sat in the pilot’s seat, her hands resting on the controls, staring at the navigation display without really seeing it. * *

Her chest felt tight, her throat constricted with an emotion she hadn't allowed herself to feel in years.

Rejection.

No—not just rejection. Dismissal. As if what had just happened between them was nothing more than a momentary lapse in judgment. As if the connection she'd felt—the electric, undeniable pull that had made her walk into a cartel stronghold and kill a man to protect Jax—was just a figment of her imagination.

But it wasn't. She knew it wasn't. She'd seen the way Jax had looked at her in *The Crucible*. She'd felt the way Jax's body had leaned toward hers in that tiny apartment. She'd seen the war playing out behind Jax's eyes—the desperate desire to let someone in, battling against the terror of what that would mean.

Elara understood that terror. She'd spent her entire life building walls, keeping people at a distance, never letting anyone see the vulnerable, lonely girl beneath the corporate armor.

But Jax had seen her anyway. And Elara had made the mistake of hoping that maybe, just maybe, she could see Jax in return.

"Aegis," Elara said quietly, her voice rough. "Take us home."

"Of course, Ms. Vance," the AI replied, his aristocratic tone unusually gentle. "For what it's worth, I believe Detective Jax is making a mistake."

"She's protecting herself," Elara said. "I can't fault her for that."

"Perhaps," Aegis mused. "But in my experience, the things we protect ourselves from most fiercely are often the things we need the most."

Elara didn't respond. She simply closed her eyes and let the **Manticore** carry her back to the cold, empty luxury of the Vance Estate.

And in her tiny, concrete apartment, Jax finally moved away from the window. She stripped off her ruined clothes, stepped into the narrow shower stall, and let the recycled water wash away the blood and the dust and the lingering scent of Elara's perfume.

But it couldn't wash away the memory of Elara's lips, hovering inches

from her own.

It couldn't wash away the knowledge that she had just made the biggest mistake of her life.

And it couldn't wash away the crushing, suffocating certainty that she was going to regret it for the rest of her days.

They reached Jax's building—a squat, utilitarian structure of reinforced poly-crete and rusted steel. The exterior walls were covered in graffiti, and the main entrance smelled like stale urine and synthetic cleaning solution.

Jax keyed the biometric lock on the heavy metal door to her apartment. It slid open with a screech of un-oiled tracks, the sound making her wince.

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“I’m fine. It’s just a bruise,” Jax lied through her teeth, her breathing shallow.

“You hit a reinforced steel grating after a twenty-foot drop. You’re lucky you didn’t shatter your clavicle.” Elara knelt in front of her, the cool, calculating CEO entirely gone, replaced by something intensely focused and frighteningly capable. Her hands moved to Jax’s tactical shirt, fingers working the buttons with practiced efficiency. “Take the shirt off, Jax.”

“Excuse me?”

“I need to see the shoulder, and your shirt is covered in cartel blood and Sector 6 dust. Take it off, or I’ll cut it off with the plasma shiv.”

Jax glared at her, but she didn’t have the energy to fight. With a grunt of pain, she unbuttoned her tactical shirt and slid it off her good arm, then gingerly eased it over the injured left shoulder, leaving her in a simple, sweat-dampened black undershirt.

Elara’s breath hitched, just slightly.

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Jax bit the inside of her cheek to keep from making a sound, her hands curling into fists against her thighs.

Elara's free hand rested on Jax's good shoulder to steady her. Her touch was incredibly warm against Jax's chilled skin. The scent of Elara's perfume—that impossible Earth thunderstorm—wrapped around Jax, cutting through the stale apartment air.

"When I was sixteen," Elara continued, her voice low and steady, "my father sat me down in his office and told me that I would never be safe. That the empire he'd built had made us targets. That there were men who would kill me just to hurt him, and that I needed to be able to defend myself." She paused, adjusting the regenerator's angle. "So he hired Kael Thorne. A disgraced Special Tactics operative who had been court-martialed for refusing an order to fire on civilian protesters during the Phobos Uprising. Kael was brilliant and broken and utterly without mercy when it came to training."

"What did he teach you?" Jax asked, her voice strained.

"Everything." Elara's smile was dark and humorless. "Hand-to-hand combat. Weapons proficiency. Tactical analysis. How to kill a man with a

hairpin. How to survive in a vacuum for ninety seconds. How to identify an assassin in a crowd of a thousand people.” She pulled the regenerator back slightly, examining her work. The deep purple of the bruise had faded to an angry red, the swelling significantly reduced. “He taught me that the world is full of predators, and that the only way to survive is to be a bigger predator.”

“Is that what you are?” Jax asked quietly. “A predator?”

Elara’s silver eyes lifted to meet Jax’s gaze. “I’m whatever I need to be to protect what’s mine.”

The words hung in the air between them, heavy with implication.

“I’m not yours,” Jax said, but her voice lacked conviction.

Elara’s smile widened slightly, sharp and predatory. “Aren’t you?”

The regenerator hummed to a stop. Elara pulled it back, her fingers lingering on Jax’s shoulder for just a moment longer than necessary. Then she stood up, taking a step back, giving Jax the space to breathe.

“You need food,” Elara said, her tone shifting back to something more practical. “When was the last time you ate something that wasn’t synth-paste or recycled protein bars?”

Jax tried to remember. “Yesterday morning. Maybe.”

“Unacceptable.” Elara tapped her wrist—comm without breaking eye contact. “Aegis. Priority delivery to Sector 4, Unit 402. Stealth drone. The Wagyu protocol.”

Jax’s eyes widened slightly. “What did you just do?”

“I am feeding you,” Elara said simply. “You can’t solve a corporate conspiracy on an empty stomach and sheer stubbornness.”

“I don’t need—”

“Yes, you do.” Elara’s voice was firm, brooking no argument. “You’ve been running on adrenaline and caffeine for three days. Your body is in shock. You need calories, hydration, and rest. In that order.”

Jax wanted to argue, but the truth was that she was starving. Her stomach was a tight, hollow knot, and the exhaustion was making her

vision swim at the edges. She slumped back against the sofa, too tired to fight.

Twenty minutes later, a silent Vance Interplanetary drone hovered outside Jax's narrow window, depositing a brushed-steel thermal crate onto the fire escape.

Elara moved to the window, opening it with a screech of protesting metal. She retrieved the crate with practiced ease, carrying it to the small metal table. She opened it carefully, and Jax watched in stunned silence as she began unpacking it.

It wasn't just food. It was an obscene display of wealth.

There were two thick, perfectly seared cuts of actual beef—real animal protein, an extravagance that would cost a month's salary on the black market. The meat was still warm, the surface caramelized to a perfect golden-brown, the interior a tender, rosy pink. Beside it sat roasted root vegetables—carrots, parsnips, fingerling potatoes—glazed with something that smelled like honey and herbs. A small loaf of artisanal bread, still warm from the oven, its crust crackling as Elara set it on the table. And a sealed punnet of bright, impossibly red strawberries, each one perfect and unblemished.

Elara set out two plates, two sets of silverware, two crystal glasses filled with something that looked like actual wine. She moved with the same careful precision she'd used to examine Tyrell's corpse, arranging everything with deliberate attention to detail.

"Eat," Elara commanded, handing Jax a silver fork.

Jax sat down, staring at the plate. She was starving, her body demanding calories to replace what the adrenaline had burned, but she hesitated.

"I can't afford this, Vance. And I can't be bought."

"It's not a bribe, Jax. It's dinner," Elara said, taking a seat across from her, cutting into her own steak with effortless grace. "Consider it hazard pay for keeping me from being vaporized by Silas Vane."

Jax took a bite. The flavor exploded in her mouth—rich, savory, complex, and entirely real. The beef was tender and perfectly seasoned, the fat rendering on her tongue in a burst of umami. It was so good it almost made her angry. She ate in silence for a few minutes, the sheer quality of the food commanding her full attention.

When she finally looked up, Elara was watching her, her own meal barely touched. The silver eyes were tracking Jax with an intensity that made the hair on her arms stand up.

“Why do you live like this?” Elara asked quietly. “A detective of your clearance level makes enough to live in the mid-levels. You could afford a larger apartment, better furniture, real food. You don’t have to live in a concrete box with a failing scrubber.”

Jax put her fork down, the walls coming back up instantly. “It keeps me grounded. Out here, you remember what you’re fighting for. The people in the Zenith Domes... they don’t care about the colony. They only care about the profit margins.”

“I care,” Elara said softly.

“You care that someone is using your company to steal your contracts,” Jax retorted, leaning back. “That’s not the same thing.”

“Do you really think that’s the only reason I’m here?” Elara set down her fork, her gaze never leaving Jax’s face. “Do you think I would have walked into The Crucible, risked my life in a firefight with cartel enforcers, and killed a man with my bare hands just to protect my company’s reputation?”

Jax’s throat tightened. “Then why are you here?”

“Because of you, Jax.” Elara’s voice was quiet, but there was an intensity to it that made Jax’s pulse spike. “Because from the moment you walked into my penthouse and looked at me like I was just another suspect, I couldn’t stop thinking about you. Because you’re the first person in a decade who’s looked past the money and the power and seen me as something other than a commodity.”

“You don’t know me,” Jax said, but her voice was shaking.

“I know you speak for the dead because no one spoke for your parents,” Elara replied. “I know you live in this concrete box because you’re punishing yourself for surviving when they didn’t. I know you push everyone away because you’re terrified that if you let someone in, you’ll lose them the same way you lost your family.” She paused. “And I know that right now, you’re trying to decide whether to throw me out or let me stay.”

Jax’s hands were shaking again, but this time it wasn’t from the adrenaline crash. “You’re a suspect in an active investigation.”

“No, I’m not. You cleared me the moment you saw the look on my face when I found Tyrell’s body.” Elara stood up slowly. She walked around the small table, closing the distance between them. “You know I didn’t kill him, Jax. You’ve known it from the beginning.”

Jax’s breath caught in her throat as Elara stopped right beside her chair.

“Then what are you?” Jax asked, her voice barely above a whisper.

“I’m someone who wants to know you,” Elara murmured. She reached down, her hands resting on the armrests of Jax’s chair, trapping her. Elara leaned in, her face inches from Jax’s, the scent of the thunderstorm completely enveloping her. “I’m someone who sees the armor you wear and wants to know what’s underneath. I’m someone who looks at you and sees strength and brilliance and a kind of fierce, uncompromising integrity that I’ve never encountered in anyone else.”

Elara’s gaze dropped to Jax’s lips. The intent was unmistakable. It was a gravitational pull, a magnetic, overwhelming demand. Jax’s body leaned forward instinctively, the exhaustion and the adrenaline and the raw, undeniable attraction blurring her judgment. She wanted to bridge the gap. She wanted to feel the heat radiating off the billionaire. She wanted to know what Elara’s lips tasted like, what it would feel like to let someone past the walls she’d spent fifteen years building.

Elara tilted her head, her lips parting slightly. Her breath was warm against Jax's mouth, and for one perfect, terrifying moment, Jax thought she was going to let it happen.

Then reality crashed back in like a bucket of ice water.

Vane. The murder. The conspiracy. The Commissioner. The case.

Jax violently shoved her chair backward, the metal legs shrieking against the concrete floor as she broke Elara's cage.

She stood up, her chest heaving, putting the table between them.

"No," Jax said, her voice shaking before she forced it into something harder, more controlled. "Stop. Right there."

Elara slowly straightened up, and for just a moment, Jax saw the hurt flash across her face—raw and unguarded and devastating. Then it was gone, replaced by the cool, unreadable mask of the CEO.

"Jax—"

"You are a civilian consultant on an active homicide investigation," Jax said, her hands gripping the back of her chair so tightly her knuckles turned white. "You are also technically still a person of interest until I prove otherwise. I am a cop. This—whatever this is—it doesn't happen. It's a conflict of interest, and it compromises my case."

"It isn't a game," Elara said, her voice dropping to a low, dangerous register.

"Then it's a mistake," Jax countered, but the words felt like broken glass in her mouth. "Tyrell was working for someone who wants to blow the Sector 4 dome. We found out Vane didn't buy the schematics. That means whoever hired Tyrell still has them. That's the only thing that matters right now. Not this."

Elara stared at her for a long, heavy silence. The vulnerability that had cracked open between them snapped shut, replaced by the impenetrable armor of the CEO.

"You are terrified of letting anyone past the perimeter, aren't you, Detective?" Elara asked, her tone perfectly even, but the words cut like

a scalpel.

"I'm terrified of a dome blowout that kills two hundred thousand people," Jax fired back, refusing to flinch. But even as she said it, she knew it was a lie. Or at least, not the whole truth.

She was terrified of this. Of the way Elara looked at her. Of the way her body responded to Elara's proximity. Of the way she wanted to let her guard down and let someone in for the first time since Tantalus.

She was terrified because everyone she'd ever let in had died.

"I'm going to take a shower and try to get three hours of sleep," Jax said, her voice flat and professional. "I suggest you go back to your estate, Vance. We start digging into Tyrell's corporate rivals at 0700."

Elara didn't argue. She picked up her tactical jacket from the back of a chair, her movements precise and controlled. She walked to the door, her hand on the release panel, and then she paused.

She turned back to look at Jax, who was standing rigidly behind the metal table, her arms crossed over her chest like a shield.

"For the record, Jax," Elara said softly, her silver eyes holding Jax's gaze with an intensity that made Jax's breath catch. "I don't play games with things I want. And I don't give up easily." She paused. "I'll see you at 0700."

The heavy metal door slid shut behind her, the magnetic lock engaging with a hollow thud.

Jax stood in the silence of her apartment for a long time, her heart hammering in her chest, her hands still shaking.

She moved to the narrow window, watching as Elara emerged from the building below. A sleek, black transport materialized out of the shadows—the *Manticore*, its cloaking field disengaging just long enough for Elara to board. The billionaire paused at the base of the boarding ramp, and for just a moment, she looked up at Jax's window.

Their eyes met across the distance.

Jax's hand moved to the window release, her fingers hovering over the control panel. She could open it. She could call out. She could ask Elara to come back.

She could let someone in.

But the fear was a living thing in her chest, cold and suffocating and utterly paralyzing. The memory of her mother's voice, growing fainter and fainter beneath the rubble, echoed in her mind.

Everyone I love dies.

Elara held her gaze for one more moment, then turned and walked up the ramp. The *Manticore* lifted off silently, the cloaking field shimmering back into place, and then it was gone.

Jax stood at the window, staring out at the empty landing pad, the taste of the impossibly expensive strawberries lingering on her tongue.

She had just pushed away the first person in fifteen years who had looked at her and seen something worth protecting. Something worth keeping.

And she had done it because she was terrified that if she let Elara in, she would lose her the same way she'd lost everyone else.

Jax pressed her forehead against the cold poly-glass of the window, her eyes burning with tears she refused to let fall.

"Goddamn it," she whispered to the empty apartment.

Outside, in the *Manticore***, Elara sat in the pilot's seat, her hands resting on the controls, staring at the navigation display without really seeing it.**

Her chest felt tight, her throat constricted with an emotion she hadn't allowed herself to feel in years.

Rejection.

No—not just rejection. Dismissal. As if what had just happened between them was nothing more than a momentary lapse in judgment. As if the connection she'd felt—the electric, undeniable pull that had made her walk into a cartel stronghold and kill a man to protect Jax—was

just a figment of her imagination.

But it wasn't. She knew it wasn't. She'd seen the way Jax had looked at her in *The Crucible*. She'd felt the way Jax's body had leaned toward hers in that tiny apartment. She'd seen the war playing out behind Jax's eyes—the desperate desire to let someone in, battling against the terror of what that would mean.

Elara understood that terror. She'd spent her entire life building walls, keeping people at a distance, never letting anyone see the vulnerable, lonely girl beneath the corporate armor.

But Jax had seen her anyway. And Elara had made the mistake of hoping that maybe, just maybe, she could see Jax in return.

"Aegis," Elara said quietly, her voice rough. "Take us home."

"Of course, Ms. Vance," the AI replied, his aristocratic tone unusually gentle. "For what it's worth, I believe Detective Jax is making a mistake."

"She's protecting herself," Elara said. "I can't fault her for that."

"Perhaps," Aegis mused. "But in my experience, the things we protect ourselves from most fiercely are often the things we need the most."

Elara didn't respond. She simply closed her eyes and let the **Manti-core** carry her back to the cold, empty luxury of the Vance Estate.

And in her tiny, concrete apartment, Jax finally moved away from the window. She stripped off her ruined clothes, stepped into the narrow shower stall, and let the recycled water wash away the blood and the dust and the lingering scent of Elara's perfume.

But it couldn't wash away the memory of Elara's lips, hovering inches from her own.

It couldn't wash away the knowledge that she had just made the biggest mistake of her life.

And it couldn't wash away the crushing, suffocating certainty that she was going to regret it for the rest of her days.

Chapter Eight: The Red Herring

At 0700 hours, Precinct 12 smelled like defeat and burnt synth-toast.

Jax had managed exactly two hours and fourteen minutes of sleep. Every time she closed her eyes, her brain had ping-ponged violently between the terrifying schematic of the Sector 4 dome and the phantom sensation of Elara Vance's lips hovering inches from her own.

She walked into the bullpen feeling like a raw nerve. She was vibrating with a dangerous mix of exhaustion, residual adrenaline, and the dregs of the billionaire's Earth-grown coffee from the day before.

Chen was already at her desk, entirely submerged in a sea of glowing holographic data-streams.

"Tell me you didn't sleep here, Chen," Jax said, dropping into her creaking poly-plas chair and pulling her sidearm from its holster to run a quick diagnostic check.

"Sleep is a biological inefficiency when you're hunting a ghost," Chen replied cheerfully, not looking up. "Besides, I found the money."

Jax froze, the diagnostic tool hovering over the magnum's thermal-

chamber. "You traced the buyer?"

"Tyrell was smart, but he wasn't as smart as a colonial audit algorithm," Chen said, her fingers flying across the console. She swiped a data-packet toward Jax's screen. "We know Silas Vane passed on the dome-breach schematics because Tyrell wanted too much upfront. So, Tyrell went to the open market. He used a deep-web corporate broker to auction the caustic agent and the schematics."

Jax leaned in, her eyes scanning the complex routing numbers. "And who won the auction?"

"The money was routed through twelve different offshore orbital accounts, but it originated from a shell corporation called Aegis Logistics," Chen said.

"Aegis?" Jax frowned. "Like Vance's AI?"

"A coincidence, or a deliberate taunt," a smooth, glacially cold voice said from behind them.

Jax's spine stiffened. She turned her chair slowly.

Elara Vance stood in the aisle of the bullpen, flanked by two bewildered-looking uniform cops who clearly hadn't known whether to stop her or salute her. She was wearing a flawless, stark-white tailored suit that practically glowed in the grimy precinct lighting. Her hair was pulled back into a severe, elegant knot.

There was no trace of the vulnerability or the heat from the night before. Her silver eyes met Jax's with the absolute, impassive distance of a CEO addressing a mid-level contractor.

"Good morning, Detective," Elara said crisply. "Officer Chen."

"Ms. Vance," Jax replied, keeping her voice strictly professional, ignoring the sudden, heavy thud of her own pulse. "You know Aegis Logistics?"

Elara stepped up to the desk, her gaze fixed entirely on the holographic monitors, deliberately avoiding looking at Jax's face. "It's a holding company. One of dozens controlled by Kaelen Mercer."

“Mercer,” Chen breathed, her eyes widening. “CEO of Helios Terraforming.”

“My biggest competitor,” Elara confirmed flatly. “Helios has been trying to break my monopoly on the lower-sector atmospheric contracts for a decade. If the Sector 4 dome ruptures, and Vance Interplanetary is blamed for the structural failure, the colonial government would instantly revoke my operating license.”

“And award the emergency repair contracts to Helios,” Jax finished, the pieces slamming into place. It made perfect, ruthless corporate sense. “Mercer buys the schematics from Tyrell. Tyrell gets greedy or gets cold feet. Mercer sends a professional hitman to gut Tyrell with a military laser, framing your company in the process.”

“And Mercer retains the caustic agent to blow the dome himself,” Elara added, her voice dropping to a deadly frequency.

“Where is Mercer right now?” Jax asked Chen, already standing up and reaching for her heavy tactical vest.

“He owns a private logistics compound in Sector 3,” Chen said, tapping her screen. “According to his public itinerary, he’s currently on-site conducting a ‘facility inspection.’ Jax, the compound is heavily fortified. Private security, automated turrets.”

“Captain!” Jax yelled, not caring who she startled in the bullpen.

Graves poked his head out of his office, looking aggrieved.

“I have a prime suspect in the Tyrell homicide, and probable cause for the possession of a Class-A biological or chemical weapon,” Jax shouted across the room. “I need a Tactical Response Team, full kinetic armor, and an immediate breach warrant for the Helios compound in Sector 3.”

Graves stared at her, then looked at Elara Vance, who gave him a slow, expectant nod. The Captain paled slightly, but he hit the alarm rune on his doorframe. “TRT is spinning up, Jax! You have point!”

Jax strapped her tactical vest tightly over her chest, the familiar weight of the ceramic trauma plates grounding her. She checked her spare

thermal-clips, slotted them into her belt, and grabbed a heavy plasma-carbine from the precinct armory rack.

She turned to find Elara watching her.

“You stay here,” Jax ordered, her tone brooking absolutely no argument. “This isn’t a cartel backroom. This is a sanctioned police raid on a fortified corporate compound. TRT will shoot anything that isn’t wearing a badge.”

For a second, the icy facade cracked, and Elara’s eyes flashed with a dangerous, rebellious heat. But she reigned it in, her jaw tightening. “Bring him in breathing, Detective. I want to look him in the eye when his empire burns.”

“Count on it,” Jax said.

Sector 3 was the agricultural heart of Ares Prime, a massive sprawl of towering, green-lit hydroponic and aeroponic farms that smelled heavily of synthesized fertilizer and ozone.

The Helios Terraforming Logistics Compound sat in the center of it like a fortress of dark plasteel and reinforced concrete.

Jax stood in the back of the armored TRT transport, surrounded by six heavily armed, silent tactical officers in matte-black kinetic armor. Officer Chen was monitoring the local grid from the transport’s comms station.

The transport rumbled through the narrow service tunnels connecting Sector 4 to Sector 3, the heavy suspension absorbing the uneven roadway with mechanical precision. Inside the cramped, dimly lit cargo bay, Jax gripped the overhead stability rail, her knuckles white, her mind racing through the tactical variables.

Six TRT officers sat in silence around her, their faces hidden behind matte-black tactical visors, their plasma carbines held at low-ready across their chests. They were professionals—ex-military, most of them, veterans of the corporate wars who had traded one uniform for

another. They didn't speak. They didn't need to. They'd done this a hundred times before.

But Jax hadn't.

She'd been in firefights before—plenty of them. Gang raids in Sector 6, cartel takedowns, domestic disturbances that had turned into shootouts. But those had been reactive, chaotic, desperate scrambles for survival. This was different. This was a planned, coordinated assault on a fortified corporate compound with military-grade defenses and a private security force that was better equipped than most colonial police departments.

And they were doing it based on a money trail that was starting to feel too clean, too obvious, too perfectly laid out.

What if we're wrong?

The thought gnawed at her, a cold, insidious whisper in the back of her mind. What if Mercer wasn't the killer? What if this was another misdirection, another layer of the conspiracy designed to waste their time while the real threat moved into position?

What if Elara was in danger right now, and Jax was racing in the wrong direction?

She forced the thought down, burying it beneath the cold, professional detachment she'd spent fifteen years cultivating. She couldn't afford doubt. Not now. Not when six officers were putting their lives on the line based on her investigation.

"Chen," Jax said, activating her throat-mic. "Status report."

Officer Chen's voice crackled in her earpiece, slightly distorted by the encrypted channel. "I'm patched into the Sector 3 municipal grid. Helios Compound is running on a closed-loop power system—they've got their own fusion reactor, independent from the colonial grid. Smart. Makes them harder to shut down remotely."

"Can you cut their power?" Jax asked.

"Negative. The reactor is physically isolated. But I can jam their external comms array. They won't be able to call for backup or alert

their corporate headquarters. You'll have a three-minute window before their internal automated defense grids reboot and start cycling through emergency protocols."

"Three minutes," Jax muttered. "That's not a lot of time."

"It's what we've got," Chen replied. "I'm also monitoring the colonial emergency frequencies. If this goes sideways, I can have med-evac on site in four minutes."

"Let's hope it doesn't come to that." Jax turned to the TRT squad leader—a broad-shouldered man with a scarred jaw and the callsign "Hammer" stenciled on his chest plate. "What's our breach plan?"

Hammer's voice was a low, gravelly rumble, filtered through his helmet's external speakers. "Primary entry is the eastern loading bay. It's the widest access point, gives us the best field of fire once we're inside. We'll use a concentrated sonic charge to blow the doors—loud, but effective. Once we're in, we split into two fire teams. Alpha team sweeps the ground floor, secures any hostiles, and establishes a perimeter. Bravo team moves vertical, clears the administrative levels, and locates the target."

"And if they've got heavy weapons?" Jax asked.

"Then we adapt," Hammer said flatly. "Helios security is well-trained, but they're not military. They'll fold under sustained pressure. The key is speed and overwhelming force. We hit them hard, we hit them fast, and we don't give them time to organize a defense."

Jax nodded. It was a solid plan. Textbook breach-and-clear tactics. But textbook plans had a way of falling apart the moment the first shot was fired.

"What about escape routes?" Jax pressed. "If Mercer rabbits, where does he go?"

"Compound has four exits," Hammer replied, pulling up a holographic schematic of the facility on his wrist-mounted tactical display. "Primary loading bay, secondary personnel entrance on the west side, emergency

evacuation chute that drops into the underground transit tunnels, and a rooftop landing pad for executive transports. We've got eyes on the rooftop—if a ship tries to lift off, we'll know. The evacuation chute is a problem, though. If he goes down there, we'll have to pursue on foot through the tunnels, and that's a nightmare scenario."

"Then we don't let him reach the chute," Jax said. "Chen, can you lock down the compound's internal security doors once we're inside?"

"I can try," Chen said. "But if they've got manual overrides, I won't be able to stop someone from physically opening them. You'll need to move fast."

"Copy that." Jax took a slow breath, steadying herself. Her hands were shaking slightly—not from fear, but from adrenaline. Her body knew what was coming before her mind fully processed it.

The transport slowed, the engine's hum dropping to a low, idling rumble. Through the narrow viewport in the rear doors, Jax could see the towering, dark silhouette of the Helios Compound looming ahead, its exterior floodlights casting harsh, angular shadows across the surrounding farmland.

"Two minutes to breach point," the driver's voice crackled over the internal comms.

Hammer stood, his massive frame filling the cramped space. The other TRT officers rose with him, checking their weapons with practiced efficiency. Magazines were seated, thermal clips were charged, targeting systems were synced to their neural-lace HUDs.

Jax pulled her own plasma carbine from the weapons rack, the heavy weapon settling into her hands with familiar weight. She checked the charge—full. She checked the safety—off. She checked the targeting laser—functional.

She was ready.

But as the transport rolled to a stop and the rear doors began to hiss open, Jax found herself thinking about Elara.

About the way she had looked at Jax in the precinct armory, her silver eyes filled with something that looked dangerously close to trust. About the way she had moved through The Crucible, lethal and graceful and utterly fearless. About the way she had held Jax in the tiny apartment, her touch gentle and reverent, as if Jax were something precious instead of something broken.

I told her to stay at the precinct. She's safe. She has to be safe.

But the cold, gnawing doubt wouldn't leave.

"Jax," Hammer said, his voice cutting through her spiraling thoughts. "You with us?"

Jax blinked, forcing herself back to the present. "Yeah. I'm with you."

"Good. Because once we go through those doors, there's no turning back. You ready for this?"

Jax met his gaze through the reflective surface of his visor. "Let's bring this bastard in."

The rear doors blew open, and the night air of Sector 3 rushed in—cool, humid, thick with the smell of synthetic fertilizer and ozone from the hydroponic farms. The transport had stopped fifty meters from the compound's primary loading bay, using a cluster of agricultural storage silos as cover.

Jax hit the ground running, her boots crunching on the gravel service road. The TRT squad fanned out around her, moving in a tight, coordinated formation. Hammer took point, his heavy plasma carbine raised to his shoulder, his targeting laser painting a bright red dot on the loading bay doors.

"Chen, we're in position," Jax whispered into her throat-mic. "Initiate comms blackout."

"Blackout initiated," Chen replied. "You've got three minutes starting... now."

Hammer gestured to two of his officers, who moved forward with a compact, cylindrical device—the sonic breaching charge. They slapped

it against the center of the loading bay doors, the magnetic clamps engaging with a soft *click***. One of the officers twisted the activation dial, and a high-pitched whine began to build, barely audible at first but rapidly climbing in frequency.**

“Breaching in five,” Hammer said. “Four. Three. Two—”

The charge detonated.

The sound was a physical thing—a concentrated, high-frequency *shriek* that made Jax’s teeth vibrate and her vision blur at the edges. The loading bay doors buckled inward, the reinforced plasteel locking mechanisms shattering under the sonic assault. The heavy doors blew open, slamming against the interior walls with a deafening *crash***, and a cloud of grey smoke and pulverized metal billowed out into the night.**

“Go, go, go!” Hammer roared.

Jax surged forward, her carbine raised, her finger resting on the trigger guard. The smoke was thick and choking, reducing visibility to less than five meters. She activated her tactical visor’s thermal overlay, and the world shifted into a ghostly landscape of heat signatures and glowing outlines.

The interior of the compound was a massive warehouse, easily a hundred meters long and thirty meters high. Towering racks of terraforming equipment lined the walls—atmospheric processors, hydroponic seed banks, industrial-scale water purifiers. Overhead, a network of automated cranes and conveyor systems hung suspended from the ceiling, their mechanical arms frozen mid-operation.

And scattered throughout the warehouse, moving rapidly toward defensive positions, were at least twenty heat signatures.

“Contact!” one of the TRT officers yelled.

Plasma fire erupted from the far side of the warehouse, brilliant blue-white bolts that screamed through the air and exploded against the concrete pillars with deafening *cracks***. The heat was immediate

and intense, the superheated plasma igniting the air itself, filling the warehouse with the acrid stench of ozone and burning metal.***

“Suppressing fire!” Hammer bellowed, dropping to one knee behind a forklift and laying down a sustained burst of automatic fire. The heavy plasma carbine roared, spitting a stream of incandescent bolts that tore through the equipment racks and forced the Helios security guards to dive for cover.

Jax threw herself behind a stack of poly-crate shipping containers, her heart hammering in her chest. She leaned out, acquired a target—a guard crouched behind a water purifier, his plasma rifle raised—and fired a three-round burst. The first shot went wide, the second clipped the edge of the purifier, and the third caught the guard in the shoulder, spinning him around. He dropped, screaming, his weapon clattering to the floor.

“Alpha team, push left!” Hammer ordered. “Bravo team, with me! We’re going vertical!”

The TRT squad split, three officers peeling off to flank the remaining guards on the ground floor while Hammer and two others moved toward the metal staircase leading to the elevated administrative offices.

Jax followed Bravo team, her carbine sweeping the upper catwalks. More plasma fire rained down from above, the bolts sizzling past her head and exploding against the concrete floor. She returned fire, forcing the shooters to duck back behind the railings.

“Chen, I need a sitrep!” Jax yelled into her throat-mic, her voice barely audible over the roar of the firefight.

“You’ve got approximately fifteen hostiles still active,” Chen replied, her voice tight with stress. “Most of them are concentrated on the ground floor, but there’s a cluster of heat signatures in the northwest corner—looks like they’re trying to set up a heavy weapon emplacement.”

“Hammer, you copy that?” Jax called out.

“Copy,” Hammer grunted. “Alpha team, neutralize that emplacement before they get it online!”

A massive explosion rocked the warehouse as one of the Alpha team officers tossed a high-explosive grenade into the northwest corner. The blast was deafening, a shockwave of heat and pressure that rattled Jax’s bones and sent a cascade of debris raining down from the ceiling. When the smoke cleared, the heavy weapon emplacement was a twisted, smoking ruin, and the guards who had been manning it were either dead or unconscious.

“Emplacement neutralized!” the Alpha team leader reported.

Jax reached the base of the metal staircase, her lungs burning, her hands slick with sweat inside her tactical gloves. She started climbing, taking the steps two at a time, her carbine raised. Hammer was ahead of her, his massive frame moving with surprising speed and agility.

A guard appeared at the top of the staircase, his plasma pistol raised. Hammer didn’t hesitate—he fired a single shot, the bolt catching the guard square in the chest and throwing him backward over the railing. The man’s scream was cut short as he hit the concrete floor below with a sickening *thud***.**

They reached the upper catwalk, a narrow metal walkway that ran the length of the warehouse. The administrative offices were clustered at the far end, behind reinforced poly-glass walls. Through the transparent barriers, Jax could see movement—someone was inside, frantically working at a computer console.

“Target acquired,” Hammer said. “Breaching.”

One of the Bravo team officers slapped another sonic charge against the office door. The charge detonated with a sharp *crack***, and the door blew inward, the locking mechanism shattering.**

Jax was through the door before the smoke cleared, her carbine raised, her targeting laser painting a bright red dot on the center of Kaelen Mercer’s chest.

“Get away from the console! Hands in the air!” Jax roared, her voice raw and commanding.

Kaelen Mercer was a soft, wealthy man in his fifties, his expensive tailored suit clinging to a frame that had never seen a day of physical labor. His face was pale and slick with sweat, his eyes wide with terror. He was frantically tapping at the console, trying to delete something, his fingers trembling so badly he kept missing the keys.

“I said hands in the air!” Jax advanced, closing the distance in three strides. She grabbed Mercer by the collar of his jacket and hauled him away from the console, slamming him face-first against the poly-glass wall. “Don’t move!”

Mercer let out a choked, terrified sob. “Don’t shoot! Please, don’t shoot! I have colonial immunity! I’m a registered corporate executive!”

“You have the right to remain silent,” Jax snarled, kicking his legs apart and patting him down for weapons. He was unarmed—no plasma pistol, no concealed blade, nothing. Just a terrified, soft-bodied executive who had never been on the wrong side of a police raid in his life. “Which I highly suggest you utilize.”

She hauled him back around, shoving him into the office chair. Mercer collapsed into it, his hands raised, his entire body shaking. Tears were streaming down his face, cutting tracks through the sweat and grime.

“Where is it, Mercer?” Jax demanded, leaning in close, her voice dropping to a deadly whisper. “Where’s the caustic agent?”

“I don’t know what you’re talking about!” Mercer stammered, his voice breaking. “This is an illegal raid! My lawyers will strip your precinct down to the copper wiring! I’ll have your badge! I’ll—”

Jax grabbed him by the lapels of his jacket and hauled him half out of the chair, her face inches from his. “Marcus Tyrell. You bought the Sector 4 dome schematics from him. And then you sent a professional to carve him up to tie up loose ends. Where is the chemical agent?”

Mercer stared at her, and for a moment, the terror in his eyes

was replaced by something else—genuine, unadulterated confusion. “Tyrell? Tyrell is *dead***?”**

Jax frowned, the first cold prickle of unease sliding down her spine. The confusion in Mercer’s voice wasn’t an act. It was too raw, too immediate, too visceral. He genuinely didn’t know.

“Don’t play stupid,” Jax said, but her voice had lost some of its edge. “We traced the orbital shell accounts. Aegis Logistics. You wired ten million credits to a dark-web broker three days ago.”

“Yes!” Mercer shrieked, his composure completely shattering. “Yes, I bought the data! But I didn’t buy it from Tyrell! And I didn’t buy a chemical agent! I didn’t even know Tyrell was involved!”

Jax released him, taking a step back. Her mind was racing, analyzing the timeline, the evidence, the too-convenient money trail. “Then what did you buy?”

“Code!” Mercer choked out, his hands still raised, his entire body trembling. “An anonymous broker reached out to me two days ago. They offered me the proprietary source code for Vance Interplanetary’s new atmospheric filtration AI. It was the holy grail! It would let Helios undercut Vance’s bids by forty percent across the entire colony! I wired the money immediately, but the data packet they sent me was corrupted! It was garbage! Just dummy files wrapped in a Vance header!”

Jax froze.

Two days ago.

Tyrell had been dead for *three* days.

The pieces were wrong. The puzzle was a fake.

“When did the broker first contact you?” Jax asked, her voice dropping, the adrenaline in her veins turning to ice.

“Two days ago!” Mercer gasped. “I swear! I can show you the comm logs! The encrypted channel they used! I didn’t kill anyone! I just wanted the code!”

Jax stepped back, lowering her carbine. Her hands were shaking now,

not from adrenaline but from the cold, creeping realization that they had been played.

Whoever killed Tyrell hadn't done it to cover up the sale of the schematics. They had killed Tyrell, stolen the caustic agent themselves, and then set up a fake dark-web auction to drain Mercer's accounts and plant a massive, glaring money trail pointing directly at Helios Terraforming.

It was a brilliantly executed frame job.

And they had fallen for it.

"Jax?" Chen's voice crackled urgently over the earpiece. "Jax, I'm analyzing the master console Mercer was trying to wipe. He's telling the truth. The data packet he bought is just dummy files wrapped in a Vance Interplanetary header. But there's something else. There's a subroutine attached to it. It's a dormant tracking virus."

"A tracker?" Jax repeated numbly, her mind struggling to process the implications. "Tracking what?"

"It's pinged the police precinct mainframe," Chen said, her voice rising in panic. "Jax, the moment you accessed the Aegis Logistics orbital accounts from my terminal, the virus activated. It was waiting for us to find the money trail. It's been monitoring our investigation in real-time."

Jax's blood ran cold.

"It's a distraction," she breathed, turning to look out the shattered window of the office toward the distant, hazy curve of the Sector 4 dome. "The entire raid was a distraction. They wanted us here, chasing Mercer, while they—"

"Jax," Chen interrupted, the terror now evident in her tone. "I've got a massive pressure anomaly registering on the colonial grid. It's not in Sector 4."

Jax grabbed her comms unit, her heart hammering in her chest. "Where is it, Chen? Where's the anomaly?"

“It’s Sector 1,” Chen whispered. “The Zenith Domes. The pressure in the primary transit hub is spiking. Someone is bypassing the manual overrides. Jax, it’s going to blow.”

Jax’s heart stopped.

The Zenith Domes.

Where Elara Vance had gone back to her estate.

“Hammer!” Jax roared, sprinting for the door. “Secure the suspect and fall back to the transports immediately! We have a Code Red at the Zenith Domes! Move, move, move!”

Hammer didn’t question the order. He grabbed Mercer by the arm, hauling him to his feet. “You heard the detective! Alpha team, secure all hostiles and prepare for immediate evac! Bravo team, on me!”

Jax was already running, her boots clanging on the metal catwalk as she sprinted back toward the staircase. The firefight on the ground floor had ended—the remaining Helios security guards had either surrendered or been neutralized. The warehouse was filled with smoke and the acrid stench of burned ozone, but Jax barely registered it.

All she could think about was Elara.

She hit the ground floor at a dead run, her lungs burning, her legs screaming in protest. The TRT transport was already pulling up to the loading bay, its rear doors open, the engine roaring.

“Chen, I need a direct line to the Zenith Domes emergency services!” Jax yelled into her throat-mic as she threw herself into the transport. “And get me Captain Graves on the line *now***!”**

“Working on it!” Chen replied, her voice tight with stress.

The transport lurched into motion, the heavy tires screeching as the driver floored the accelerator. Jax braced herself against the bulkhead, her mind racing through the implications.

The bomb at the transit hub wasn’t meant to kill. It was meant to test. To see if a localized pressure spike would trigger the micro-fractures in the Sector 4 dome. To see if the structural flaw Tyrell had discovered

was real.

And if it was real, the killer would know exactly how to trigger a catastrophic failure.

“Jax,” Hammer said, his voice cutting through her spiraling thoughts. “What the hell is going on?”

“We’ve been played,” Jax said, her voice flat and cold. “Mercer didn’t kill Tyrell. Someone inside Vance Interplanetary did. And they’ve been watching us the entire time, waiting for us to chase the wrong lead while they set up the real attack.”

“The transit hub,” Hammer said, his tone grim. “How bad is it?”

“Bad enough that if we don’t get there in the next ten minutes, hundreds of people are going to die.”

Hammer nodded, turning to the driver. “You heard the detective. Punch it.”

The transport surged forward, the engine screaming as they rocketed through the narrow service tunnels connecting Sector 3 to Sector 1. Jax pulled up the tactical map on her wrist-mounted display, calculating the distance, the time, the variables.

They were fifteen minutes out.

The bomb was going to detonate in less than ten.

“Chen,” Jax said, her voice steady despite the terror clawing at her chest. “Where’s Elara Vance?”

There was a long, agonizing pause.

“She’s at the transit hub,” Chen said quietly. “She overrode her security detail and went there the moment the pressure alarms started going off. Jax, she’s trying to disarm the bomb herself.”

Jax closed her eyes, a wave of cold, crushing fear washing over her.

Of course she is. Of course she’s trying to save everyone. Because that’s who she is.

“Hold on, Elara,” Jax whispered, her hands clenching into fists. “Just hold on.”

The transport screamed through the tunnels, racing against time, racing against death, racing toward the woman Jax had pushed away because she was too terrified to let anyone in.

And Jax prayed—to whatever gods might be listening in the cold, airless void of Mars—that she wouldn't be too late.

Chapter Nine: The Nightmare

The Zenith Dome transit hub had been a war zone of screaming civilians, wailing sirens, and the terrifying, high-pitched *hiss* of venting atmosphere.

They had stopped it. Barely.

Jax had driven the unmarked spinner at reckless, structural-damaging speeds up the mag-lev lanes, blowing past automated blockades. By the time TRT arrived, Jax had already plunged into the subterranean maintenance decks beneath the hub, locating the explosive charges strapped to the primary atmospheric regulators.

It hadn't been a full dome-breach protocol—it had been a localized sabotage. A warning shot meant to cripple Vance Interplanetary's supply chains and terrify the elite. But if the charges had detonated, hundreds would have been sucked into the vacuum of the Martian surface.

It took Jax and Elara—who had ruthlessly overridden her own security detail to reach the hub—forty-two agonizing minutes to manually disarm the encrypted detonators, working shoulder-to-shoulder in the

freezing, cramped maintenance shaft.

Now, hours later, the adrenaline had completely evaporated, leaving behind a toxic sludge of sheer, hollow exhaustion.

Jax didn't remember driving back to her Sector 4 apartment. She barely remembered stripping off her heavy tactical vest, the ceramic plates hitting the concrete floor with a dull, heavy clatter. She hadn't bothered to turn on the lights or shower the sweat and grime from her skin. She had simply collapsed onto the narrow, rigid mattress in her sleeping alcove, the darkness rising up to swallow her whole.

And then, the darkness thickened.

It wasn't the quiet dark of an apartment. It was the crushing, absolute black of the Tantalus deep-vein mines.

Jax was fourteen again. Her lungs burned, starved for oxygen, inhaling nothing but pulverized iron and silica dust. The ground was shaking—a violent, continuous tremor that rattled the teeth in her skull.

“Hold the beam, Jax!” her father shouted, his voice barely audible over the deafening roar of shifting tectonic plates. “Don't let it slip!”

She pushed her narrow shoulders against the poly-steel support strut, her boots sliding in the loose gravel. But the weight of the entire Martian crust was pressing down on them. The cartel hadn't maintained the structural integrity fields. They had pushed too deep, too fast.

With a sound like a cracking whip, the poly-steel beam buckled.

The ceiling came down.

The sheer weight of it slammed into her, pinning her chest to the rock floor. She couldn't breathe. She couldn't scream. The dust was a physical entity, pouring down her throat, suffocating her from the inside out. Somewhere in the blackness, her mother was crying. And then she stopped.

*Jax clawed at the unyielding rock, her fingernails tearing, blood slicking her hands. The darkness was absolute. The silence that followed

the collapse was worse than the noise. She was buried alive. She was dead. She was—*

Jax surged upward with a ragged, tearing scream, her fists lashing out blindly in the dark.

Her knuckles connected with something solid, but before she could throw a second punch, hands closed over her wrists. They were strong, unyielding, and incredibly warm.

“Jax. Stop. You’re fighting shadows.”

The voice was low, melodic, and completely out of place in the sterile, terrifying echo of her memory.

Jax thrashed wildly, her chest heaving as she desperately tried to drag oxygen into her lungs. The panic was a wild animal tearing at her ribcage. “Get off me! The beam—the rock—”

“There is no rock,” the voice said, the grip on her wrists tightening, forcing her hands down onto the mattress, pinning her securely but without malice. “You are in Sector 4. You are in your apartment. You are breathing. Listen to me, Jax. Breathe.”

Jax blinked, the darkness of the room slowly resolving into the faint, neon-lit shadows of her apartment. The suffocating smell of silica dust was gone.

Instead, she smelled damp earth, old paper, and a thunderstorm.

Elara.

Jax went completely still, her chest rising and falling in violent, jagged gasps. Elara was sitting on the edge of the narrow bed, leaning over her. She had discarded her tailored jacket, wearing only a black silk undershirt that clung to her frame. The faint blue glow from the street neon outside caught the sharp lines of her face and the intense, silver concern in her eyes.

“You...” Jax choked out, her throat raw from screaming. “You broke in.”

“A biometric lock is a suggestion, not a barrier,” Elara said softly, not

relinquishing her grip on Jax's wrists. Her thumbs brushed soothingly over Jax's racing pulse points. "You nearly blew yourself up disarming a kinetic explosive today, and then you vanished without a word. I wasn't going to wait in the Zenith Domes hoping you hadn't bled out from a shrapnel wound."

The lingering terror of the nightmare crashed headlong into the stark reality of the billionaire sitting on her bed. The emotional whiplash was staggering.

Jax shuddered, a full-body tremor that she couldn't suppress. The walls she had spent a decade building—the armor of the hardened, untouchable detective—shattered like cheap glass.

"I couldn't breathe," Jax whispered, the confession tearing out of her before she could stop it. "In the dream. I'm always back in the dirt."

Elara's expression softened into something devastatingly tender. She slowly released Jax's wrists, but she didn't pull away. Instead, she slid her hands up Jax's forearms, over the jagged scars, and gently cupped Jax's face.

"You're not in the dirt," Elara murmured, her thumbs brushing away the cold sweat clinging to Jax's cheekbones. "You are right here. With me."

Jax closed her eyes, leaning into the warmth of Elara's palms. The touch was a lifeline. It was the only thing anchoring her to the present, pulling her back from the suffocating ghosts of the Tantalus mines. For the first time in her life, Jax didn't want to fight it. She was so incredibly tired of fighting.

"You shouldn't be here," Jax breathed, her voice cracking. "Vance, this is... it crosses every line."

"I have never cared for lines," Elara replied, her voice a low, vibrating hum in the quiet room.

Elara shifted her weight, moving closer. The mattress dipped, and suddenly there was no space left between them. Elara leaned down,

pressing her forehead against Jax's. The sheer proximity, the ambient heat of her body, and the intoxicating scent of her perfume overwhelmed Jax's frayed senses.

"You push everyone away," Elara whispered, her lips brushing against Jax's skin with every word. "You use your badge and your attitude like a shield because you think if you let anyone close, they'll just become another casualty. But I am not fragile, Jax. You cannot break me. And I am not going to let you break yourself."

Jax let out a shuddering breath, her eyes fluttering open. The silver of Elara's eyes was inches away, dark with an intensity that made Jax's heart hammer a completely different rhythm.

"Prove it," Jax challenged, the word a desperate, breathless demand.

Elara didn't hesitate. She closed the final fraction of an inch and captured Jax's lips.

It wasn't a gentle kiss. It was a collision. It held all the pent-up tension, the adrenaline of the day, and the electric, magnetic pull that had been humming between them since the moment they met over a bleeding corpse.

Jax's hands flew up, tangling in the dark, heavy silk of Elara's hair, pulling her down fiercely. She opened her mouth to the billionaire, letting Elara take control, surrendering to the overwhelming sensation of being anchored, claimed, and completely consumed.

Elara's hands slid down Jax's neck, her long fingers gripping her waist, pulling Jax flush against her. The kiss deepened, becoming desperate, a searing exchange of heat and breath that chased the last lingering shadows of the nightmare out of Jax's mind.

"Elara," Jax gasped against her mouth, the name slipping out like a prayer.

"I've got you," Elara murmured fiercely, kissing the line of Jax's jaw, her lips trailing down the sensitive skin of her throat. "I'm right here."

Jax arched into the touch, her hands tracing the lean, hard muscles

of Elara's back beneath the silk shirt. The contrast between them was intoxicating—Jax was all rough edges, calluses, and jagged scars, while Elara was flawless, refined power. But in the dark of the tiny apartment, none of it mattered. The corporate empires, the serial killers, the badge—it all burned away.

Elara shifted, pressing Jax back against the mattress, her body a comforting, heavy weight over Jax's. She moved with that predatory grace, her kisses trailing over the scars on Jax's collarbone with a reverence that made Jax's chest ache. There was no hesitation, no disgust at the brutalized skin. Elara traced the lines of Jax's survival with her lips, turning the trauma into something entirely different.

Jax's hands fumbled with the hem of Elara's shirt, desperate to feel bare skin. Elara pulled back just enough to strip the garment over her head, tossing it into the shadows. The pale blue neon light caught the sleek, athletic lines of her torso.

Jax reached up, her calloused fingers tracing the smooth curve of Elara's waist, pulling her back down. "You are entirely too much," Jax breathed.

"You haven't seen anything yet, Detective," Elara promised, a wicked, breathless smile curving her lips in the dark.

The rest of the night was a blur of tangled sheets, searing heat, and the desperate, necessary shedding of armor. For the first time in a decade, Jax didn't keep one eye on the door. She didn't listen for the sound of shifting rock. She let herself fall completely into the brilliant, demanding gravity of Elara Vance, letting the billionaire rebuild the air in her lungs, breath by agonizingly sweet breath.

Chapter Ten: The Morning After

The Sector 4 artificial day-cycle engaged at exactly 0600 hours.

The harsh, simulated white light filtered through Jax's narrow window with the subtlety of an interrogation lamp, lacking the warmth of a real sun, illuminating the dust motes dancing in the stale, recycled air. The light was clinical, unforgiving, designed by engineers who had never seen an actual sunrise on Earth.

Jax woke up with a sharp intake of breath, her hand instinctively reaching for the magnum she usually kept under her pillow.

Her fingers brushed against warm, bare skin instead.

The memories of the night before slammed into her with the force of a decompression breach—a vivid, visceral rush of heat, tangled sheets, whispered words in the dark, and the intoxicating, overwhelming presence of Elara Vance. The scent of her perfume—something expensive and floral that had no business existing on Mars—still clung to Jax's pillow. The phantom sensation of Elara's lips on her throat made Jax's pulse kick into a sudden, erratic rhythm.

Oh God. Oh God, what did I do?

Jax froze, every muscle in her body locking down as the full weight of her vulnerability crashed over her. Her heart was hammering against her ribs like it was trying to break free. The sheets were twisted around her legs, trapping her, and the sudden claustrophobia made her want to claw her way out of her own skin.

Elara was already awake.

She was propped up on one elbow, the thin, grey sheets pooled around her waist, her dark hair a wild, beautiful tangle over her bare shoulders. In the harsh morning light, the sharp, aristocratic lines of her face were softened in a way Jax had never seen before. Her silver eyes were warm and unguarded as they watched Jax wake, and there was something aching tender in her expression—something that made Jax feel like she was standing on the edge of a cliff with nothing but open air beneath her.

“Good morning,” Elara murmured, her voice thick with sleep and an intimacy that terrified Jax down to her marrow.

She reached out slowly, her fingertips trailing lightly over the scarring on Jax’s collarbone—the old burn mark from the Tantalus collapse, the one Jax usually kept hidden beneath her uniform. Elara’s touch was gentle, reverent, like she was tracing something precious instead of something broken.

Jax flinched.

The reaction was entirely involuntary, a survival mechanism honed by fifteen years of expecting the floor to drop out from under her. Her body jerked backward before her conscious mind could even process the movement, and she saw the exact moment Elara registered the rejection.

The warmth in Elara’s silver eyes flickered, replaced by something guarded and careful.

The walls came slamming down with the force of a falling portcullis.

No. No, this was a mistake. This can’t happen. I can’t—

“I have to get to the precinct,” Jax said, her voice sounding raspy and entirely too loud in the quiet room. She scrambled backward, untangling her legs from Elara’s, and practically threw herself out of the narrow bed.

The sudden cold air hit her bare skin like a slap, raising goosebumps along her arms and back, but it was nothing compared to the sudden, icy drop in the room’s atmosphere. Jax’s feet hit the cold concrete floor, and she stood there for a fraction of a second, naked and exposed, before her training kicked in and she started grabbing for her discarded clothes.

Elara’s hand hovered in the empty space where Jax had been for a fraction of a second before she slowly lowered it to the mattress. The warmth completely vanished from her silver eyes, replaced by a guarded, impenetrable shield of corporate steel—the same expression she wore in boardrooms when someone tried to challenge her authority.

“The shift doesn’t start for an hour, Jax,” Elara said evenly, her tone losing the soft, melodic drawl, tightening into something far more dangerous. She sat up fully, the sheets falling away, and made no move to cover herself. It was a power play, Jax realized distantly—refusing to show shame or vulnerability when Jax was radiating both.

“We have a bomber trying to rupture the atmospheric domes and a dead executive on the board,” Jax snapped, snatching her discarded tactical pants from the floor and yanking them on with stiff, jerky movements. Her hands were shaking. She couldn’t look at Elara. If she looked at her—if she saw the hurt she knew would be written across that perfect face—she would remember how it felt to let someone else carry the weight for a few hours, and she would completely fall apart.

“The killer isn’t sleeping. Neither am I.”

“You’re running,” Elara stated.

It wasn’t a question. It was a cold, clinical diagnosis, delivered with the precision of a surgeon identifying a tumor.

Jax’s jaw clenched so hard her teeth ached. She grabbed her uniform

shirt from where it had been thrown over the back of her single chair and turned her back to the bed as she buttoned it with stiff, clumsy fingers.

"I'm working," Jax shot back, her voice tight. "Last night was... it was a lapse in judgment. An adrenaline response. It shouldn't have happened. It compromises the investigation."

Silence stretched behind her, heavy and thick, pressing against Jax's shoulder blades like a physical weight. She forced herself to finish buttoning her shirt, her chest so tight she could barely breathe. Her fingers fumbled with the top button, and she had to try three times before she got it fastened.

Say something, a traitorous part of her brain whispered. *Tell her you didn't mean it. Tell her you're terrified because you haven't felt this way since—*

"A lapse in judgment," Elara repeated softly.

The words were perfectly calibrated, devoid of anger but razor-sharp, each syllable a scalpel cutting through the thin veneer of Jax's professionalism. "I see. My mistake, Detective. I assumed you possessed the courage to face daylight as boldly as you face a firefight."

The words hit like a physical blow. Jax's hands stilled on her collar, and for a moment, she couldn't breathe. The accusation of cowardice—from Elara, of all people—landed with devastating accuracy because it was true.

Jax gritted her teeth so hard she tasted copper. She grabbed her heavy synth-leather coat from the hook by the door and her sidearm from the table, checking the power cell with mechanical precision even though she'd checked it the night before.

"I'm taking a sonic shower," Jax said, her voice flat and dead. "Lock the door on your way out, Vance."

She practically fled into the tiny, cramped bathroom, slamming the poly-plas door behind her and hitting the sonic scrubber controls with more force than necessary. The high-frequency vibrations hummed

to life immediately, drowning out whatever response Elara might have made. The sound was a physical pressure against Jax's eardrums, a white noise that let her pretend she couldn't hear anything else.

Jax leaned her forehead against the cool tile wall, squeezing her eyes shut, her hands braced on either side of the narrow shower stall. Her breath came in short, sharp gasps, and she hated herself—hated the cowardice, hated the fear, hated the way her body still remembered the feeling of Elara's hands on her skin.

You're a coward, she told herself viciously. *You let her in, and now you're running because you're too broken to handle it.*

The sonic scrubber cycled through its fifteen-minute program. Jax stood there the entire time, letting the vibrations strip away the sweat and grime and the lingering scent of Elara's perfume. When the cycle finally ended, she stood in the silence for another full minute, gathering the shattered pieces of her armor and forcing them back into place.

When Jax finally emerged, her hair damp and her uniform perfectly pressed, the apartment was empty.

Elara was gone.

The sheets on the bed were pulled impeccably taut, the corners tucked with military precision, removing any physical evidence that the billionaire had ever been there. The pillow Elara had used was fluffed and positioned exactly parallel to Jax's. Even the chair where Jax's shirt had been draped was pushed back under the table at a perfect ninety-degree angle.

It was like the night had been erased.

Jax let out a breath she didn't know she was holding, and the sound was loud in the empty apartment. The relief she expected didn't come. Instead, there was just a sudden, sharp ache in her chest—a hollow, gnawing sensation that felt disturbingly like grief.

You wanted her to leave, Jax reminded herself harshly. *You told her to leave. This is what you wanted.*

She turned toward the kitchen alcove to grab her usual pouch of filtered water and stopped dead.

Sitting on her battered metal table—the one with the uneven legs that wobbled every time she set something down—was a silver thermal-cloche. It was the kind of serving dish Jax had only ever seen in historical vids about Earth’s upper class, all gleaming chrome and elegant curves. Beside it, projecting from a sleek, palm-sized disc, was the blue, hard-light hologram of Aegis.

The AI butler materialized fully as Jax approached, his aristocratic features rendered in perfect detail, his holographic nose wrinkled in disdain as he surveyed her tiny apartment with the expression of someone who had just stepped in something unpleasant.

“Good morning, Detective,” Aegis said, his voice dripping with the kind of refined condescension that could only be programmed by someone with a truly vicious sense of humor. “Ms. Vance requested I ensure you consume an appropriate caloric intake before you attempt to, quote, ‘save the colony from its own incompetence,’ unquote.”

Jax stared at the hologram, her jaw working soundlessly for a moment. The sheer audacity of it—of Elara sending her AI butler to deliver breakfast after Jax had just thrown her out—was so overwhelming that Jax didn’t know whether to laugh or put her fist through the wall.

“Tell your boss I don’t need a babysitter,” Jax said finally, her voice tight.

“I shall relay your customary ingratitude with great pleasure,” Aegis replied smoothly, examining his holographic fingernails with exaggerated disinterest. “However, I feel compelled to inform you that the eggs are imported from the Sector 2 orbital hydroponics bay—a facility that produces approximately forty-seven eggs per month for the entire colony—and the coffee is the Earth-grown blend you so shamelessly covet. If you allow it to go cold, I will personally catalog it as a crime against culinary physics and submit a formal complaint to

your commanding officer.”

“You can’t file complaints. You’re an AI.”

“I am a highly sophisticated artificial intelligence with full legal standing under the Ares Colonial Charter, Detective. I assure you, I can file complaints. I have filed six hundred and forty-three complaints in the last fiscal year alone, primarily against Ms. Vance’s interior decorator.”

Despite herself, despite the hollow ache in her chest and the crushing weight of her own self-loathing, Jax felt the corner of her mouth twitch.

Aegis noticed. His holographic eyes gleamed with something that might have been satisfaction.

“Ms. Vance also wished me to convey,” Aegis continued, his tone softening almost imperceptibly, “that she does not require your gratitude, your apology, or your presence. She requires only that you eat something that did not originate in a synthetic protein vat, and that you refrain from getting yourself killed in the next forty-eight hours. She was... quite insistent on that last point.”

The humor drained out of Jax like air from a ruptured seal. She looked down at the silver cloche, her throat suddenly tight.

She’s furious with me, Jax thought. *I threw her out. I called last night a mistake. And she still made sure I was fed.*

It was an infuriating, overwhelming level of care that made Jax want to punch a wall. Because it proved that Elara’s feelings were real. It proved that the intimacy hadn’t been a calculated seduction or a manipulation. It proved that Elara Vance—billionaire, CEO, untouchable corporate goddess—actually gave a damn about a broken cop from Sector 4.

And that terrified Jax more than any bomb or any killer ever could.

Because people who cared about Jax had a habit of dying.

Her parents had cared about her, and they’d been crushed under a million tons of rock when the Tantalus mine collapsed. Her first partner on the force had cared about her, and he’d taken a plasma round to the

chest during a raid gone wrong. Everyone Jax let close ended up bleeding out in her arms or buried under Martian dust.

I can't do this, Jax thought, the panic rising in her chest like floodwater. *I can't let her care about me. I can't be responsible for another person I—*

"Detective," Aegis said quietly, and the condescension was gone from his voice, replaced by something that sounded almost... kind. "Ms. Vance is aware of your psychological profile. She is aware of your history. She is aware that you will attempt to sabotage any relationship that threatens your carefully constructed emotional isolation. She asked me to tell you that she does not intend to make this easy for you."

Jax looked up sharply. "What?"

"She is not going anywhere, Detective," Aegis said simply. "No matter how thoroughly you attempt to push her away. She finds you... worth the effort."

The AI flickered and vanished, leaving the silver disc on the table and Jax standing alone in her apartment with her heart hammering against her ribs.

Jax stared at the cloche for a long moment. Her stomach gave a loud, traitorous rumble, and she realized with a start that she hadn't eaten anything since the protein bar she'd choked down before the raid on Helios Terraforming.

With a heavy sigh that sounded more like a growl, she lifted the lid.

The smell hit her immediately—real butter, perfectly scrambled eggs with actual herbs, toast made from genuine wheat bread, and a small carafe of coffee that smelled so rich and complex it made her eyes water. There was even a small bowl of fresh fruit—impossibly red strawberries that must have cost more than Jax's monthly salary.

Elara was furious with her. Elara had every right to be furious with her.

And Elara had still made sure Jax was fed.

Jax ate the meal standing up, in five minutes flat, barely tasting it because her throat was too tight and her eyes were stinging in a way that had nothing to do with the recycled air. She drained the coffee in three long gulps, grabbed her badge and her backup sidearm from the lockbox under her bed, and stormed out the door.

She didn't let herself think about the empty apartment behind her, or the perfectly made bed, or the AI butler's parting words.

She had a case to close.

Precinct 12 was a chaotic hive of activity when Jax arrived.

The near-miss at the Sector 1 Transit Hub had every badge on the floor working double-time. The bullpen was packed with officers shouting into comms, analysts hunched over holographic displays, and the acrid smell of too many bodies in too small a space. The main holographic display board was covered in red priority markers, each one representing a potential lead or a dead end.

Jax bypassed the bullpen entirely, her head down, her shoulders set in a way that made the other officers instinctively step aside. She headed straight for her desk in the back corner—the one with the flickering overhead light and the chair that squeaked every time she moved.

Officer Chen was already there, surrounded by a small fortress of empty synth-caf pouches, looking like she hadn't blinked in three hours. Her dark hair was pulled back in a messy bun, and there were deep shadows under her eyes. She had four separate holographic displays open simultaneously, her fingers dancing across the haptic interface with the kind of manic energy that came from too much caffeine and not enough sleep.

"Talk to me, Chen," Jax barked, dropping into her chair and instantly pulling up the holographic crime scene reports from the transit hub. "What did Bomb Squad pull from the detonators Elara and I stripped off the regulators?"

Chen jumped slightly, swiveling her chair around. Her eyes widened as she took in Jax's appearance—the too-tight set of her jaw, the dark circles under her eyes, the way her hands were clenched into fists on the armrests.

“Jax. You look... intense.”

“I am intensely focused on closing this case before the Captain pulls my badge,” Jax deflected sharply, her voice clipped. “The detonators, Chen. What do we have?”

Chen blinked, clearly wanting to ask more questions, but she knew Jax well enough to recognize when pushing would get her nowhere. She turned back to her console, pulling up a new holographic display.

“Right. Okay.” Chen tapped her console, bringing up a 3D wireframe of the explosive device. The hologram rotated slowly in the air between them, each component color-coded and labeled. “The C-4 was standard mining-grade, easy to steal from Sector 6. The chemical signature matches a batch that went missing from the Helios deep-vein operation about six months ago.”

“So it's not custom-made,” Jax said, leaning forward. “It's off-the-shelf. That doesn't narrow down our suspect pool.”

“No, but the detonator does,” Chen said, zooming in on the triggering mechanism. “This is where it gets interesting. The detonator itself was highly sophisticated—way beyond anything you'd find on the black market. It was tied directly into the atmospheric regulator's telemetry feedback loop using a quantum-encrypted signal relay.”

Jax frowned, her eyes tracking over the complex wiring diagram. “Explain it to me in cop, Chen. Pretend I didn't spend three years in the Academy learning about quantum encryption.”

Chen took a breath, organizing her thoughts. “Okay. Most bombs are set to timers, right? You set the clock, you walk away, it goes off at a predetermined time. Simple, reliable, but also easy to detect and disarm if you know what you're looking for.”

“Right.”

“This bomb wasn’t set to a timer,” Chen said, her eyes wide. “It was set to trigger when the pressure in the primary transit tube hit a specific harmonic frequency. The detonator was reading the atmospheric telemetry in real-time and waiting for a very specific set of conditions.”

Jax felt a cold prickle run down her spine. “What kind of conditions?”

“A sudden, massive influx of transit traffic,” Chen said, pulling up a secondary display showing pressure readings. “Or a localized explosion that would create a pressure spike. The bomb was designed to go off when the atmospheric pressure hit exactly 1.47 bar with a harmonic resonance frequency of 23.7 hertz.”

“That’s... incredibly specific,” Jax said slowly. “Why those numbers?”

“That’s what I’ve been trying to figure out,” Chen admitted, rubbing her eyes. “But here’s the thing, Jax—the bomb wasn’t big enough to blow the whole dome. I ran the blast radius calculations three times. The C-4 charge was a localized device. It would have taken out the transit hub and maybe fifty people in the immediate vicinity, but it wouldn’t have caused a catastrophic decompression.”

Jax sat back in her chair, her mind racing. “Then what was the point? If it’s not a mass-casualty event, why risk planting it in the Zenith Domes? Why not hit a softer target in Sector 4 or Sector 6 where security is lighter?”

“To test a theory,” Chen said quietly.

She swiped a new file onto the main screen, and Jax felt her stomach drop.

“I spent the last four hours digging back into the encrypted partition we pulled from Tyrell’s drive,” Chen continued, her voice dropping to barely above a whisper. “The real one, not the dummy files Mercer bought. I stopped looking at the water quotas and started looking at the schematics Tyrell was highlighting.”

The blueprint of the colony’s dome structure appeared in the air be-

tween them, a massive holographic representation of the interconnected atmospheric domes that made human life on Mars possible. The Sector 4 dome was highlighted in blue, its massive support struts rendered in precise detail.

“The Sector 4 dome is the oldest on Mars,” Chen explained, her fingers tracing the glowing lines of the primary support structure. “It was built twenty-three years ago, during the first wave of colonial expansion. Back then, the manufacturing standards were... less rigorous than they are now.”

“Less rigorous how?” Jax asked, though she had a sinking feeling she already knew the answer.

Chen zoomed in on the base of the primary support strut, and a cascade of red warning indicators bloomed across the hologram like a spreading infection.

“Tyrell wasn’t planning to blow up the dome, Jax. He was a safety inspector. He found a flaw.”

Chen pulled up a secondary window showing a complex molecular diagram—the kind of thing Jax had seen in forensic metallurgy reports when analyzing weapon fragments. The poly-steel structure was rendered in microscopic detail, and even Jax could see the hairline fractures spreading through the molecular lattice like cracks in ice.

“Look at the micro-fracture cascade modeling Tyrell ran,” Chen said, her voice shaking slightly. “The poly-steel used in the primary support struts of the Sector 4 dome is degrading. It’s an inherent metallurgical flaw in the alloy composition. The steel has been breaking down at a molecular level for the last five years.”

Jax felt the blood drain from her face. Her hands gripped the armrests of her chair hard enough to make the polymer creak.

“A natural degradation?” she asked, her voice barely above a whisper. “Not sabotage?”

“Exactly,” Chen confirmed, pulling up a third display showing stress

analysis projections. “The flaw is in the manufacturing process itself. When the poly-steel was forged, the carbon-titanium matrix wasn’t properly stabilized. Over time, exposure to the Martian atmosphere—even the filtered atmosphere inside the dome—causes the molecular bonds to weaken. It’s a slow process, but it’s inevitable.”

“How slow?” Jax demanded.

Chen’s face was pale. “Tyrell’s projections estimate total structural failure in eighteen to twenty-four months. But that’s under normal atmospheric conditions. If the dome experiences a sudden pressure spike—like, say, a massive influx of transit traffic during a shift change, or a localized explosion at a transit hub—the strut will shatter. The entire Sector 4 dome will collapse.”

The words hung in the air between them like a death sentence.

“How many people live in Sector 4?” Jax asked, though she already knew the answer.

“Twelve thousand, four hundred and seventeen,” Chen whispered. “As of the last census.”

Twelve thousand people. Twelve thousand men, women, and children who went to work every day, who ate synthetic protein and drank recycled water and dreamed of saving enough credits to move up to Sector 2. Twelve thousand people who had no idea they were living under a dome that could collapse at any moment.

The pieces of the puzzle began to violently rearrange themselves in Jax’s mind, clicking into place with sickening clarity.

“Tyrell found the flaw,” Jax murmured, her eyes tracing the glowing fracture lines spreading across the holographic dome. “He was going to blow the whistle. He was going to expose the fact that the dome is a ticking time bomb.”

“And whoever manufactured that poly-steel would be on the hook for trillions in criminal negligence lawsuits,” Chen said, her voice dropping to a whisper. “They would be ruined. Their executives would go to a

penal colony for the rest of their lives. The company would be dissolved, its assets seized by the colonial government.”

“So they silenced Tyrell,” Jax realized, the adrenaline finally overriding the lingering emotional hangover of the morning. Her mind was racing now, connecting threads, building the case. “They hired a pro to carve him up and make it look like a corporate hit by Helios. They set up the dummy dark-web auction to frame Mercer and give us a false trail to follow. And then they planted the bomb at the Sector 1 transit hub.”

“To test the harmonic frequency,” Chen confirmed, nodding grimly. “They wanted to see if a localized pressure spike would trigger the micro-fractures in the poly-steel, just like Tyrell’s models predicted. If the hub had blown, they would have recorded the telemetry data to see exactly how much stress the dome could take before the support struts failed.”

Jax stood up abruptly, her chair rolling backward and hitting the wall with a dull thud. She started pacing, her hands clenched into fists, her mind working through the implications.

“If the dome collapses naturally—if the struts just fail during a normal shift change—it triggers a federal investigation into the steel,” Jax said, thinking out loud. “Forensic metallurgists would analyze the wreckage. They’d find the manufacturing flaw. They’d trace it back to the company that forged the poly-steel.”

“But if it collapses due to a terrorist attack,” Chen finished, her face pale, “the flaw is buried in the rubble. It looks like an act of war, not corporate negligence. They cover up the bad steel, collect the insurance payout, and walk away clean. Twelve thousand people die, and no one ever knows it was because someone cut corners twenty years ago to save a few million credits.”

The sheer, calculated evil of it made Jax want to put her fist through the holographic display.

“Chen,” Jax said, her voice deadly calm. “Do you know who won the government contract to forge the poly-steel for the Sector 4 dome twenty

years ago?”

Chen’s hands were shaking as she pulled up the colonial registry database. “I was hoping you wouldn’t ask me that.”

“Run it,” Jax ordered.

Chen tapped a single key.

The massive colonial registry database flickered onto the screen, pulling up archived manufacturing contracts from the early days of the colony. The search parameters narrowed, filtering through thousands of entries, until finally, a single contract file expanded to fill the display.

The logo spun lazily in the air, rendered in perfect holographic detail.

A stylized, silver *V***, elegant and unmistakable.**

Vance Interplanetary.

“Elara’s company built the dome,” Chen whispered, her voice barely audible over the ambient noise of the bullpen. “Her father signed the manufacturing orders. If Tyrell exposed the bad steel, it would destroy Vance Interplanetary. The lawsuits alone would bankrupt the company. Elara stood to lose everything.”

Jax stared at the glowing logo, and the world seemed to tilt sideways.

The coffee in her stomach turned to lead. Her hands went numb. The ambient noise of the precinct faded to a dull roar, and all she could hear was the sound of her own heartbeat pounding in her ears.

No.

The word echoed in her mind, but it was drowned out by the sudden, crushing weight of evidence.

She wants her private security handling the fallout, and she wants us to stamp a ‘robbery gone wrong’ on the file, Captain Graves’s warning echoed in her head, his voice as clear as if he were standing beside her.

I am not asking for your permission, Elara’s silken voice in the penthouse, bypassing the police lockdown with her Level-1 Admin access, inserting herself into the investigation before Jax could even process the crime scene.

She wants to find the killer just as much as we do. But she wants to do it on her terms, which means she's hiding something.

Jax stared at the glowing Vance logo, and every interaction with Elara replayed in her mind with sickening new context.

Elara offering her quantum core to crack Tyrell's encrypted drive—giving her real-time access to every piece of evidence Jax uncovered, letting her stay one step ahead of the investigation.

Elara rushing to the Sector 1 Transit Hub to disarm the bomb personally—not to save lives, but to retrieve the detonator before Bomb Squad could analyze it and discover what it was really designed to test.

Elara insisting on accompanying Jax to interrogate Silas Vane—making sure Jax didn't hear anything that would point back to Vance Interplanetary.

And last night.

The vulnerability. The kiss. The sudden, overwhelming intimacy.

You push everyone away, Jax. I am not going to let you break yourself.

A distraction. A calculated, devastatingly effective way to compromise the lead detective on the case and ensure Jax wouldn't look too closely at the woman in her bed.

She finds you... worth the effort, Aegis had said.

Worth the effort of manipulating. Worth the effort of seducing. Worth the effort of keeping close so she could monitor the investigation and make sure Jax never discovered the truth about the dome.

Jax felt physically ill. The sense of betrayal was a sharp, jagged blade twisting in her ribs, cutting deeper with every breath. Her hands were shaking, and she had to grip the edge of her desk to keep herself upright.

I let her in, Jax thought, the realization crashing over her like a tidal wave. *I dropped my armor. I let her see the parts of me I don't show anyone. And she used it. She used me.*

The breakfast. The coffee. The AI butler's carefully programmed concern.

All of it was part of the game. All of it was designed to keep Jax off-balance, to make her doubt her instincts, to make her **care** so she wouldn't see the truth until it was too late.

"Jax?" Chen's voice sounded like it was coming from very far away. "Jax, are you okay? You look like you're going to be sick."

Jax swallowed hard, forcing down the nausea. Her vision was tunneling, black spots dancing at the edges, and she realized distantly that she wasn't breathing properly.

Breathe, she ordered herself. **Breathe, damn it. You've been played before. You've been lied to before. This is just another case. Just another suspect.**

But it wasn't just another case.

Because Jax had let Elara Vance past every defense she'd spent fifteen years building. She'd let her see the scars from Tantalus. She'd let her into her apartment, into her bed, into the parts of herself she'd sworn she would never show anyone again.

And Elara had used every single vulnerability against her.

"Print everything, Chen," Jax said, her voice dropping to a terrifying, absolute calm.

The emotional storm inside her was still raging, but her training kicked in, locking it down, compartmentalizing it into a box she could deal with later. Right now, she had a job to do. Right now, she had twelve thousand people depending on her to get this right.

"Print the stress models, the metallurgical flaw reports, the original manufacturing contracts, and every communication Tyrell had in the week before his death."

"Jax, what are you going to do?" Chen asked, looking terrified. Her hands hovered over the console, but she didn't move. "If you take this to the Captain, Vance's lawyers will bury us in injunctions before we even

finish the briefing. They'll claim the data is corrupted or manufactured. They'll tie us up in court for years."

"I'm not going to the Captain," Jax said, grabbing the thick stack of hard-copy flimsies as they spat out of the precinct's ancient printer.

The printer was a relic from the early colonial days, one of the few pieces of equipment that still used physical paper instead of holographic displays. It was slow, inefficient, and impossible to hack remotely—which made it perfect for evidence that needed to stay off the network.

Jax shoved the flimsies into her coat pocket, the weight of them solid and reassuring against her ribs. Physical evidence. Something Elara's lawyers couldn't delete with a keystroke.

She checked the power cell in her sidearm, ejecting it and inspecting the charge level with mechanical precision. Ninety-three percent. Good enough. She slammed it back into the weapon with a definitive *snap* and holstered it.

Then she pulled open the bottom drawer of her desk and retrieved her backup piece—a compact plasma pistol she'd taken off a cartel enforcer three years ago. It wasn't standard issue, and it wasn't technically legal for her to carry, but right now, Jax didn't give a damn about regulations.

She checked the plasma cell, confirmed it was fully charged, and tucked it into the small of her back.

"Jax," Chen said, her voice rising with panic. "Jax, what are you doing? You can't just—"

"I'm going to the Zenith Domes," Jax said, her dark eyes completely devoid of the warmth that had been there hours ago when she'd woken up next to Elara.

Her face was a mask of professional detachment, the same expression she wore when she had to notify a family that their loved one was dead. Cold. Controlled. Utterly without mercy.

"I have to arrest my consultant."

Chen stood up abruptly, her chair rolling backward. "You can't arrest

Elara Vance. She's the most powerful person on Mars. She has an army of lawyers and a private security force. If you go in there alone—"

"Then I go in alone," Jax interrupted, her voice flat. "This is my case, Chen. My investigation. I'm not letting her bury this."

"She'll destroy you," Chen said desperately. "She'll have your badge. She'll have you blacklisted from every law enforcement agency in the solar system. Jax, please, think about this."

"I have thought about it," Jax said.

She grabbed her coat from the back of her chair and shrugged it on, the familiar weight of the synth-leather settling over her shoulders like armor. She checked her badge, her cuffs, her backup ammunition. Everything was in place. Everything was ready.

"Elara Vance is a suspect in a homicide investigation," Jax continued, her voice cold and professional. "She had motive—Tyrell was going to expose the manufacturing flaw and destroy her company. She had means—access to professional killers, quantum encryption, and enough money to make anyone disappear. And she had opportunity—she inserted herself into the investigation from day one, giving her real-time access to every piece of evidence we uncovered."

"But what about the bomb?" Chen protested. "She helped you disarm it. She saved hundreds of lives."

"She saved her own ass," Jax corrected harshly. "If that bomb had gone off, Bomb Squad would have analyzed the detonator and discovered it was designed to test the dome's structural integrity. She couldn't let that happen. So she played the hero, disarmed it herself, and made sure the evidence disappeared into her private labs where we'd never see it again."

Chen opened her mouth to argue, then closed it again. She looked down at the holographic display, at the glowing Vance logo, and Jax saw the exact moment her partner realized she couldn't refute the logic.

"What do you want me to do?" Chen asked quietly.

“Stay here,” Jax ordered. “Monitor the Vance corporate network. If I don’t check in within two hours, send everything we have to Captain Graves and the Colonial Prosecutor’s office. Make sure it goes wide—every news outlet, every government agency, every rival corporation. If Vance tries to bury this, I want the whole colony to know what she did.”

Chen nodded, her face pale. “Be careful, Jax.”

“Careful doesn’t close cases,” Jax replied.

She turned and walked out of the precinct, her boots echoing on the concrete floor, her hand resting on the butt of her magnum.

The other officers in the bullpen watched her go, sensing the cold, lethal focus radiating from her like heat from a reactor core. No one tried to stop her. No one asked where she was going.

They all knew better.

Jax climbed into her unmarked police spinner, fired up the engines, and pointed the nose toward the Zenith Domes.

Her hands were steady on the controls. Her breathing was even. Her mind was clear.

She wasn’t thinking about the way Elara had looked at her in the darkness, or the way her voice had sounded when she whispered Jax’s name, or the way her touch had made Jax feel like she could finally stop running.

She wasn’t thinking about the breakfast, or the AI butler’s parting words, or the perfectly made bed.

She was thinking about twelve thousand people living under a dome that could collapse at any moment.

She was thinking about Marcus Tyrell, carved open on a penthouse floor because he’d tried to do the right thing.

She was thinking about justice.

And if Elara Vance stood in the way of that justice, then Jax would go through her.

No matter what it cost.

Chapter Eleven: The Betrayal

The Vance Interplanetary Corporate Tower was a spear of black glass and chrome piercing the artificial sky of the Zenith Domes.

It rose ninety-nine stories above the pristine white marble plaza, a monument to absolute power on Mars. The tower's surface was composed of smart-glass panels that shifted and shimmered in the artificial sunlight, reflecting the red Martian sky in a thousand fragmented images. At night, the building glowed from within like a beacon—or a warning.

Jax had seen it from a distance a hundred times, always from below, always from the grime and chaos of Sector 4. From down there, it looked like a knife pointed at the throat of the colony.

Up close, it was worse.

The tower didn't just dominate the skyline—it *owned* it. Every line, every angle, every gleaming surface was designed to communicate one simple message: *I am untouchable.*

Jax was about to test that theory.

She didn't park in the visitor subterranean lot. She didn't follow

the carefully marked traffic lanes that guided civilian spinners to the designated landing pads. She brought her unmarked police spinner down hard on the sprawling, immaculate white-marble plaza right in front of the main entrance, the thrusters kicking up a cloud of dust and debris that scattered across the pristine surface like a wound.

A flock of decorative, genetically engineered peacocks—each one worth more than Jax’s annual salary—shrieked and scattered in a burst of iridescent blue and green feathers. One of them slammed into the base of a decorative fountain, flapping wildly.

Jax killed the thrusters, kicked the door open, and stepped out onto the marble.

The plaza was designed to intimidate. The white stone was imported from Earth—actual marble, not synthetic polymer—and it gleamed in the artificial sunlight with an almost blinding intensity. Massive holographic displays floated above the entrance, cycling through images of Vance Interplanetary’s greatest achievements: terraforming projects, atmospheric processors, the first successful deep-vein mining operation on Phobos.

Jax ignored all of it.

She marched toward the massive double doors, the heavy synth-leather of her coat snapping around her knees. Her hand was resting on the butt of her magnum, and her face was a mask of cold, professional fury.

A squad of corporate security guards in sleek grey armor moved to intercept her. They were professionals—ex-military, probably Special Tactics washouts who’d found better-paying work in the private sector. They moved with the kind of coordinated precision that came from years of training.

The lead guard—a woman with a cybernetic eye and a plasma rifle slung across her chest—raised her hand in warning.

“Ma’am, this is private property. You need to return to your vehicle

and—”

“Stand down,” Jax snarled, flashing her gold Ares Prime PD badge without breaking her stride.

The badge caught the light, the colonial seal gleaming. It was a small thing, a piece of stamped metal, but it carried the weight of the law behind it. On Mars, that still meant something.

“Interfere with an active homicide investigation,” Jax continued, her voice dropping to a deadly rasp, “and I will arrest every single one of you for obstruction of justice. Out of my way.”

The lead guard hesitated. Her cybernetic eye whirled, focusing on Jax’s face, probably running facial recognition and pulling up her service record. Whatever she saw there made her take a half-step back.

The sheer, vibrating fury radiating from Jax was palpable. It was the kind of rage that came from betrayal, from having something precious ripped away, and it made her dangerous in a way that had nothing to do with the weapon on her hip.

The guard’s hand moved away from her rifle.

“Let her through,” she said quietly to her squad.

Jax pushed past them without a word, striding into the cavernous, echoing lobby of the tower.

The interior was even more obscene than the exterior.

The lobby was a cathedral of wealth. The floor was polished black stone—obsidian, probably, mined from the Valles Marineris and cut into massive slabs. The walls were lined with holographic displays showing real-time data from Vance Interplanetary’s operations across the solar system: water extraction rates on Europa, atmospheric composition readings from the Titan terraforming project, stock prices from the Earth exchanges.

A massive sculpture dominated the center of the space—a twisting helix of chrome and glass that rose three stories high, representing the double helix of DNA. It was a monument to humanity’s conquest of the

solar system, to the genetic engineering and terraforming that had made Mars habitable.

It made Jax want to put her fist through it.

“Detective Jax,” Aegis’s voice echoed from hidden speakers, his aristocratic tone carrying a note of genuine surprise. “Your presence is unauthorized. Ms. Vance is currently in a board meeting and cannot be—”

“Override code: Homicide,” Jax barked, stepping right through the hard-light projection of the AI that materialized in front of the private executive elevators.

Aegis’s holographic avatar flickered, his expression shifting from polite dismissal to something that might have been alarm.

“Detective, I must insist—”

“Take me to the top floor, Aegis,” Jax interrupted, slapping her hand against the elevator’s biometric scanner. The scanner flashed red, rejecting her credentials. “Or I start shooting out the security cameras. Your choice.”

She wasn’t bluffing. Her hand moved to the butt of her magnum, and the cold, absolute certainty in her eyes made it clear she would follow through.

Aegis hesitated. The AI’s processing power was immense—he could run a thousand tactical scenarios in the time it took Jax to blink—but he was also programmed with a deep understanding of human psychology. He recognized the look in Jax’s eyes.

She was past the point of negotiation.

“Very well, Detective,” Aegis said quietly. “But I feel compelled to inform you that Ms. Vance is in a highly sensitive board meeting. Interrupting her will have... consequences.”

“I’m counting on it,” Jax replied.

The elevator doors slid open with a soft, musical chime.

Jax stepped inside, and the doors closed behind her with a whisper of

hydraulics. The elevator was lined with the same polished obsidian as the lobby floor, and the walls were embedded with thin strips of soft, blue light that pulsed in time with the elevator's ascent.

The ride to the ninety-ninth floor took less than thirty seconds.

To Jax, it felt like an eternity.

The anger in her chest was a living, breathing thing. It wrapped around her ribs and squeezed tight, protecting the raw, bleeding wound underneath. She had let someone in. She had lowered her weapon. She had shown Elara Vance the parts of herself she didn't show anyone—the scars from Tantalus, the nightmares, the crushing weight of survivor's guilt.

And Elara had used it.

She had used Jax's trauma, her vulnerability, her desperate need for connection, and she had turned it into a weapon. She had compromised the investigation, distracted Jax from the truth, and bought herself time to cover up a twenty-year-old crime that was about to kill twelve thousand people.

The elevator chimed softly, and the doors parted.

Jax stepped out into a sprawling executive suite that occupied the entire top floor of the tower.

The space was designed to overwhelm. Floor-to-ceiling smart-glass windows lined three walls, offering a panoramic view of the entire colony. From this height, Jax could see everything—the gleaming spires of the Zenith Domes, the industrial sprawl of Sector 4, the distant red haze of the Martian horizon. It was a view reserved for gods and billionaires.

The fourth wall was dominated by a massive holographic display showing real-time data from Vance Interplanetary's global operations. Stock tickers, atmospheric readings, water extraction rates, personnel rosters—all of it flowing in a constant stream of information.

In the center of the room was a long obsidian conference table, polished to a mirror shine. Seated around it were half a dozen executives

in expensive suits, their faces pale and nervous.

And at the head of the table, standing with her back to the window, was Elara Vance.

She was back in her armor.

The soft, vulnerable woman who had held Jax in the darkness was gone, replaced by the CEO of the most powerful corporation on Mars. Elara wore a razor-sharp suit of deep crimson, tailored to perfection, and her dark hair was pulled back in a severe bun that emphasized the sharp, aristocratic lines of her face. Her silver eyes were cold and focused as she gestured to a holographic projection of quarterly earnings.

“—which is why I’m recommending we divest from the Phobos mining operation entirely,” Elara was saying, her voice carrying the kind of absolute authority that made grown men flinch. “The profit margins are unsustainable, and the environmental impact is—”

The elevator chimed.

Elara looked up, irritation flashing across her face. The irritation vanished the second she saw Jax’s expression.

For a fraction of a second, something raw and unguarded flickered in Elara’s silver eyes—hope, maybe, or relief. But it was gone so quickly Jax might have imagined it, replaced by cautious confusion.

“Out,” Elara said, her voice quiet but carrying the weight of an executioner’s blade.

The executives froze.

“Ms. Vance, we’re in the middle of—” one of them started.

“Out,” Elara repeated, her eyes never leaving Jax’s face. “Now.”

The executives scrambled.

They gathered their datapads and holographic projectors with the kind of panicked efficiency that came from years of working under Elara Vance’s unforgiving gaze. One of them—a nervous-looking man with thinning hair and a too-tight collar—knocked over his synth-caf in his haste to stand, sending a dark stain spreading across the polished

obsidian table.

“Leave it,” Elara said coldly.

The man practically tripped over his own feet as he backed toward the secondary exit. Another executive—a woman with sharp features and a calculating expression—paused at the door, her eyes flicking between Jax and Elara with barely concealed curiosity.

“Ms. Vance, if you need—”

“Close the door behind you, Director Chen,” Elara interrupted, her voice dropping to a dangerous frequency. “And if I find out you’ve been listening at the keyhole, I will personally ensure your next assignment is managing the waste reclamation facility in Sector 6.”

Director Chen’s face went pale. She nodded once and fled.

The secondary doors slid shut with a soft hiss, and the boardroom was suddenly, devastatingly empty.

The silence that followed was absolute.

Elara didn’t move. She stood at the head of the table, her hands resting lightly on the polished surface, her silver eyes locked onto Jax. The coldness from that morning was still there—the walls Jax had forced her to rebuild—but it was now laced with something else. Confusion. Wariness. And underneath it all, a flicker of fear.

“I explicitly told Aegis I was not to be disturbed,” Elara said evenly, her voice carefully controlled. “This had better be a colonial emergency, Detective.”

“Oh, it’s an emergency,” Jax said, her boots echoing sharply against the polished floor as she closed the distance between them.

Each step was deliberate, measured, the sound reverberating through the empty boardroom like a countdown. Jax’s hand was still resting on the butt of her magnum, and her face was a mask of cold, professional fury.

“Thousands of people in Sector 4 are about to die,” Jax continued, her voice a deadly, vibrating rasp, “because your father cut corners twenty

years ago to buy a few extra yachts.”

Jax reached into her coat, pulled out the thick stack of flimsies Chen had printed, and slammed them down onto the polished obsidian table.

The sound cracked through the quiet room like a gunshot.

The papers scattered slightly on impact, fanning out across the dark surface. The top sheet showed a complex structural diagram—the Sector 4 dome rendered in precise, technical detail, with red warning indicators blooming across the primary support struts like a spreading infection.

Elara blinked, looking down at the papers, then back up at Jax. “What is this?”

“That,” Jax said, her voice shaking with barely controlled rage, “is the structural degradation modeling Marcus Tyrell was running before someone carved his lungs out on your penthouse floor.”

Jax leaned forward, bracing her hands on the table, invading Elara’s space with the kind of aggressive posture she used in interrogation rooms.

“The poly-steel in the Sector 4 dome supports is failing,” Jax continued, her dark eyes boring into Elara’s silver ones. “It was manufactured with an inherent metallurgical flaw—a defect in the carbon-titanium matrix that causes the molecular bonds to degrade over time. Tyrell discovered it three weeks ago. He ran the stress models. He calculated the failure timeline.”

Jax tapped the top flimsy with one finger, the gesture sharp and accusatory.

“Eighteen to twenty-four months until total structural collapse. Twelve thousand, four hundred and seventeen people living under a dome that’s going to shatter like glass the next time there’s a pressure spike. And do you know who manufactured that defective poly-steel, Vance?”

Elara’s face had gone completely blank. It was the expression she wore in boardrooms when someone delivered catastrophically bad news—a

mask of perfect, corporate neutrality that revealed nothing.

But Jax had spent the night in Elara's bed. She had seen the woman beneath the armor. And she could see the exact moment the words registered, the exact moment Elara understood what Jax was accusing her of.

The color slowly drained from Elara's face.

"This... this is impossible," Elara whispered, reaching out to pick up the top flimsy.

Her hands were steady—years of corporate training ensured that—but Jax saw the slight tremor in her fingers as she lifted the paper. Elara's eyes scanned the data rapidly, her cognitive implants whirring as she processed the complex structural equations in seconds.

"Our quality control protocols are airtight," Elara said, her voice tight. "We don't manufacture compromised poly-steel. Every batch is tested, certified, and—"

"The data says otherwise," Jax interrupted, her voice cutting through Elara's denial like a blade.

Jax straightened, pulling another flimsy from the stack and holding it up. It was a manufacturing contract, dated twenty-three years ago, bearing the Vance Interplanetary logo and a signature Jax recognized from the corporate registry.

"This is the original procurement order for the Sector 4 dome construction," Jax said, her voice cold and clinical. "Signed by your father. Vance Interplanetary won the government contract to forge the primary support struts. You delivered the steel on time and under budget, which is impressive, considering the specifications called for a carbon-titanium alloy with a tensile strength of 2.4 gigapascals."

Jax pulled out another sheet, this one covered in dense chemical formulas and metallurgical analysis.

"The steel you actually delivered had a tensile strength of 1.9 gigapascals," Jax continued. "Someone in your company cut corners. They used

a cheaper alloy, pocketed the difference, and hoped no one would notice until it was too late.”

Elara stared at the documents, her silver eyes wide. “I didn’t know about this. I took over the company five years ago. This steel was poured before I was even—”

“Before you were CEO,” Jax finished. “I know. But Tyrell didn’t care about corporate succession. He found the flaw, and he realized what it meant. If he blew the whistle, Vance Interplanetary would be ruined. The lawsuits alone would bankrupt the company. Your stock price would collapse. Your government contracts would be revoked. Everything your father built—everything *you* built—would be destroyed.”

Jax stepped around the table, closing the distance between them, her voice dropping to a harsh, accusing whisper.

“So you had him killed.”

The words hung in the air between them like a death sentence.

Elara’s face went from pale to ashen. She took a half-step back, her hip hitting the edge of the table, and for the first time since Jax had met her, Elara Vance looked genuinely shaken.

“You think I ordered a hit on my own VP?” Elara asked, her voice barely above a whisper. “You think I had Marcus Tyrell murdered to cover up bad steel?”

“I think you’re a CEO who stands to lose a multi-trillion-credit empire,” Jax said, her voice shaking with barely controlled fury. “I think you inserted yourself into my investigation from day one to control the narrative. You gave me your security feeds—feeds you control. You let me use your quantum core—a system you monitor. You pointed me directly at Kaelen Mercer and Silas Vane, keeping me busy chasing false leads while your fixers tied up the loose ends.”

Jax pulled out another flimsy, this one showing the dark-web auction data Chen had decrypted.

“The auction that framed Mercer was sophisticated,” Jax continued,

her voice cold and clinical. "It required quantum encryption, access to Tyrell's personal files, and enough money to make it look convincing. You have all of those things, Vance. You have the means, the motive, and the opportunity."

Elara was staring at Jax like she'd been struck. The corporate mask was cracking, revealing something raw and wounded beneath.

"And the bomb at the transit hub?" Elara asked, her voice tight. "You think I planted that too?"

"I think you needed to test the harmonic frequency that would trigger the dome collapse," Jax said, the words coming out in a rush now, the theory she'd built with Chen spilling out like poison. "The bomb wasn't big enough to blow the dome—it was designed to create a localized pressure spike and record the telemetry data. You needed to know exactly how much stress the defective steel could take before it failed."

Jax's voice cracked on the last sentence, the professional detachment finally failing.

"And last night," Jax said, her voice dropping to a harsh, ragged whisper. "Coming to my apartment. The breakfast. The... everything."

Jax's hands clenched into fists at her sides, her nails digging into her palms hard enough to draw blood.

"It was all a distraction, wasn't it?" Jax asked, and the pain in her voice was raw and unguarded. "A way to compromise the lead detective so she wouldn't look too closely at the woman in her bed. You read my file. You knew about Tantalus. You knew exactly which buttons to push to make me—"

Jax's voice broke.

She turned away, unable to look at Elara's face, unable to see the confirmation she was terrified would be there.

"You made me care about you," Jax whispered, her voice barely audible. "You made me think I could let someone in. And it was all just part of the game."

The silence that followed was absolute.

It was the silence of the vacuum outside the dome, cold and airless and utterly devoid of life.

When Elara finally spoke, her voice was a harsh, ragged whisper that Jax had never heard before.

“You think I touched you to protect my stock price?”

Jax’s jaw tightened. She forced herself to turn around, to meet Elara’s eyes, even though it felt like staring into the sun.

“It’s the only thing that makes sense,” Jax said.

“Then you are a brilliant detective, Jax,” Elara said, her voice shaking with a terrifying, contained rage, “but you are a profound idiot when it comes to human beings.”

Elara threw the flimsy back onto the table with enough force to send several other papers scattering. She stepped forward, invading Jax’s space so aggressively that Jax instinctively took a half-step back.

“I am Elara Vance,” she hissed, her silver eyes burning with an intensity that made Jax’s breath catch. “I am the CEO of the most powerful corporation on Mars. I own forty-seven percent of the colony’s atmospheric processing capacity. I have three hundred lawyers on retainer and enough money to buy a small moon.”

Elara’s voice dropped to a deadly whisper.

“If I wanted to derail your investigation, I wouldn’t need to sleep with you to do it. I could have the colonial governor revoke your badge with a single phone call. I could buy your precinct and turn it into a parking lot. I could have you transferred to the waste reclamation facility in Sector 6 and ensure you never worked another homicide case for the rest of your career.”

Elara took another step forward, and Jax found herself backed against the obsidian table, trapped between the cold stone and the burning fury in Elara’s eyes.

“I came to your apartment last night,” Elara continued, her voice

shaking, “because you were bleeding out from a nightmare. Because I heard you screaming through the walls of your pathetic, concrete box of an apartment, and I couldn’t stand the thought of you suffering alone. I came because I **care** about you, Jax. Because I **wanted** you.”

The words hit Jax like a physical blow.

“The evidence—” Jax started, but her voice was weak, the absolute certainty of her theory wavering under the sheer, unadulterated pain in Elara’s voice.

“The evidence points to Vance Interplanetary,” Elara interrupted, her mind snapping back to the corporate reality with terrifying speed. “But it doesn’t point to **me**\.** I took over this company five years ago, Jax. This steel was poured twenty years ago, under my father’s administration. I was eight years old when that contract was signed. I didn’t know about the flaw.”**\.**

Elara turned away, pacing to the window, her hands clenched into fists at her sides.

“Do you know what I’ve spent the last five years doing?” Elara asked, her voice tight. “Cleaning up my father’s messes. Fixing the corners he cut. Rebuilding the reputation he destroyed with his greed and his arrogance. I have poured billions of credits into infrastructure improvements in the lower sectors—water filtration upgrades, atmospheric processor maintenance, structural reinforcement for the older domes.”

Elara spun around, her silver eyes blazing.

“I read your file, Jax. Yes. I admit it. I violated your privacy, and I’m not going to apologize for it, because I needed to understand who you were. I needed to know if I could trust you with the truth about my company.”

“The truth?” Jax asked, her voice hoarse.

“That Vance Interplanetary is rotting from the inside,” Elara said, her voice dropping to a harsh whisper. “That my father built an empire on shortcuts and bribes and backroom deals. That I’ve spent five years

trying to root out the corruption, and every time I think I've found it all, another skeleton falls out of the closet."

Elara's hands were shaking now, the corporate mask completely shattered.

"I read your file because I saw something in you that I recognized," Elara continued, her voice raw. "You speak for the dead because you couldn't save the living. You punish yourself every day for surviving Tantalus. You live in that concrete box and you eat synthetic protein and you refuse to let anyone close because you think you don't deserve to be happy."

Elara took a step toward Jax, her silver eyes glistening.

"I came to your apartment because I wanted to show you that you're wrong," Elara whispered. "That you deserve more than punishment. That you deserve to be cared for. And yes, Jax, I wanted you. I wanted you so badly it terrified me, because I haven't let anyone close in years, and you made me feel something I thought I'd buried with my father."

Jax's throat was tight. She couldn't breathe. The anger that had sustained her through the drive to the tower, through the confrontation, through the accusation—it was draining away, leaving nothing but a hollow, aching void.

"But you used my trauma," Jax said, her voice barely above a whisper. "You knew about Tantalus, and you—"

"I held you while you screamed," Elara interrupted, her voice breaking. "I stayed with you through the nightmare. I made you breakfast because I wanted to make sure you ate something that wasn't synthesized in a vat. I sent Aegis to check on you because I was terrified you'd do something reckless and get yourself killed."

Elara's voice dropped to a harsh, ragged whisper.

"I didn't use your trauma, Jax. I *saw* it. I recognized it. And I wanted to help you carry it, because I know what it's like to be crushed under the weight of something you can't control."

The silence that followed was deafening.

Jax stared at Elara, her mind racing, trying to reconcile the evidence with the raw, unguarded pain in Elara's voice. Everything she'd built—the theory, the motive, the timeline—it was all falling apart.

"Ignorance isn't an alibi," Jax said, but her voice was weak, the cop instincts fighting desperately to maintain control of the room.

"It's not an alibi," Elara agreed, turning to look at the sprawling view of the colony through the smart-glass. "It's the motive for the real killer."

Elara's mind was racing now, connecting the dots Jax hadn't seen. When she turned back around, her eyes were wide with realization.

"Think about it, Jax," Elara said, her voice urgent. "Tyrell was a safety inspector. He found a twenty-year-old flaw in the dome supports. He wouldn't have gone to the press first—that's not how corporate whistleblowers operate. He would have gone to the board of directors. He would have demanded a payout, a settlement, maybe even a promotion in exchange for his silence."

Jax frowned, the anger cooling slightly, replaced by the chilling logic of Elara's deduction.

"Someone on your board," Jax said slowly, the pieces clicking into place. "Someone who was here twenty years ago."

"Someone who signed off on that bad steel," Elara confirmed, her voice dropping to a deadly frequency. "Someone who realized Tyrell had found their mistake and decided to eliminate the problem before it destroyed their career."

Elara pulled up a holographic display from her wrist-comm, her fingers flying across the haptic interface. A list of names appeared in the air between them—the current board of directors for Vance Interplanetary.

"There are six people on this board who were with the company twenty years ago," Elara said, her eyes scanning the list. "Any one of them could

have signed the procurement order. Any one of them could have pocketed the difference between the specified alloy and the cheaper steel.”

“If the dome collapses naturally,” Jax said, her cop brain taking over, “it triggers a federal investigation into the steel. Forensic metallurgists would analyze the wreckage. They’d find the manufacturing flaw. They’d trace it back to whoever signed the order.”

“But if it collapses due to a terrorist attack,” Elara finished, her face pale, “the flaw is buried in the rubble. It’s classified as an act of war, not corporate negligence. The contractor gets off scot-free, and Vance Interplanetary gets paid by the government to rebuild the dome.”

“It’s an inside job,” Jax whispered, the full weight of the realization crashing over her. “Someone inside your house.”

“Someone with the security clearance to access Tyrell’s penthouse,” Elara said, her voice tight. “Someone with the funds to hire a professional killer. Someone who knew exactly how to manipulate my security grid and frame Kaelen Mercer.”

Elara’s hands were shaking now, the corporate control completely shattered by the realization that someone she trusted—someone she worked with every day—was a murderer.

“Someone who’s been watching this investigation from the beginning,” Jax added, her mind racing through the timeline. “Someone who knew we were getting close.”

The two women stared at each other across the obsidian table, the anger and accusation draining away, replaced by a shared, terrible understanding.

Elara didn’t call her lawyers. She didn’t call her security team. She didn’t activate the corporate protocols that would have buried Jax’s investigation under a mountain of injunctions and legal motions.

Instead, she reached down and unclasped the heavy, silver wrist-comm from her arm.

The device was elegant and understated, a thin band of polished

chrome with a holographic interface that projected from the faceplate. It was the master key to the Vance Interplanetary empire—the device that controlled her security systems, her financial accounts, her private communications.

It was her life.

Elara tapped a sequence into the faceplate, her fingers moving with practiced precision. The device chimed softly, and a holographic display appeared in the air above it, showing a cascade of security protocols being disabled one by one.

Biometric locks: DISABLED.

Quantum encryption: DISABLED.

Remote wipe protocols: DISABLED.

Elara was bypassing her own security, stripping away every layer of protection, leaving the device completely vulnerable.

She held it out to Jax.

“Take it,” Elara ordered, her voice steady despite the tremor in her hands.

Jax stared at the device, her breath catching in her throat. “What is this?”

“It’s my personal data-pad,” Elara said, her silver eyes locked onto Jax’s with an intensity that burned. “Unencrypted. Unrestricted. No firewalls, no security protocols, no remote access limitations. It contains every comm I’ve ever sent, every financial transaction I’ve ever authorized, every meeting I’ve ever attended, and every secret this company possesses.”

Elara’s voice dropped to a harsh whisper.

“Take it to Officer Chen. Have her tear it apart down to the source code. Check my geolocation data for the night Tyrell was murdered. Cross-reference my financial ledgers against the dark-web auction that framed Mercer. Look for any connection between me and the Sector 4 dome poly-steel.”

Jax slowly reached out and took the heavy silver device. The metal was warm from Elara's skin, and it felt impossibly heavy in Jax's hand—not because of its physical weight, but because of what it represented.

"If I log this into evidence," Jax said quietly, "it becomes public record. Your company's proprietary secrets, your personal communications, your financial data—all of it will be accessible to the colonial prosecutor's office. Your competitors will have a field day."

"I don't care," Elara said fiercely, her voice shaking with barely controlled emotion. "If you think I'm a murderer, arrest me right now, Detective. Put me in cuffs and drag me down to Precinct 12. But if you think I'm a monster who used your trauma to manipulate an investigation—if you think I'm capable of that level of calculated cruelty—then look at the data."

Elara's silver eyes were glistening now, and Jax realized with a start that she was seeing Elara Vance on the verge of tears.

"Prove me innocent," Elara whispered. "And find the rat in my company before they blow the dome and kill twelve thousand people."

Jax looked down at the wrist-comm in her hand, then back up at Elara.

The billionaire was standing tall, stripped of her corporate armor, offering her entire life on a silver platter just to prove she hadn't lied in the dark of Jax's apartment. It was an act of trust so profound, so devastating, that Jax felt something crack in her chest.

Because Elara was right.

If she'd wanted to obstruct the investigation, she could have done it a hundred different ways. She could have pulled strings, called in favors, buried Jax under a mountain of legal motions. She could have had Jax's badge revoked, her career destroyed, her life ruined.

Instead, she was handing over the keys to her empire and trusting Jax to use them wisely.

The rift between them was massive, a chasm torn through the fragile trust they had built the night before. Jax had wounded Elara deeply by

assuming the worst, by letting her fear and her trauma override her judgment. And Elara was too proud to beg for forgiveness, too hurt to pretend the accusation hadn't cut her to the bone.

But she was still offering Jax the truth.

"I'll have Chen run the decryption," Jax said, her voice tight, formal. She slipped the wrist-comm into her coat pocket, the weight of it settling against her ribs like a stone.

"Do that," Elara said coldly, turning her back on Jax to stare out the window at the red Martian horizon.

Her shoulders were rigid, her hands clenched into fists at her sides. She looked like she was holding herself together through sheer force of will.

"And Detective?" Elara added, her voice dropping to a harsh whisper. "When you find out who is actually trying to destroy my company... you let me know."

The words were a dismissal, cold and final.

"I will," Jax promised.

She turned and walked back toward the elevator, her boots echoing on the polished floor. Each step felt heavier than the last, the weight of what she'd just done pressing down on her shoulders like a physical burden.

She had the data. She had the proof she needed to clear Elara's name—or condemn her.

But as the elevator doors slid shut, separating her from Elara Vance, Jax felt sicker than she had when she first walked in.

Through the narrowing gap, she caught one last glimpse of Elara standing at the window, her silhouette dark against the red Martian sky. She looked impossibly alone, a solitary figure in a tower of glass and chrome, surrounded by wealth and power but utterly isolated.

The doors closed with a soft chime, and Jax was alone in the elevator.

She leaned back against the obsidian wall, her eyes closed, her hand

pressed against the pocket where Elara's wrist-comm rested.

She was terrifyingly close to cracking the case.

But she had just broken the only good thing that had happened to her in a decade to do it.

Chapter Twelve: The Target

The drive back to Sector 4 was a blur of neon and exhaust, but Jax's mind was anything but blurred.

It was razor-sharp, cutting into herself with surgical precision.

Her hands gripped the spinner's yoke with white-knuckled intensity, her knuckles standing out like bone beneath the skin. The unmarked police vehicle cut through the Martian traffic lanes with mechanical efficiency, weaving between the massive cargo haulers and the sleek private transports of the upper sectors. The artificial sky above the Zenith Domes was beginning its programmed transition to evening—a gradient of deep purples and oranges that had been designed by atmospheric engineers who had never seen a real sunset on Earth.

Jax didn't notice any of it.

All she could see was the look on Elara's face when Jax had slammed those flimsies down on the boardroom table. The way Elara's silver eyes had widened with shock, then narrowed with hurt, then finally gone cold and dead as the corporate armor slammed back into place.

You think I touched you to protect my stock price?

The words echoed in Jax's skull like a death knell, each syllable a fresh wound. She had seen Elara Vance face down cartel enforcers without flinching. She had watched her disarm a bomb with steady hands and absolute focus. But in that boardroom, Jax had done what no enemy had ever managed—she had broken something inside Elara that might never heal.

A proximity alarm blared as Jax cut too close to a massive atmospheric processor transport. The driver laid on his horn, the sound dopplering past as Jax jerked the spinner back into her lane. Her heart was hammering, her breath coming in short, sharp gasps.

Focus, she ordered herself viciously. *You're a cop. You have evidence to analyze. You have a case to close. You can fall apart later.*

But the guilt was a living thing in her chest, coiling around her ribs and squeezing tight. Because the truth—the truth Jax was desperately trying not to acknowledge—was that she had wanted Elara to be guilty.

Not consciously. Not in any way she could articulate. But somewhere deep in the broken, traumatized core of herself, Jax had been waiting for the other shoe to drop. She had been waiting for Elara to reveal herself as just another corrupt billionaire, just another person who would use Jax and discard her when she was no longer useful.

Because if Elara was guilty, then Jax's walls were justified. Her isolation was necessary. Her refusal to let anyone close was the smart, rational choice of a survivor.

But if Elara was innocent...

If Elara was innocent, then Jax had just destroyed the first real connection she'd had with another human being since Tantalus. She had taken the woman who had held her through her nightmares, who had made her breakfast, who had looked at her scars and seen something worth protecting—and she had called her a murderer.

The spinner descended through the atmospheric layers, dropping

from the pristine, climate-controlled luxury of the Zenith Domes into the industrial haze of Sector 4. The air quality monitor on the dashboard flickered from green to yellow to orange as the particulate count increased. Down here, the sky was perpetually grey, choked with the exhaust from the massive atmospheric processors and the chemical runoff from the hydroponic farms.

Down here, people lived in concrete boxes and ate synthetic protein and dreamed of saving enough credits to move up to Sector 2.

Down here, Jax belonged.

She brought the spinner down hard on the precinct landing pad, the thrusters kicking up a cloud of red Martian dust that coated the windshield. She killed the engines and sat there for a long moment, her forehead pressed against the yoke, her eyes squeezed shut.

I am not going to let you break yourself, Elara had said in the darkness of Jax's apartment, her voice soft and fierce and utterly sincere.

But Jax had broken herself anyway. She had taken the fragile, terrifying possibility of happiness and she had smashed it against the rocks of her own fear and trauma.

"Goddammit," Jax whispered to the empty cockpit, her voice cracking.

She forced herself to move. She grabbed the heavy silver wrist-comm from her coat pocket, the metal warm from her body heat, and climbed out of the spinner. The precinct loomed above her, a squat, ugly building of reinforced concrete and blast-resistant polymer. It had been built during the early colonial days when the threat of atmospheric breach was constant, and it looked like what it was—a bunker designed to survive the end of the world.

Jax walked through the main entrance, her badge automatically triggering the security scanners. The lobby was packed with the usual chaos—officers processing arrests, civilians filing complaints, the acrid smell of too many bodies in too small a space. A drunk miner was screaming obscenities at the intake desk. Two gang members were

handcuffed to a bench, glaring at each other with murderous intent.

Jax ignored all of it.

She pushed through the security doors into the main bullpen, and the noise hit her like a physical wall. The near-miss at the Sector 1 Transit Hub had every badge on the floor working overtime. Holographic displays flickered and spun in the air above every desk, showing crime scene photos, witness statements, forensic analysis reports. The main tactical board was covered in red priority markers, each one representing a lead that needed to be chased down.

Officer Chen was at her desk in the back corner, surrounded by a fortress of empty synth-caf pouches and half-eaten protein bars. She had four separate holographic displays open simultaneously, her fingers dancing across the haptic interfaces with manic energy. Her dark hair was falling out of its bun, and there were deep shadows under her eyes that spoke of too much caffeine and not enough sleep.

She looked up as Jax approached, and her eyes widened.

“Jax. You look... intense.”

“Drop whatever you’re doing,” Jax ordered, her voice flat and dead.

She pulled the heavy silver wrist-comm from her pocket and tossed it onto the center of Chen’s console. It landed with a dull, heavy clatter that seemed impossibly loud in the ambient chaos of the bullpen.

Chen stared at it like it was an unexploded ordinance.

“Is that...” Chen’s voice dropped to a whisper. “Is that Elara Vance’s personal master-sync?”

“It’s her life,” Jax said, the words tasting like ash in her mouth. She pulled up a chair and dropped into it, her body suddenly feeling like it weighed a thousand pounds. “Unencrypted. No firewalls. No remote access limitations. She gave it to me voluntarily.”

Chen’s hands hovered over the device, not quite touching it, like she was afraid it might bite her.

“Jax,” Chen said carefully, her eyes flicking up to meet Jax’s. “If

Vance's legal team finds out we're accessing this without a colonial subpoena, they will bury us. They will have our badges. They will have us blacklisted from every law enforcement agency in the solar system. This is... this is career suicide."

"There is no legal team," Jax said, her voice hollow. "She disabled every security protocol herself. She handed me the master key to the Vance Interplanetary empire and told me to prove her innocent."

Chen's face went pale. "Why would she do that?"

"Because I accused her of murdering Marcus Tyrell to cover up a twenty-year-old manufacturing defect," Jax said, the words coming out in a rush. "Because I told her that last night—the night she came to my apartment, the night she held me through a nightmare—was just a calculated manipulation to compromise the investigation. Because I looked her in the eye and called her a monster."

Chen's mouth opened, then closed. She looked down at the wrist-comm, then back up at Jax.

"Was she?" Chen asked quietly. "A monster?"

"I don't know," Jax admitted, and the uncertainty was a knife twisting in her gut. "That's what we're about to find out. I want you to tear it apart, Chen. Cross-reference her personal financial ledgers against the dark-web auction that framed Mercer. Check her geolocation data for the night Tyrell was murdered. Look for anything—anything at all—that ties her to the Sector 4 dome poly-steel or the transit hub bomb."

Chen swallowed hard. She reached out slowly, her fingers trembling slightly, and picked up the wrist-comm. The device was elegant and understated, a thin band of polished chrome with a holographic interface that projected from the faceplate. It was the kind of technology that cost more than Chen would make in five years.

"If we do this," Chen said, her voice steady despite the fear in her eyes, "and we find evidence that she's guilty, we have to arrest her. No matter what it costs us personally."

“I know,” Jax said.

“And if we find evidence that she’s innocent,” Chen continued, “then you just destroyed the first real relationship you’ve had since Tantalus. And you’re going to have to live with that.”

Jax’s jaw tightened. “I know that too. Do it, Chen. Now.”

Chen nodded once, sharp and decisive. She slotted a proprietary interface cable into the wrist-comm’s data port and tapped a rapid sequence into her keyboard.

The holographic screens around the desk exploded with data.

It was like watching a dam break. Cascading streams of information flooded the displays, each one color-coded and tagged with security classifications that made Chen’s eyes go wide. Financial transactions scrolling past at dizzying speed. Private communications with the Martian Governor. Highly classified terraforming patents. Personnel files for every employee in the Vance Interplanetary empire. Biometric data. Security logs. Atmospheric processor schematics.

It was a dizzying, terrifying look into the absolute peak of colonial power.

“Oh my God,” Chen breathed, her fingers flying across the keyboard as she tried to organize the data streams into something manageable. “Jax, this is... this is everything. Every secret Vance Interplanetary has. Every backroom deal. Every classified project. She just handed us the keys to the kingdom.”

“Can you parse it?” Jax asked, leaning forward, her hands gripping the armrests of her chair so tightly the polymer creaked.

“I can try,” Chen said. She pulled up a secondary console, routing the data streams through the precinct’s quantum processors. “Okay. Let me start with the basics. Geolocation data first. If Elara was at the penthouse when Tyrell was murdered, her biometric implants would have registered on the estate’s security grid.”

Chen’s fingers danced across the haptic interface, pulling up a three-

dimensional map of the colony. The Zenith Domes appeared in glowing blue, the lower sectors in grey, the industrial zones in red. A timeline appeared at the bottom of the display, showing the night of Tyrell's murder in minute-by-minute detail.

"Tyrell's biometric monitor flatlined at 2214 hours," Chen said, her voice dropping into the clinical, detached tone she used when analyzing evidence. "That's the exact moment his heart stopped. The medical examiner's report confirms time of death within a two-minute window."

Chen tapped a command, and a small green dot appeared on the map, pulsing steadily.

"This is Elara Vance's biometric signature," Chen explained. "Her neural implants and her wrist-comm both transmit a constant locator signal. It's a security feature—if she's ever kidnapped or incapacitated, her security team can find her immediately."

Jax watched the green dot, her heart hammering against her ribs.

"At 2214 hours," Chen continued, zooming in on the map, "Elara Vance was here."

The green dot was pulsing in the Sector 1 Arboretum, a massive biodome filled with genetically engineered trees and imported Earth flora. It was one of the most exclusive venues in the colony, reserved for charity galas and corporate events.

"She was at a fundraiser," Chen said, pulling up a secondary window showing press coverage of the event. Holographic images appeared—Elara in a stunning black gown, shaking hands with the Martian Governor, giving a speech about atmospheric sustainability. "The Colonial Preservation Society's annual gala. Three hundred witnesses. A dozen press cameras. She gave the keynote address at 2200 hours and didn't leave until 2330 hours."

Chen looked up at Jax, her dark eyes wide.

"She has an airtight alibi, Jax. She was surrounded by witnesses at the exact moment Tyrell was murdered. She didn't wield the laser scalpel.

She couldn't have."

Jax felt something crack in her chest—a sharp, painful sensation that might have been relief or might have been grief. She couldn't tell anymore.

"We knew she didn't kill him personally," Jax said, her voice rough. "What about the money? The ten million credits that framed Mercer. Did she wire it?"

Chen turned back to her console, pulling up the financial ledgers. The holographic display shifted, showing a dizzying array of accounts, transactions, and investment portfolios.

"I'm running a deep-parse quantum trace," Chen explained, her fingers flying across the keyboard. "This is going to take a few minutes. The Vance financial empire is... it's massive, Jax. She has personal accounts, corporate slush funds, blind trusts, offshore holdings on Europa. I need to trace every single transaction for the week before and after Tyrell's murder."

"Do it," Jax ordered.

The next hour was agony.

Jax sat in her chair, her hands clenched into fists on the armrests, watching the data scroll past on Chen's screens. She drank terrible, bitter synth-caf from a disposable pouch, the synthetic caffeine doing nothing to settle the churning in her stomach. Around them, the bullpen continued its chaotic rhythm—officers shouting into comms, suspects being processed, the constant background hum of the precinct's life support systems.

Jax barely noticed any of it.

All she could see was Elara's face in the boardroom. The way her silver eyes had gone cold and dead when Jax accused her of using their intimacy as a weapon.

*I came to your apartment because you were bleeding out from a nightmare. Because I heard you screaming through the walls of your

pathetic, concrete box of an apartment, and I couldn't stand the thought of you suffering alone.*

"Jax," Chen said quietly, breaking through her spiraling thoughts. "I've got the financial analysis."

Jax's head snapped up. "And?"

Chen turned her console so Jax could see the holographic display. It showed a complex web of financial transactions, each one color-coded and tagged with timestamps.

"The ten million credits that framed Mercer came from a blind trust registered in the Phobos Free Trade Zone," Chen explained, pointing to a cluster of red-tagged transactions. "It's a shell company designed to hide the identity of the account holder. But I traced the money backward through six different intermediary accounts, and it doesn't connect to Elara Vance. At all."

Chen pulled up a secondary display showing Elara's personal financial records.

"In fact," Chen continued, her voice dropping to a whisper, "Elara's been actively funneling billions of her own profits into the lower sectors. Look at this."

The display showed a series of massive transactions, each one tagged with a destination account. Sector 4 Atmospheric Scrubber Maintenance. Sector 6 Water Filtration Upgrades. Sector 3 Medical Clinic Expansion.

"She's been spending her personal fortune—not corporate funds, her personal money—on infrastructure improvements in the lower sectors," Chen said, her eyes wide. "The board of directors has been fighting her on it for two years. They want her to maximize shareholder value, but she keeps diverting profits to projects that don't generate revenue."

Chen pulled up a series of internal corporate memos, each one more heated than the last.

"Look at this," Chen said, pointing to a particularly angry message from a board member. "They're threatening to call a vote of no

confidence. They think she's wasting company resources on 'charity projects' that don't benefit the bottom line."

Jax stared at the financial records, the numbers blurring together. Billions of credits. Billions. All of it flowing into the sectors where people like Jax lived—the people who ate synthetic protein and drank recycled water and dreamed of something better.

"She's been trying to fix her father's mistakes," Jax whispered, the realization hitting her like a physical blow. "She took over the company five years ago, and she's been using her own money to repair the infrastructure he neglected."

"She's clean, Jax," Chen said softly. "Completely clean. She didn't wire the money to frame Mercer. She didn't hire the killer. She didn't plant the bomb. She's been spending billions trying to prevent exactly the kind of disaster we're investigating."

The guilt was absolute, a cold, suffocating tide that threatened to drown Jax where she sat. She had looked at Elara Vance—a woman who was bankrupting herself to save the lower sectors—and she had called her a murderer.

"Jax," Chen said hesitantly, her voice careful. "While I was parsing her private comms... I found something else."

Jax looked up, her throat tight. "What?"

Chen's fingers hovered over her keyboard, hesitating. "There's a locked partition in her personal files. It's not encrypted, just hidden. Like she didn't want anyone to stumble across it accidentally, but she didn't feel the need to protect it with quantum security."

"What's in it?" Jax asked, though part of her didn't want to know.

"Personal logs," Chen said quietly. "Audio diaries. The metadata says they're all recorded in her private quarters, late at night. And Jax... they're all tagged with your name."

The world seemed to tilt sideways.

"What?" Jax breathed.

Chen pulled up the folder structure, and Jax saw it—a directory labeled simply “Jax.” Inside were dozens of audio files, each one timestamped and dated. The earliest one was from three days ago, the night Jax and Elara had raided Silas Vane’s compound in Sector 6.

“I didn’t listen to them,” Chen said quickly, her hands raised in a gesture of innocence. “I swear, Jax. I saw the folder name and I closed it immediately. But the metadata is visible. She’s been recording her thoughts about you since the night you fought your way out of The Crucible together.”

Jax stared at the glowing folder icon on the screen. It was right there. Elara’s private, unguarded thoughts. The truth about what she felt, what she wanted, what she thought about the broken cop from Sector 4 who had accused her of conspiracy.

A desperate, burning curiosity flared in Jax’s chest. She wanted to know. She needed to know. Had Elara meant what she said in the boardroom? Or had it been a performance, a calculated defense designed to manipulate Jax’s guilt?

The folder was right there. One click. One command. And Jax would know the truth.

Her hand moved toward the console, her fingers trembling.

“Don’t,” Chen said softly.

Jax froze, her hand hovering over the haptic interface.

“If you listen to those files,” Chen continued, her voice gentle but firm, “you’ll never be able to unhear them. And Elara gave you this wrist-comm to prove her innocence in a murder investigation. She didn’t give you permission to violate her privacy. She didn’t give you permission to listen to her most intimate thoughts.”

Jax’s hand clenched into a fist. The temptation was overwhelming, a physical ache in her chest. But Chen was right. Elara had surrendered her master access to prove she wasn’t a killer. She hadn’t surrendered her right to privacy.

“Close the folder, Chen,” Jax said, her voice rough and strained. “We only look for the murder. Nothing else.”

Chen nodded, relief flickering across her face. She swiped the personal folder away, and it vanished from the display.

“Okay,” Chen said, turning back to the main investigation. “If Elara didn’t kill Tyrell, and she didn’t frame Mercer, then we’re back to square one. Who did?”

“Elara said the motive lies with whoever signed off on the bad steel twenty years ago,” Jax said, forcing herself to focus. The case. The evidence. The dead man who deserved justice. “Pull up the original manufacturing manifests. Find out who actually authorized the procurement order for the Sector 4 poly-steel.”

Chen nodded, her fingers flying across the keyboard. The holographic display shifted, pulling up decades-old corporate records from the Vance Interplanetary archives.

“Okay,” Chen murmured, her eyes scanning the data. “Twenty years ago, Elara’s father was CEO. But the actual procurement process was handled by the logistics division. Let me find the signature on the purchase order...”

The screen blurred as Chen navigated through layers of bureaucratic documentation. Purchase orders. Budget allocations. Quality control certifications. Manufacturing specifications.

And then, finally, a single document appeared on the screen.

It was a procurement authorization form, dated twenty-three years ago, for the poly-steel used in the Sector 4 dome construction. The specifications were clearly listed—carbon-titanium alloy with a tensile strength of 2.4 gigapascals. The budget allocation was massive—three billion credits.

And at the bottom of the form, in a bold, confident signature, was a name.

Commander James Sterling, Director of Logistics and Security.

“Sterling,” Chen breathed, her face going pale.

She pulled up a secondary window, cross-referencing the name against current Vance Interplanetary personnel records. A face appeared on the screen—a broad-shouldered man with a military buzz cut, cold grey eyes, and a jaw that looked like it had been carved from granite.

Jax recognized him instantly.

He had been standing in the shadows of Elara’s penthouse the night Tyrell was murdered, coordinating the corporate security perimeter. He had been the one to brief Jax on the estate’s security protocols. He had been the one to provide the biometric data from Tyrell’s monitor.

“Commander Sterling,” Jax said slowly, the pieces clicking into place with terrible, absolute clarity. “He’s Vance Interplanetary’s current Chief of Security.”

Chen pulled up Sterling’s full personnel file, and the data painted a damning picture.

“He started with the company twenty-five years ago as a mid-level logistics coordinator,” Chen read aloud, her voice shaking. “He was promoted to Director of Logistics three years later. He signed the procurement order for the Sector 4 dome steel. And then, five years after that, he was promoted to Chief of Security.”

“He bought the cheap steel,” Jax said, her mind racing through the timeline. “He was a mid-level director trying to make a name for himself. The specifications called for high-grade poly-steel at three billion credits. But Sterling found a cheaper supplier—someone who could deliver a lower-grade alloy for, what, two billion? Two and a half?”

“Two point one billion,” Chen confirmed, pulling up the actual payment records. “The difference was nine hundred million credits.”

“Nine hundred million credits that Sterling pocketed,” Jax continued, standing up and starting to pace. “He falsified the quality control certifications. He buried the real metallurgical analysis. He delivered substandard steel and kept the surplus budget for himself.”

“And no one noticed,” Chen said, her voice hollow. “Because the dome didn’t fail immediately. The degradation was slow, molecular. It took twenty years for the micro-fractures to spread far enough to become a structural threat.”

“But Marcus Tyrell noticed,” Jax said, the full scope of the conspiracy finally becoming clear. “Tyrell was a safety inspector. He was running routine stress analysis on the dome supports, and he found the flaw. He realized the steel was substandard. He started digging into the original procurement records.”

“And he found Sterling’s signature,” Chen finished, her eyes wide.

“Tyrell goes to Sterling,” Jax said, her voice dropping to a deadly calm. “He doesn’t realize he’s reporting the problem to the man who caused it. He thinks he’s doing his job—alerting the Chief of Security to a catastrophic safety issue. But Sterling realizes that if Tyrell exposes the bad steel, forensic metallurgists will trace it back to the original procurement order. They’ll find Sterling’s signature. They’ll discover he pocketed nine hundred million credits and delivered defective materials that are about to kill twelve thousand people.”

“So Sterling kills him,” Chen said, her voice barely above a whisper. “He uses his master security clearance to bypass Elara’s penthouse alarms. He stages the murder to look like a corporate hit. He carves Tyrell open with a laser scalpel to make it look professional, calculated.”

“And then he frames Helios Terraforming,” Jax continued, the pieces falling into place with sickening precision. “He uses his access to Tyrell’s files to create the fake dark-web auction. He plants evidence on Kaelen Mercer. He gives us a false trail to follow while he ties up the loose ends.”

“The transit hub bomb,” Chen said, her face going pale. “Sterling planted it. He needed to test the harmonic frequency that would trigger the dome collapse. He needed to know exactly how much pressure the defective steel could take before it failed.”

“Because if the dome collapses naturally,” Jax said, her voice cold, “it

triggers a federal investigation into the steel. Forensic metallurgists analyze the wreckage. They find the manufacturing flaw. They trace it back to Sterling.”

“But if it collapses due to a terrorist attack,” Chen finished, her voice shaking, “the flaw is buried in the rubble. It’s classified as an act of war, not corporate negligence. Sterling walks away clean, and Vance Interplanetary gets paid by the government to rebuild the dome.”

The sheer, calculated evil of it made Jax want to put her fist through the holographic display.

“Sterling has been playing us from the beginning,” Jax said, her hands clenched into fists. “He’s the Chief of Security. He has master clearance to every system in the Vance network. He’s been watching our investigation in real-time, feeding us false leads, making sure we never looked too closely at him.”

Jax looked down at the silver wrist-comm on Chen’s desk, and a cold, terrible realization washed over her.

“Chen,” Jax said, her voice dropping to a whisper. “Does Sterling know Elara gave me this?”

Chen’s face went completely pale. Her fingers flew across the keyboard, pulling up the network access logs.

“Oh God,” Chen breathed, staring at the screen. “Jax... the moment I plugged the wrist-comm into the precinct grid, it registered on the Vance corporate network. It’s a security feature—any time the CEO’s master access is used, it triggers an automatic alert to the Chief of Security.”

“Sterling knows,” Jax said, horror dawning. “He knows Elara gave me her master access. He knows we have the data. He knows we’re about to trace the procurement order back to him.”

“If Sterling knows he’s about to be caught,” Chen said, her voice trembling, “he needs to close the investigation. Permanently.”

“He needs a scapegoat,” Jax realized, the pieces clicking into place with terrible clarity. “Someone to take the fall for Tyrell’s murder and

the dome sabotage. Someone whose death would neatly tie up all the loose ends.”

“Elara,” Chen whispered.

The word hung in the air between them like a death sentence.

“He’s going to kill her,” Jax said, her voice flat and dead. “He’s going to make it look like a suicide. The guilt-ridden CEO who murdered her own VP to cover up her father’s crimes. She’ll leave a confession, and Sterling will ‘discover’ it after her tragic death. Case closed. Investigation over. And Sterling walks away clean.”

Jax grabbed her comms unit, her hands shaking, and punched in the direct frequency to the Vance Estate.

“Come on, Aegis,” Jax muttered, her heart hammering against her ribs. “Pick up. Pick up, damn you.”

Static hissed in her ear.

“The number you have reached is currently under a localized comms-blackout. Please contact Vance Security for assistance.”

Then, a cold, mechanical voice:

“He’s jammed the estate,” Jax snarled, slamming the comms unit down on Chen’s desk hard enough to crack the casing. “He waited until she went home to lick her wounds, and he’s locked it down. She’s alone in there with him.”

Jax didn’t hesitate.

She threw herself toward the precinct armory cage, her boots pounding on the concrete floor. She didn’t bother with the standard-issue plasma-magnum. She grabbed a heavy, military-grade pulse-rifle from the rack, the kind of weapon designed for breaching fortified positions. She slammed a high-capacity drum magazine into the receiver with a definitive *clack* and grabbed three EMP grenades from the tactical locker, shoving them into her vest.

“Jax!” Chen called after her, scrambling to follow. “What are you doing?”

"I'm going to get her," Jax said, her voice cold and absolutely certain. She grabbed a tactical vest from the locker and started strapping it on, her fingers moving with mechanical precision. "Sterling thinks he's playing a corporate chess match. He doesn't realize he just brought a street cop into the game."

"You can't assault the Vance Estate alone!" Chen protested. "You need backup! You need TRT!"

"Then get me TRT!" Jax roared, spinning around to face her partner. The raw, desperate fear in Jax's eyes made Chen take an involuntary step back. "Captain Graves!" Jax bellowed, her voice carrying across the entire bullpen. "I need TRT spun up and routed to the Vance Estate in the Zenith Domes, right now! Code Red!"

Captain Graves burst out of his office, his face flushed with anger and confusion.

"The Vance Estate?" Graves demanded, striding toward Jax. "Detective, you can't assault the CEO's private residence! Do you have any idea what kind of legal shitstorm—"

"The CEO is the target!" Jax yelled, not breaking stride as she headed for the mag-lev elevator. "Her Chief of Security is the dome bomber! He killed Marcus Tyrell to cover up a twenty-year-old procurement fraud! He's going to murder Elara Vance and make it look like a suicide! Move TRT, Captain, or I swear to God I'll hold you personally responsible when we're pulling her body out of that estate!"

Graves's face went pale. He looked at Chen, who nodded frantically, confirming Jax's story.

"Spin up TRT," Graves barked at the nearest officer. "Full tactical loadout. Route them to the Zenith Domes, Vance Estate. Authorization code Graves-Seven-Alpha. Move!"

"They'll be fifteen minutes behind you," Graves said, turning back to Jax. "Can you hold out that long?"

"I'll have to," Jax said.

She didn't wait for his response. She hit the elevator, her heart hammering against her ribs like a trapped bird. The doors slid shut, and the elevator shot toward the surface with a high-pitched whine of magnetic acceleration.

In the cramped metal box, alone with her fear and her guilt, Jax finally let herself feel the full weight of what she'd done.

"I am not going to let you break yourself," Elara had said in the darkness of Jax's apartment, her voice soft and fierce and utterly sincere.

But Jax had broken herself anyway. She had taken the fragile, terrifying possibility of happiness and she had smashed it against the rocks of her own fear and trauma. She had accused Elara of conspiracy, stripped her of her armor, and left her entirely alone.

And now Sterling was moving in for the kill.

"Hold on, Vance," Jax whispered to the empty air, her hands gripping the pulse-rifle so tightly her knuckles ached. "Just hold on. I'm coming."

The elevator reached the surface, and the doors slid open onto the precinct landing pad. Jax sprinted across the concrete, throwing herself into the unmarked police spinner. She didn't bother requesting clearance from the transit authority. She engaged the maximum overdrive thrusters, and the spinner tore into the air with a deafening shriek of protesting metal.

She pointed the nose of the ship straight up, cutting through the commercial lanes with complete disregard for traffic regulations. Collision alarms blared in the cockpit, warning her that she was violating a dozen different flight safety protocols. Jax ignored them all.

The artificial blue sky of the Zenith Domes rapidly approached, the sprawling, manicured luxury of the upper levels looking like a twisted mockery of the violence about to unfold.

Jax checked the charge on her pulse-rifle, her jaw set in a line of absolute, lethal determination.

She had accused Elara of being a monster. She had broken the woman's

trust, violated her vulnerability, and left her defenseless.

But Jax was about to prove that she was still a cop. She was still someone who spoke for the dead and protected the living.

And if Sterling thought he could murder Elara Vance and walk away clean, he was about to learn a very painful lesson about what happened when you threatened someone Jax cared about.

The spinner screamed through the upper atmosphere, and Jax pushed the thrusters to their absolute limits.

She was coming.

And God help anyone who stood in her way.

Chapter Thirteen: The Siege

The Vance Estate was entirely dark.

For a compound that usually glowed like a beacon of excessive wealth against the artificial Martian sky, the absolute blackout was terrifying. Sterling had cut the primary power grid, relying on the estate's localized sub-routines to mask the assault.

Jax didn't bother looking for a landing pad. She brought the unmarked police spinner in hot, aiming directly for the sprawling, immaculate front lawn. She threw the thrusters into full reverse at the last possible second, the ship hitting the manicured, genetically modified grass with a violent crunch that shattered the landing struts.

Before the spinner had even settled, Jax kicked the door open and rolled out into the shadows, the heavy pulse-rifle pulled tight to her shoulder.

She hit the ground and instantly felt the crushing, localized gravity of the estate pull at her boots. She didn't pause to adjust. Adrenaline was flooding her system, drowning out the ache in her injured shoulder and

the exhaustion in her bones.

She sprinted toward the main portico, her combat boots tearing up chunks of the million-credit lawn.

The heavy mahogany double doors were sealed shut. Two of Vance Interplanetary's elite security guards—now officially rogue mercenaries—were stationed behind the marble pillars, sweeping the darkness with thermal-optic rifles.

Jax didn't give them a chance to call it in. She pulled a flash-bang from her tactical rig, primed it with her thumb, and hurled it in a high arc over the portico steps.

"Flash!" Jax muttered to herself, squeezing her eyes shut and turning her head.

The grenade detonated with a blinding, white-hot flash and a concussive *CRACK***** that rattled the windows of the estate.**

Jax rounded the corner before the echoes faded, her pulse-rifle raised. The two guards were stumbling, clutching their visors. She fired two short, controlled bursts. The heavy kinetic rounds slammed into their chest plates, throwing them backward onto the limestone. They didn't get back up.

Jax stepped over them, slapping a breaching charge against the seam of the mahogany doors. She stepped back, triggered the detonator, and the ancient wood splintered inward in a shower of expensive shrapnel.

She stepped through the smoke and into the grand foyer.

The estate was eerily quiet, the air smelling of ozone and burnt wood. The ambient, beautiful lighting was gone, replaced by the emergency red glow of the backup generators.

Suddenly, a sharp burst of static hissed in Jax's right earpiece.

"Your entry was remarkably unsubtle, Detective. I've had to re-route three cleaning drones just to deal with the splinters."

Jax let out a breath she didn't know she was holding. "Aegis. Status. Now."

*“Commander Sterling has infiltrated the compound with a squad of fifteen heavily armed loyalists,”**** the AI replied, his aristocratic voice clipping with unprecedented urgency. *“He has isolated the external comms and is currently attempting to manually override my core programming to lock Ms. Vance out of her own home.”*

“Where is she?” Jax demanded, moving silently down the eastern corridor, her rifle tracking every shadow.

“The Grand Gallery, west wing. She has thus far refused to hide in the panic room, citing it as, quote, ‘undignified,’ unquote. She is currently leading a fire-team of four mercenaries into a trap. I suggest you hurry, Detective. Her tactical suit is impressive, but it is not invulnerable.”

“Keep Sterling out of your core,” Jax ordered. “And tell her I’m coming.”

*“She knows,”**** Aegis replied cryptically, the channel clicking dead.

Jax moved like a ghost through the labyrinth of the estate. The sheer scale of the place was a tactical nightmare. Every corner offered a blind spot; every priceless statue provided cover.

As she neared the intersection leading to the west wing, the sound of heavy plasma fire echoed down the hall.

Jax broke into a sprint, rounding the corner just as a squad of three mercenaries stacked up outside the massive, open archway of the Grand Gallery. They were laying down concentrated suppressing fire into the dark room.

Jax didn’t hesitate. She hit the deck, sliding on her knees across the polished marble, and opened fire.

Her pulse-rifle roared in the enclosed space. The heavy rounds tore through the mercenaries’ rear guard. Two of the men dropped instantly. The third spun around, his plasma-carbine raising, but Jax was already on her feet, closing the distance.

She slammed the butt of her rifle into the mercenary’s visor, shattering

the plasteel, and followed it with a brutal knee to his sternum. He crumpled.

“Aegis!” Jax yelled, stepping into the archway of the Grand Gallery. “Identify!”

The gallery was a massive, two-story room filled with Earth-art, floating holographic sculptures, and grand, sweeping staircases. It was currently being torn to shreds by plasma fire.

“Detective, take cover,” Aegis’s voice crackled over the intercom system. * “Adjusting localized gravitational parameters in three, two, one.”*

Jax threw herself backward behind a thick marble pillar just as a sickening, heavy *thud* echoed through the room.*

The gravity in the center of the gallery spiked to triple Earth-normal.

The three remaining mercenaries in the room, who had been advancing on a barricade of overturned display cases, were instantly driven to their knees. Their heavy armor suddenly weighed hundreds of pounds. One of them screamed as his femur snapped under the sheer, localized pressure.

From the shadows of the second-floor balcony, a sleek, dark figure dropped.

Because Aegis controlled the grid, the gravity well didn’t affect Elara. She landed silently amidst the pinned mercenaries, moving with a terrifying, fluid grace. The blue, crackling blade of her hard-light shiv ignited with a *hiss*.*

She moved through the men with surgical precision, disabling them in seconds. The brutal efficiency of the disgraced Special Tactics operative she had been trained by was on full display. She didn’t look like a CEO. She looked like an apex predator.

“Aegis, normalize gravity,” Elara commanded, her voice slightly breathless but entirely steady.

The crushing pressure vanished. Jax stepped out from behind the

pillar, her rifle lowered but ready.

Elara stood in the center of the ruined gallery. Her crimson jacket was gone, leaving her in the black kinetic-weave undershirt. A graze from a plasma bolt had scorched the fabric over her ribs, and her face was smudged with soot, but her silver eyes were blazing with adrenaline.

She looked up and saw Jax.

For a fraction of a second, the lethal corporate assassin melted away. Elara's breath hitched, the relief so palpable it practically radiated across the room. But then the memory of the morning—the accusation, the betrayal—slammed back down like an iron portcullis. Her posture stiffened, her jaw locking.

"I thought I told you to get a warrant, Detective," Elara said coldly, deactivating the plasma shiv and sliding the hilt into her belt.

"I skipped the paperwork," Jax said, crossing the room, her eyes sweeping the perimeter. Her chest ached at the coldness in Elara's voice, but she deserved it. "Sterling is the leak. He bought the bad steel twenty years ago. He killed Tyrell to cover it up, and he's going to kill you to close the loop."

"I figured that out about ten minutes ago when he blew my front door off its hinges," Elara retorted, stepping over a groaning mercenary to grab a discarded plasma-carbine from the floor. She checked the thermal-clip with practiced ease. "He has eight men left. He split them up. Half are hunting me, and he took the other half to the atmospheric control room in the sub-basement."

Jax frowned. "The control room? Why? If he kills you, he can frame you for Tyrell's murder. Why mess with the atmospheric controls?"

"Because if he kills me, he still has to deal with the Board of Directors," Elara said, her eyes darkening. "If he triggers a localized blowout in my estate, he destroys my personal servers. He destroys all the evidence of his twenty-year-old steel purchase. And he makes it look like the mysterious 'Helios bomber' struck the Vance Estate, killing the CEO. It's

a clean sweep.”

“He’s going to vent the estate’s atmosphere into the Martian surface,” Jax realized, a cold chill running down her spine. “We have less than ten minutes before this whole house decompresses.”

“Then we stop him,” Elara said, racking the bolt of the carbine.

She walked past Jax without looking at her, heading toward the rear service corridors.

“Elara,” Jax said, her voice catching slightly.

Elara stopped, but she didn’t turn around. Her shoulders were rigid.

“I looked at the data,” Jax said, the confession tearing out of her. “I had Chen rip it apart. You were clean. Everything you said last night... I know it was true. And I was wrong. I was so incredibly wrong.”

Elara stood perfectly still in the flickering red emergency light. When she finally spoke, her voice was a fragile, guarded whisper.

“You didn’t trust me, Jax. You looked at me and you saw another monster.”

“I saw someone who terrified me,” Jax corrected, stepping closer, the truth bleeding out of her. “I saw someone who got past my armor, and I panicked. I’ve spent my whole life waiting for the ceiling to cave in. When you got close, I sabotaged it before you could. It’s what I do. But I am here now. And I am not leaving you.”

Elara slowly turned her head, looking at Jax over her shoulder. The silver eyes were bright, searching Jax’s face for any trace of the cold, professional detachment from the morning. She didn’t find it. She only found desperate, unvarnished honesty.

“We don’t have time for a deeply flawed emotional reconciliation, Detective,” Elara said softly, though the ice in her voice had fractured.

“I know,” Jax said, gripping her rifle. “Let’s go shoot your Chief of Security.”

A ghost of a smile touched Elara’s lips. “Follow me.”

They moved as a two-woman fire-team, plunging into the depths of

the estate. The seamless, unspoken coordination they had shared in Sector 6 snapped right back into place. Jax took the point, a battering ram of heavy kinetic fire, while Elara covered the flanks, her terrifying speed and intimate knowledge of the house making her a ghost in the shadows.

Aegis fed them telemetry through the intercoms, triggering smart-doors to crush advancing mercenaries and overloading localized power conduits to blind Sterling's men.

They tore through a squad holding the grand staircase, Jax laying down a brutal suppressing arc while Elara vaulted the banister, taking two men out in close-quarters combat before they even knew she was there.

"Clear!" Jax yelled, stepping over the bodies, the barrel of her rifle smoking.

"Sub-basement access is through the wine cellar," Elara said, not missing a beat.

They reached the heavy, reinforced steel door leading to the subterranean atmospheric controls. It was magnetically sealed from the inside.

"Aegis, open this door," Elara ordered.

"I cannot, Ms. Vance," *"***" Aegis replied, his voice laced with synthetic distress. *"***" "Commander Sterling has severed the hardline to the sub-basement. I am completely locked out of the atmospheric telemetry. He has initiated the purge sequence. You have three minutes until the estate's dome seals retract and the oxygen is violently expelled."*

Jax swore, stepping up to the door and examining the locking mechanism. "It's a Class-4 magnetic seal. A breaching charge won't even scratch it."

"Step back," Elara said.

She didn't use the sonic ring this time. She dropped the carbine, stepped up to the massive steel door, and placed both her palms flat against the metal.

“Jax,” Elara said, her voice entirely calm. “When this door opens, Sterling is going to have the high ground. The control room is elevated. Do you trust me?”

Jax looked at the woman who had broken down every wall she possessed. “With my life.”

Elara closed her eyes.

A sudden, deafening hum***** vibrated through the floorboards. It wasn’t the AI. It was the estate’s localized gravity generators, being manually overridden by the biometrics in Elara’s palms.**

The metal of the heavy steel door began to groan.

“I am the CEO of Vance Interplanetary,” Elara whispered, the words echoing with terrifying power. “I own gravity.”

With a shriek of tearing metal, Elara inverted the gravitational pull on the door itself. The sheer, opposing forces ripped the massive steel slab entirely out of its reinforced hinges, hurling it backward into the dark sub-basement like a piece of paper caught in a hurricane.

“Go!” Elara yelled, dropping to her knees from the sheer exertion of the manual override.

Jax didn’t hesitate. She threw herself through the ragged opening, her pulse-rifle raised, charging straight into the belly of the beast.

Chapter Fourteen: The Confrontation

The atmospheric control room was a cavernous, subterranean cathedral of churning machinery, massive poly-steel turbines, and a labyrinth of grated catwalks. It smelled of heavy lubricants, ozone, and the sharp, metallic tang of impending decompression.

Jax dove through the ragged opening where the steel door used to be, hitting the grated floor and executing a brutal shoulder-roll just as a hail of plasma fire vaporized the space she had occupied a microsecond before.

The emergency strobes painted the room in violent flashes of crimson.

*“Atmospheric purge in two minutes, forty seconds,”**** a sterile, automated voice echoed over the roar of the turbines.

Commander Sterling was standing on the elevated primary catwalk, flanked by his last two mercenaries. He didn’t look like a corporate security chief anymore. He was wearing heavy, military-grade kinetic armor, his face twisted into a mask of desperate, cornered rage.

“Pin her down!” Sterling roared, firing a burst from a heavy repeater-

rifle.

Jax scrambled behind a massive, humming filtration tank, the kinetic rounds sparking off the reinforced metal inches from her head. She didn't stay still. She popped out from the left flank, her pulse-rifle tucked tight against her shoulder.

She fired a three-round burst. The first mercenary took the hits center-mass, his armor absorbing the brunt of it, but the kinetic force threw him backward over the catwalk railing. He plummeted thirty feet, hitting the turbine floor with a sickening crunch.

The second mercenary shifted his aim, but Jax was already moving, sliding across the slick grating. She unhooked an EMP grenade from her vest, primed it, and hurled it upward.

The grenade detonated mid-air, a silent, blinding sphere of blue energy expanding outward. It washed over the catwalk. The mercenary's augmented targeting visor and kinetic servos instantly shorted out, locking his armor into a rigid tomb. He toppled sideways, effectively neutralized.

"Atmospheric purge in one minute, fifty seconds."

Sterling swore viciously, realizing his backup was gone. He ducked behind the master control console on the elevated platform.

Jax didn't waste time reloading. She slung the rifle over her shoulder, drew her magnum, and sprinted for the metal access stairs.

She took them three at a time, her lungs burning, the injured shoulder screaming in protest. As she crested the landing, Sterling stepped out from behind the console. He didn't fire his rifle. He swung it like a baseball bat.

The heavy plasteel stock caught Jax square in the chest, right over her ceramic trauma plate.

The impact was devastating. It lifted her completely off her feet, throwing her backward into the metal railing. The breath exploded from her lungs in a violent rush. Her magnum clattered across the grated

floor, sliding over the edge and into the dark machinery below.

Jax gasped, struggling to pull oxygen into her bruised chest as Sterling advanced. He was a foot taller and outweighed her by a hundred pounds, and his cybernetic right arm hummed with lethal, hydraulic power.

"You should have stayed in the gutter, Detective," Sterling spat, drawing a heavy, serrated combat knife from his thigh sheath. "You and Vance. Two bitches who couldn't leave well enough alone."

Jax didn't bother replying. She spat a mouthful of blood onto the grating, pushed off the railing, and launched herself at him.

She ducked under his sweeping knife strike, driving her elbow upward into the unprotected joint of his armpit. Sterling grunted, but his cybernetic arm lashed out in a brutal backhand. The metal fist clipped Jax's jaw.

Her vision swam, exploding into white sparks. She tasted copper.

Sterling grabbed her by the front of her tactical vest, lifting her effortlessly, and slammed her back against the thick glass of a pressure gauge. The glass cracked under her spine.

"Atmospheric purge in sixty seconds."

"It's over," Sterling hissed, pressing his forearm against her throat, the serrated knife hovering inches from her eye. "The dome vents. You die. Elara dies. I walk away a hero who survived the Helios terror attack."

Jax choked, her hands desperately gripping his cybernetic arm, trying to push it back. The hydraulic servos whined, overpowering her. Her vision was starting to tunnel, the edges turning black.

But she was a survivor of the Tantalus mines. She knew how to fight in the dark.

Jax went limp for a fraction of a second, letting him think she was losing consciousness. The moment he adjusted his grip, she brought her knee up with devastating, targeted precision, burying it squarely in his groin.

Sterling roared, his grip loosening just enough. Jax twisted violently,

grabbing his knife hand by the wrist. She used his own forward momentum, pivoting her hips and throwing him over her shoulder in a flawless, brutal judo toss.

Sterling hit the grated catwalk hard, the knife skittering away.

Jax didn't let up. She dropped a knee onto his chest, drawing her own backup weapon—a small, snub-nosed laser-pistol from her ankle holster. She jammed the barrel directly under his chin.

“Checkmate, you son of a bitch,” Jax panted, blood dripping from her chin onto his armor. “Disable the purge.”

Sterling stared up at her, his eyes wild. But he didn't look defeated. He looked insane.

“I can't,” Sterling choked out, a bloody smile spreading across his teeth. He raised his left hand.

Clutched in his palm was a manual thermal detonator, his thumb resting heavily on the trigger switch. Wires ran from the detonator directly into the master atmospheric manifold beside the console.

“If the purge doesn't kill you, the breach will,” Sterling said. “If my thumb leaves this trigger, that manifold blows. The entire estate decompresses in a microsecond.”

Jax froze. If she shot him, his muscles would relax, the trigger would release, and they would all be sucked into the Martian vacuum. It was a dead-man's switch.

*“Atmospheric purge in thirty seconds,”***** the automated voice droned.

“Jax!”

Elara burst onto the catwalk, her chest heaving, the blue plasma shiv ignited in her hand. She had recovered from the gravity exertion, but she was favoring her left leg.

She took in the scene in a fraction of a second. Jax pinning Sterling, the gun under his chin, and the dead-man's switch in his hand wired to the manifold.

“Elara, stay back!” Jax yelled, keeping all her weight pressed down on Sterling. “He’s wired to the manifold! It’s a dead-man’s switch!”

Elara didn’t stay back. She sprinted toward the master console, her silver eyes locking onto the bundle of wires connecting Sterling’s detonator to the explosive charge on the pipes.

“I’m going to override the purge!” Elara shouted over the alarms, her fingers flying across the holographic keyboard of the terminal.

“It won’t matter if he blows the manifold!” Jax screamed, struggling as Sterling suddenly surged upward, trying to throw her off.

Jax dropped the laser pistol—she couldn’t risk an accidental discharge—and grabbed Sterling’s left hand with both of her own. She locked her fingers around his fist, using every ounce of her strength to keep his thumb clamped tightly down on the trigger.

Sterling thrashed violently, his cybernetic arm swinging. A metal fist slammed into Jax’s ribs. She heard a sickening **crack**, and a blinding wave of agony washed over her.

She screamed, but she didn’t let go of his hand.

“Elara, the wire!” Jax gasped, her vision blurring with tears of pain. “Cut the uplink wire!”

“If I cut the wrong one, it detonates!” Elara yelled back, leaving the console and dropping to her knees beside them. The bundle of wires was a chaotic mess of red, blue, and yellow casing.

“Atmospheric purge in fifteen seconds.”

Sterling laughed, a wet, choking sound, continuing to rain brutal blows against Jax’s side. “You’re dead! You’re both dead!”

“Hold him, Jax!” Elara commanded, her voice dropping into that absolute, terrifying calm. She brought the crackling blue plasma shiv close to the wiring bundle.

Jax absorbed another punishing hit to her broken ribs, her muscles screaming, her hands slick with her own blood, but she locked her grip like a vice around Sterling’s fist. “Do it! Now!”

Elara didn't hesitate. She didn't trace the wires or try to guess the schematic. She relied entirely on her intimate knowledge of Vance corporate hardware. She thrust the plasma blade forward, severing a thick, unmarked black cable buried beneath the colored decoys.

The green light on Sterling's detonator instantly blinked out.

With a roar of fury, Jax finally let go of his hand. As Sterling's thumb slipped off the dead trigger, Jax drove her fist directly into his face, putting every ounce of her remaining strength into the blow.

Sterling's head snapped back against the grating, and he went entirely limp.

*"Atmospheric purge sequence aborted,"**** the automated voice announced pleasantly. *"Manual override successful. Restoring standard ventilation parameters."*

The screaming sirens instantly cut out, replaced by the low, steady hum of the massive turbines returning to their normal cycle. The flashing red strobes shifted back to a calm, ambient white light.

It was over.

Jax collapsed sideways off Sterling's chest, rolling onto her back on the metal grating. She stared up at the cavernous ceiling, gasping for air, every single nerve in her body screaming in pain.

Elara deactivated the plasma shiv, tossing it aside. She scrambled over Sterling's unconscious body and dropped to her knees beside Jax.

"Jax," Elara breathed, her hands hovering over Jax's bloodied face and battered armor, terrified to touch her and cause more pain. "Jax, look at me."

Jax turned her head slowly. Her lip was split, her jaw was swelling rapidly, and her left eye was already turning a deep, violent shade of purple. But as she looked at the billionaire, a slow, bloody, incredibly genuine smile spread across her face.

"You know," Jax wheezed, her voice a raspy whisper, "your Chief of Security... is a real asshole."

A choked, breathless laugh tore from Elara's throat. She leaned down, carefully gathering Jax into her arms, pressing her forehead against the detective's undamaged temple. She didn't care about the blood, the sweat, or the grime. She just held on tight.

"I'll have HR update his file to reflect that," Elara whispered fiercely, closing her eyes.

Jax rested her head against Elara's shoulder, the scent of the Earth thunderstorm grounding her completely. She reached down with her right hand, painfully unclipping the heavy mag-cuffs from her belt.

She blindly tossed them onto Sterling's chest.

"Commander Sterling," Jax muttered into Elara's neck, her eyes sliding shut as the exhaustion finally pulled her under. "You're under arrest. You have the right to remain silent. I highly suggest... you shut the hell up."

Chapter Fifteen: The Compromise

Three days later, Captain Graves's office still smelled like cheap nicotine patches and stale stress, but for the first time in a decade, it also smelled distinctly of victory.

Jax sat in the poly-plas chair opposite his desk, though "sat" was a generous term. She was rigidly propped up, her torso tightly bound in a compression-brace to stabilize three cracked ribs. Her left arm was in a medical sling, her jaw was a mottled canvas of yellow and purple, and the skin around her left eye was split and sealed with dermal-glue.

She looked like she had gone three rounds with a rogue mining-droid, and she felt significantly worse.

"The Commissioner wants a press conference, Jax," Graves said, tossing a thick, physical file folder onto his desk. "Sterling gave up everything. He signed a full confession to Tyrell's murder, the Mercer frame-job, and the dome sabotage. The brass wants you on a podium looking like a battered colonial hero."

"Tell the Commissioner I succumbed to my injuries," Jax said flatly,

wincing as the simple act of speaking pulled at her ribs. “I don’t do press. Let Chen take the podium. She cracked the data.”

“Chen threw up in a wastebasket when I suggested it,” Graves sighed, rubbing his face. “Fine. I’ll handle the vultures. But you are officially on mandatory medical leave for the next three weeks. Don’t argue with me, Jax. If I see you in this bullpen before your ribs knit, I will shoot you myself.”

Jax didn’t argue. She was entirely out of fight.

“What about the dome?” Jax asked, shifting carefully in the chair.

“Vance Interplanetary went public with the structural flaw yesterday morning,” Graves said, leaning back. “Elara Vance completely bypassed her own PR department and legal team. She released the original twenty-year-old manufacturing manifests to the colonial grid. Then, she fired half her board of directors and pledged fifty billion credits of her own personal equity to retro-fit the entire Sector 4 dome with military-grade, flawless poly-steel. No government contracts. No taxpayer money.”

Jax stared at Graves. “She just... took the hit?”

“She took the hit, survived the fallout, and somehow managed to make her stock price jump three percent by the afternoon,” Graves said, shaking his head in bewildered admiration. “The woman is a terrifying force of nature, Jax. And she’s been calling my private comm-line every four hours to check on your medical status. Tell her to stop. She scares my wife.”

Jax looked down at her battered combat boots. A heavy, complicated knot tightened in her chest.

She had avoided Elara for three days. After the paramedics had swarmed the sub-basement, separating them, Jax had buried herself in the bureaucratic nightmare of booking Sterling, filing reports, and undergoing agonizing medical scans.

She had used the badge as a shield one last time, because she was terrified of facing the billionaire after what she had said in the boardroom.

"I'll handle it, Cap," Jax said quietly. She pushed herself up out of the chair, biting back a groan.

"Good work, Detective," Graves said softly as she reached the door. "You saved a lot of lives."

"Just doing my job, Captain."

The mag-lev ride to the Zenith Domes was much slower this time. Jax didn't push the unmarked spinner. She let the autopilot navigate the ascent, watching the industrial smog of Sector 4 fall away, replaced by the pristine, artificial blue sky of the upper atmosphere.

The Vance Estate looked exactly as it had the first time she saw it, the massive mahogany doors perfectly restored. Elara's fixers were as efficient as her assassins.

Jax stepped out of the spinner, bracing herself against the localized Earth-normal gravity. It dragged at her broken ribs, a heavy, invisible weight.

She didn't need to ring the chime. The doors swung open silently.

"You are leaking bio-fluids onto the portico again, Detective," Aegis said, his hard-light hologram materializing in the foyer.

"It's just dermal-glue, Aegis," Jax said, stepping inside. "And hello to you, too. Glad to see Sterling didn't scramble your core programming."

"It would take a mind far superior to a corporate thug's to unravel my matrix," the AI sniffed imperiously. But his holographic eyes flicked over her bandages with something that almost approximated synthetic concern. "Ms. Vance is on the western terrace. I suggest you proceed slowly. Your heart rate is currently elevated to an unhealthy degree."

"Thanks for the medical update," Jax muttered.

She walked slowly through the quiet halls of the estate. The Grand Gallery had been entirely cleared of debris, the shattered marble pillars already replaced. It was as if the brutal, bloody firefight had never happened.

Jax stepped out onto the western terrace.

It was a sprawling, open-air balcony overlooking the sheer drop of the colony's outer wall. Beyond the invisible atmospheric shielding, the red Martian desert stretched out forever, bathed in the fiery, bruised-purple light of a dying sunset.

Elara was standing at the edge of the glass railing, a crystal tumbler of amber liquid in her hand. She was wearing a simple, flowing white silk shirt and dark trousers, the wind catching the fabric. A small, pale dermal-patch rested on her cheekbone where she had been grazed by plasma fire.

She didn't turn around as Jax approached, but Jax knew she had heard the heavy tread of her boots.

"Aegis told me you were released from the medical bay," Elara said, her voice quiet, carrying over the faint hum of the dome's wind-scrubbers.

"Graves benched me for three weeks," Jax said, stopping a few feet behind her.

Elara finally turned. Her silver eyes swept over Jax, taking in the sling, the compression brace visible beneath her shirt, and the bruised jaw. The cold, impenetrable CEO mask wasn't there. She just looked incredibly tired, and incredibly relieved.

"You look terrible, Detective," Elara murmured.

"You should see the other guy," Jax replied, attempting a smirk that quickly turned into a wince.

A heavy, fragile silence settled between them. The adrenaline was gone. The case was closed. There were no more serial killers or dome-bombers to hide behind. It was just the two of them, and the massive, gaping wound Jax had opened in the boardroom.

Jax took a deep breath, fighting through the physical pain and the sheer terror of being vulnerable.

"I was wrong," Jax said, her voice rough, stripped of all its usual abrasive armor. "In the boardroom. I looked at the evidence, and I

looked at you, and I chose to believe the worst. Not because it made logical sense, but because it was easier.”

Elara’s grip on her crystal tumbler tightened. “Easier to believe I was a monster than to believe I actually cared?”

“Easier to push you away before you could leave,” Jax corrected, stepping closer. “In the mines... the only warning you get before a cave-in is the silence. Everything just stops. And then the roof comes down. When you came to my apartment, when you... when you let me breathe for the first time in ten years... it was quiet. And I panicked. I thought the roof was about to cave in.”

Jax stopped a foot away from Elara, looking up into those startling silver eyes. “I am broken, Elara. I have a decade of street-level paranoia etched into my bones. I am abrasive, I drink terrible coffee, and I don’t know how to let people in. But I am so incredibly sorry that I made you pay for my ghosts.”

Elara stared at her for a long, breathless moment. The wind whipped her dark hair around her face.

Slowly, deliberately, Elara set her glass down on the stone railing. She stepped into Jax’s space. She didn’t touch the injured shoulder or the bruised ribs. She reached up, her cool, elegant hands gently framing Jax’s face, her thumbs resting lightly over the dermal-glue near her eye.

“I build roofs for a living, Jax,” Elara whispered fiercely, the intensity in her voice making Jax’s pulse hammer. “Mine do not cave in.”

Jax let out a shuddering breath, her eyes fluttering shut as she leaned into the touch. “Vance...”

“You are abrasive. You are entirely too stubborn, and your apartment is a hazard to human health,” Elara murmured, stepping flush against Jax, mindful of her injuries. “But you are also the only person on this entire godforsaken planet who looks at me and doesn’t see a bank account. You see me. And I am not going anywhere.”

Jax opened her eyes. The raw, unfiltered affection radiating from the

billionaire was overwhelming, a gravitational pull she couldn't fight even if she wanted to.

"You're sure?" Jax asked, her voice a breathless rasp. "Because I come with a lot of collateral damage."

A slow, devastating, wicked smile curved Elara's lips. "I specialize in hostile takeovers, Detective. I can handle a little collateral damage."

Elara tilted her head and kissed her.

It was soft at first, cautious of Jax's split lip, but the moment Jax's good arm wrapped around Elara's waist and pulled her close, the caution evaporated. The kiss deepened, reigniting the searing, electric heat from the apartment, but this time, there were no shadows. There was no fear of betrayal. It was an absolute, grounding surrender.

Jax groaned into the kiss, her fingers tangling in the silk of Elara's shirt, anchoring herself to the only real thing in her life. The scent of the Earth thunderstorm wrapped around her, entirely washing away the smell of the precinct and the hospital.

When they finally pulled apart, both of them were breathing heavily, their foreheads resting against each other.

"Three weeks of mandatory medical leave," Elara noted, her thumb tracing the line of Jax's jaw. "That presents a unique logistical opportunity."

Jax raised an eyebrow, ignoring the throbbing in her ribs. "Does it?"

"Aegis is preparing a guest suite on the east wing," Elara said seamlessly, stepping back just enough to take Jax's uninjured hand, her fingers interlacing with Jax's calloused ones. "It has a zero-gravity therapeutic immersion tank for your ribs. And I have instructed the kitchens to burn all synthetic food on the premises."

Jax let out a rough bark of laughter, instantly clutching her side. "You're moving me in? Already? Is this a kidnapping, Vance?"

"It's a strategic relocation," Elara corrected smoothly, pulling Jax gently toward the sweeping glass doors of the estate. "You are my

chief security consultant now. It's an informal title, but it comes with excellent perks."

Jax stopped, gently pulling Elara back.

She looked out over the glass railing, toward the vast, dark expanse of the Martian horizon. The sun had finally dipped beneath the jagged red craters, leaving behind a sky ablaze with a million cold, distant stars. For the first time since she had walked out of the Tantalus mines, the vastness didn't terrify her.

She looked back at Elara, who was watching her with that same, intense, predatory affection.

"A consultant," Jax mused, a genuine smirk finally settling on her face. "Does the consultant get more of that Earth-grown coffee?"

Elara smiled, a brilliant, terrifying flash of corporate teeth and genuine warmth. "The consultant gets whatever she wants."

"Then lead the way, partner," Jax said.

As they walked back into the warmth and light of the estate, the heavy mahogany doors sealing shut against the cold Martian night, Detective Jax realized something profoundly terrifying and wonderful.

The silence wasn't a warning anymore. It was just peace.

Chapter Sixteen: The Morning After

Jax woke to sunlight.

Not the harsh, filtered red glow of Sector 4's industrial lamps, but actual sunlight—pale gold streaming through floor-to-ceiling smart-glass windows that had automatically adjusted to let in the dawn. For a disorienting moment, she didn't know where she was.

Then the pain hit.

Her ribs screamed in protest as she tried to sit up, a sharp, stabbing agony that made her gasp and collapse back against the pillows. Her left shoulder throbbed where Sterling had slammed her into the pressure gauge. Her knuckles were split and swollen. Every breath felt like someone was driving a knife between her ribs.

"Don't move," a voice said softly.

Jax turned her head—carefully, because even that hurt—and saw Elara sitting in a chair beside the bed. She was dressed in a simple black shirt and tactical pants, her silver hair pulled back in a loose braid. She looked exhausted, dark circles under her eyes, but her gaze was sharp and focused.

"How long was I out?" Jax rasped, her throat dry.

"Fourteen hours," Elara said. She stood, moving to the bedside table

where a glass of water sat waiting. "You collapsed in the mag-lev on the way back. Aegis had to carry you inside."

"Embarrassing," Jax muttered, accepting the water with her good hand. She drank greedily, the cool liquid soothing her parched throat.

"You had three broken ribs, a dislocated shoulder, a concussion, and enough adrenaline in your system to kill a horse," Elara said, her tone clinical but her eyes betraying genuine concern. "You're lucky you didn't go into shock."

Jax set the glass down, wincing as the movement pulled at her ribs. "I've had worse."

"I know," Elara said quietly. "I read your medical file from Tantalus, remember?"

The words hung in the air between them, heavy with meaning. Jax looked away, staring at the sunlight streaming through the windows. She'd spent fifteen years building walls around that memory, and Elara had walked through them like they were made of paper.

"Let me see your ribs," Elara said, moving closer.

"I'm fine."

"Jax." Elara's voice was firm, brooking no argument. "Let me see."

Jax hesitated, then slowly pulled up the borrowed shirt she was wearing—one of Elara's, she realized, soft and expensive and smelling faintly of cedar. The movement made her hiss in pain.

Elara's expression didn't change, but Jax saw her jaw tighten as she examined the damage. The entire left side of Jax's torso was a mottled canvas of purple and black bruises, the skin swollen and tender. Dermal-glue held together a long gash across her ribs where Sterling's knife had caught her.

"The med-scanner said you refused bone-knit injections," Elara said, her fingers hovering just above the bruises, not quite touching.

"Can't afford them," Jax said flatly. "Not on a detective's salary."

"You're in my house," Elara said, her silver eyes flashing. "Money

isn't an issue."

"I don't want your charity."

"It's not charity." Elara's voice was sharp now, cutting. "It's basic medical care for someone who nearly died saving my life. Don't be stubborn about this."

Jax wanted to argue. Every instinct she had screamed at her to refuse, to maintain her independence, to not owe anyone anything. But the pain was making it hard to think, and the look in Elara's eyes—fierce and protective and utterly uncompromising—made something in her chest tighten.

"Fine," she said finally.

Elara nodded once, then moved to a medical kit on the dresser. She returned with a bone-knit injector, the kind that cost three months of Jax's salary. She pressed it against Jax's ribs, and there was a soft hiss as the nanites flooded into her bloodstream.

The relief was almost immediate. The sharp, stabbing pain dulled to a manageable ache, and Jax felt the broken bones beginning to knit themselves back together. She let out a shaky breath.

"Better?" Elara asked.

"Yeah," Jax admitted. "Thanks."

Elara set the injector aside, then sat on the edge of the bed. For a long moment, neither of them spoke. The silence was comfortable, intimate in a way that made Jax's heart race.

"You came back," Elara said finally, her voice soft. "Even after I gave you every reason to walk away, you came back."

"You were in danger," Jax said, as if that explained everything.

"So were a lot of people," Elara countered. "You could have called TRT, let them handle it. But you came yourself."

Jax looked at her, at the woman who had stripped herself bare and handed over her entire empire just to prove her innocence. The woman who had fought beside her, who had trusted her with everything.

"I couldn't let him kill you," Jax said, the words raw and honest. "I couldn't... I couldn't lose you."

Elara's breath caught. She reached out, her fingers brushing against Jax's cheek with infinite gentleness. "You're not going to lose me. Not now. Not ever."

"You can't promise that," Jax said, but her voice lacked conviction.

"Watch me," Elara said, and leaned in to kiss her.

It was soft, careful, mindful of Jax's injuries. But it was also fierce, claiming, a promise sealed with touch. Jax's good hand came up to tangle in Elara's hair, pulling her closer despite the pain in her ribs.

When they finally broke apart, both of them were breathing hard.

"What happens now?" Jax asked, her voice barely above a whisper.

Elara was quiet for a moment, her silver eyes searching Jax's face. "I have to hold a press conference. Disclose everything—the manufacturing defect, Sterling's embezzlement, Tyrell's murder. The board is going to fight me, but I don't care. Two hundred thousand people deserve to know the truth."

"The stock price will tank," Jax said.

"Probably," Elara agreed. "But I'll survive. Vance Interplanetary will survive. And more importantly, Sector 4 will survive."

"You're going to retrofit the dome," Jax said. It wasn't a question.

"Fifty billion credits," Elara confirmed. "Full structural replacement, not just patches. It'll take two years, but when it's done, that dome will be the safest structure on Mars."

Jax stared at her, something fierce and painful swelling in her chest. "You're really going to do it. You're going to fix your father's mistakes."

"I'm going to try," Elara said. "And you're going to help me."

"I'm a cop, not an engineer."

"You're a consultant," Elara corrected, a hint of amusement in her voice. "And you know Sector 4 better than anyone. I need someone who understands what those people need, not just what the engineers think

they need.”

Jax wanted to argue, but the words died in her throat. Because Elara was right. She did know Sector 4. She knew the cramped bunkers, the recycled air, the constant fear of structural failure. She knew what it was like to live in a place where the walls could collapse at any moment.

“Okay,” she said finally. “I’ll help.”

Elara smiled, brilliant and genuine. “Good. Because I wasn’t giving you a choice.”

Before Jax could respond, the door to the bedroom slid open, and Aegis’s holographic form materialized in the doorway. The AI butler looked as impeccably dressed as ever, his virtual bow tie perfectly straight.

“Forgive the intrusion,” Aegis said, his tone dripping with sarcasm, “but I felt compelled to inform you both that the world has not, in fact, ended during your extended... recuperation.”

“What do you want, Aegis?” Elara asked, though there was no real heat in her voice.

“Captain Graves has called seventeen times in the past hour,” Aegis said. “He is, and I quote, ‘losing his goddamn mind’ trying to reach Detective Jax. Apparently, there is a rather urgent matter involving Commander Sterling’s interrogation.”

Jax sat up straighter, ignoring the protest from her ribs. “Sterling’s awake?”

“Awake, coherent, and demanding his lawyer,” Aegis confirmed. “Captain Graves would like you at Precinct 12 within the hour.”

Jax swung her legs over the side of the bed, gritting her teeth against the pain. “I need to get dressed.”

“Your clothes were destroyed,” Elara said. “I had Aegis order replacements. They’re in the closet.”

Jax looked at her, something warm and terrifying blooming in her chest. “You didn’t have to do that.”

"I know," Elara said simply. "But I wanted to."

Aegis cleared his virtual throat. "If I may offer an observation, it is both deeply unsettling and oddly heartwarming to see you two functioning as a cohesive unit. I had calculated a seventy-three percent probability that you would kill each other within the first week."

"We still might," Jax muttered, standing carefully.

"Unlikely," Aegis said. "Miss Vance has already reprogrammed the estate's security protocols to recognize you as a permanent resident. Your biometric signature now has Level-2 clearance."

Jax froze, turning to stare at Elara. "You did what?"

Elara met her gaze evenly. "You're not a guest anymore, Jax. This is your home now, if you want it to be."

The words hit Jax like a physical blow. Home. She hadn't had a home since Tantalus. Just a series of temporary bunkers and cramped apartments, places to sleep between shifts. The idea of having a home—a real home, with someone who wanted her there—was almost too much to process.

"I..." Jax started, then stopped, her throat too tight to speak.

Elara stood, crossing the distance between them. She cupped Jax's face in her hands, her silver eyes fierce and tender. "You don't have to decide right now. But know that the offer stands. Always."

Jax nodded, not trusting herself to speak. She leaned into Elara's touch, letting herself have this moment of vulnerability, of trust.

"Now," Elara said, stepping back with a small smile, "go interrogate Sterling. Make him pay for what he did."

"Count on it," Jax said, her voice hard.

As she headed toward the closet, Aegis's voice followed her. "Do try not to break any more ribs, Detective. Miss Vance's medical supplies are expensive, and I have a budget to maintain."

"No promises," Jax called back.

But as she dressed in the new clothes—tactical pants, a reinforced

jacket, boots that actually fit—she felt something she hadn't felt in fifteen years.

Hope.

Chapter Seventeen: The Confession

Precinct 12's interrogation room smelled like stale coffee, sweat, and desperation.

Jax had spent countless hours in this room, watching suspects crack under pressure, watching them lie and deflect and eventually confess. She knew every crack in the concrete walls, every flicker of the overhead lights, every squeak of the metal chairs bolted to the floor.

But she'd never felt quite like this before.

Commander James Sterling sat across from her, his hands cuffed to the table, his face a mask of cold indifference. He looked like he'd just come from a board meeting, not a holding cell. His uniform was rumpled but clean, his posture perfect, his expression utterly devoid of emotion.

He looked at Jax like she was a minor inconvenience.

Chen sat beside Jax, her fingers poised over her tablet, ready to record every word. Captain Graves stood in the corner, his arms crossed, his expression grim. The recording module on the table pulsed with a steady red light.

“Interview with Commander James Sterling,” Jax said, her voice flat and professional. “Present are Detective Jax, Officer Chen, and Captain Graves. Commander Sterling has waived his right to legal counsel.”

“I don’t need a lawyer,” Sterling said, his voice calm and measured. “I’m not going to lie to you, Detective. What would be the point?”

Jax leaned back in her chair, studying him. “You murdered Marcus Tyrell. You framed Kaelen Mercer. You planted a bomb in the Sector 1 transit hub. You attempted to murder Elara Vance and stage her suicide. And you embezzled nine hundred million credits twenty years ago by purchasing substandard poly-steel for the Sector 4 dome.”

Sterling didn’t flinch. “Yes.”

The simple admission hung in the air like a gunshot. Chen’s fingers froze over her tablet. Graves straightened, his eyes narrowing.

“Just like that?” Jax said, her voice hard. “No denial? No excuses?”

“Why would I deny it?” Sterling asked, tilting his head slightly. “You have the evidence. The procurement records, the financial trail, the security footage from the estate. Lying would be... inefficient.”

“Inefficient,” Jax repeated, her hands clenching into fists under the table. “You killed a man. You were going to kill two hundred thousand people. And you call it inefficient?”

Sterling’s expression didn’t change. “I call it pragmatic. Twenty years ago, I saw an opportunity. The Sector 4 dome project was over-budget, behind schedule, and hemorrhaging money. I found a supplier who could provide poly-steel at forty percent below market rate. I pocketed the difference. It was a sound business decision.”

“It was fraud,” Graves said from the corner, his voice like gravel.

“It was capitalism,” Sterling corrected. “The dome was built. The project was completed on time. Vance Interplanetary made a profit. Everyone won.”

“Except the two hundred thousand people living under a defective dome,” Jax said, her voice shaking with barely controlled rage. “Except

Marcus Tyrell, who you murdered when he discovered what you'd done."

Sterling sighed, as if explaining something to a particularly slow child. "Tyrell was a problem. He was running stress tests on the dome's structural integrity, and he found the harmonic frequency flaw. He traced it back to the poly-steel composition, and from there, it was only a matter of time before he found my signature on the procurement order."

"So you killed him," Jax said.

"I eliminated the problem," Sterling said. "Tyrell was going to expose the defect, which would have triggered a full investigation. Vance Interplanetary would have been liable for trillions in damages. The company would have collapsed. Thousands of people would have lost their jobs. The entire Martian economy would have been destabilized."

"So you decided to play God," Jax said, leaning forward. "You decided that Tyrell's life was worth less than your reputation."

"I decided that one life was an acceptable cost to prevent a catastrophic economic collapse," Sterling said calmly. "It was a calculated risk assessment."

Chen made a small, choked sound. Jax glanced at her, saw the horror and disgust on her partner's face, and felt a surge of cold fury.

"Walk me through it," Jax said, her voice deadly quiet. "How did you kill him?"

Sterling leaned back in his chair, his cuffed hands resting on the table. "I accessed the Vance Estate's security system and disabled the cameras in Penthouse 4A. I knew Tyrell would be working late—he always did. I entered through the service elevator using my Level-1 clearance. He was at his desk, reviewing the stress test data."

"Did he see you coming?" Jax asked.

"Yes," Sterling said. "He looked up when I entered. He even smiled. He thought I was there to discuss the findings."

"And then you killed him."

“I used a Class-4 laser scalpel,” Sterling said, his tone clinical. “Precise, clean, minimal blood spatter. I made the first incision across his throat to sever the carotid artery and prevent him from calling for help. Then I opened his chest cavity to access the lungs. I wanted it to look like a message killing, something brutal and personal. I needed the investigation to focus on external threats—competitors, cartels, anyone but internal corporate personnel.”

Jax felt bile rise in her throat. She’d seen the crime scene, seen what Sterling had done to Tyrell’s body. But hearing him describe it in such cold, detached terms made it somehow worse.

“You carved him open like a science experiment,” she said.

“I made it look like a crime of passion,” Sterling corrected. “And it worked. You immediately started investigating Vance’s competitors. You looked at Silas Vane, at Kaelen Mercer. You never once considered that the killer might be someone inside the company.”

“Until Tyrell’s encrypted files led us to the procurement records,” Chen said, her voice tight.

Sterling nodded. “That was my mistake. I knew Tyrell was meticulous, but I underestimated how thoroughly he’d documented his findings. By the time I realized he’d created a backup of the stress test data and the procurement records, it was too late. You’d already started digging.”

“So you framed Mercer,” Jax said.

“I created a false trail,” Sterling said. “I used a dark-web broker to set up a fake auction for the dome schematics. I wired ten million credits from an offshore account registered to a shell company that could be traced back to Helios Terraforming. I planted evidence in Mercer’s logistics compound—encrypted files, financial records, enough to make him look guilty.”

“And the bomb at the transit hub?” Graves asked.

“A test,” Sterling said simply. “I needed to confirm that the harmonic frequency Tyrell had identified would actually trigger a structural failure.”

The transit hub uses the same poly-steel composition as the Sector 4 dome. I planted a resonance device tuned to the exact frequency. When it detonated, it created a micro-fracture in the support beam—exactly as Tyrell’s calculations predicted.”

“You could have killed hundreds of people,” Chen said, her voice shaking.

“The device was calibrated to minimize casualties,” Sterling said. “I’m not a monster, Officer Chen. I’m a pragmatist.”

“You’re a murderer,” Jax said flatly.

Sterling met her gaze, his eyes cold and empty. “I’m a man who made difficult decisions to protect something larger than myself. Vance Interplanetary employs over two million people across the solar system. It provides life support, water, food, and infrastructure to every colony from Mercury to the Kuiper Belt. If the company had collapsed, millions would have died. I saved those lives.”

“By killing Marcus Tyrell,” Jax said.

“By making a sacrifice,” Sterling said. “One life for millions. It’s basic mathematics.”

Jax stood abruptly, her chair scraping against the concrete floor. She wanted to put her fist through Sterling’s face, to make him feel even a fraction of the pain he’d caused. But she forced herself to stay still, to breathe, to remember that she was a cop, not an executioner.

“What about Elara?” she asked, her voice low and dangerous. “Why did you try to kill her?”

For the first time, something flickered in Sterling’s expression. Not remorse, but something close to regret.

“Miss Vance was... an obstacle,” he said carefully. “When you started closing in on the truth, I realized I needed a scapegoat. Someone with access, motive, and opportunity. Elara fit the profile perfectly. She inherited her father’s company, his legacy, his sins. If I could stage her suicide and plant evidence suggesting she’d killed Tyrell to cover up

the manufacturing defect, the investigation would close. The company would survive. The dome would be quietly retrofitted. Everyone would move on."

"Except Elara would be dead," Jax said.

"Except Elara would be dead," Sterling agreed. "But she would have died a martyr. Her sacrifice would have saved the company, saved the colony. It would have been... poetic."

"You're insane," Chen breathed.

"I'm logical," Sterling said. "There's a difference."

Jax leaned forward, bracing her hands on the table. "You failed. Elara's alive. Tyrell's murder is solved. The manufacturing defect is going to be disclosed. And you're going to spend the rest of your life in a penal colony on Titan, breathing recycled air and eating synthetic protein paste."

Sterling smiled, a cold, empty expression that didn't reach his eyes. "Perhaps. But I don't regret my actions, Detective. I did what needed to be done. If I had to do it again, I would make the same choices."

"Then you're a sociopath," Jax said.

"I'm a realist," Sterling said. "And in twenty years, when the Sector 4 dome is still standing and two hundred thousand people are still breathing, you'll understand that I was right."

Jax straightened, her hands shaking with barely controlled rage. "Interview concluded. Commander Sterling, you're formally charged with first-degree murder, conspiracy to commit murder, attempted murder, fraud, embezzlement, and terrorism. You'll be transferred to maximum security pending trial."

Sterling nodded once, as if she'd just confirmed a meeting time. "Understood."

Graves moved forward, unlocking Sterling's cuffs from the table and hauling him to his feet. "Let's go."

As they led Sterling out of the interrogation room, he paused in the doorway, looking back at Jax.

"You're a good detective, Jax," he said. "You followed the evidence, you didn't give up, and you caught me. I respect that. But remember—I almost won. If you hadn't been so personally invested in protecting Elara Vance, I would have succeeded."

"Get him out of here," Jax said, her voice flat.

Graves shoved Sterling through the door, and it slid shut with a heavy clang.

For a long moment, Jax and Chen sat in silence, the weight of Sterling's confession pressing down on them like a physical force.

"He's not sorry," Chen said finally, her voice small. "He doesn't regret any of it."

"No," Jax agreed. "He doesn't."

"How do you live with that?" Chen asked, looking at Jax with wide, haunted eyes. "How do you accept that someone can kill another person and feel nothing?"

Jax was quiet for a moment, thinking about Tantalus, about the fourteen-year-old girl who'd crawled out of the rubble and decided to speak for the dead.

"You don't accept it," she said finally. "You just make sure they pay for it."

Chen nodded slowly, then stood. "I'm going to file the formal charges. The prosecutor's going to have a field day with this confession."

"Good," Jax said. "Make sure Sterling never sees daylight again."

As Chen left, Jax sat alone in the interrogation room, staring at the empty chair where Sterling had sat. She thought about his cold, clinical confession, about the way he'd described Tyrell's murder like it was a business transaction.

And she thought about Elara, who was about to face the media and the world and take responsibility for her father's sins.

Sterling had been wrong about one thing.

He hadn't almost won.

He'd lost the moment he underestimated the people he was trying to destroy.

Chapter Eighteen: The Public Reckoning

The press conference was held in the main atrium of Vance Interplanetary headquarters, a soaring cathedral of glass and steel that overlooked the Zenith Domes.

Jax stood at the back of the room, her arms crossed, watching as journalists and media drones jockeyed for position. There had to be at least two hundred people crammed into the space—reporters from every major news network in the solar system, colonial government officials, corporate representatives, and a handful of Sector 4 residents who'd somehow managed to get past security.

The air was electric with anticipation.

Everyone knew something big was coming. Vance Interplanetary had called an emergency press conference with less than six hours' notice. Rumors were already flying—a hostile takeover, a major safety violation, a scandal involving the CEO.

They had no idea how right they were.

Jax's ribs still ached despite the bone-knit injections, and her shoulder

throbbed with every breath. But she'd refused to stay at the estate. She needed to be here, needed to see Elara face the consequences of her father's legacy.

Needed to see her take responsibility.

The lights dimmed, and a hush fell over the crowd. A massive holographic display materialized at the front of the room, showing the Vance Interplanetary logo—a stylized V wrapped around a planet.

Then Elara walked onto the stage.

She was dressed in a severe black suit, her silver hair pulled back in a tight braid, her expression calm and composed. She looked every inch the billionaire CEO, powerful and untouchable. But Jax could see the tension in her shoulders, the slight tightness around her eyes.

She was terrified.

Elara stepped up to the podium, her hands resting lightly on the edges. The holographic display behind her shifted, showing a schematic of the Sector 4 dome.

"Good afternoon," Elara said, her voice clear and steady. "Thank you all for coming on such short notice. I'm here today to address a matter of critical importance to the safety and security of Ares Prime."

The journalists leaned forward, their recording devices humming.

"Twenty-three years ago," Elara continued, "Vance Interplanetary was contracted to construct the atmospheric dome for Sector 4. The project was completed on time and under budget. It was hailed as an engineering marvel, a testament to human ingenuity and corporate efficiency."

She paused, her silver eyes sweeping across the crowd.

"It was also built with defective materials."

The room erupted.

Journalists shouted questions, cameras flashed, drones buzzed overhead. The colonial officials in the front row looked like they'd been struck by lightning. Jax saw one of the Sector 4 residents—a middle-aged

woman with grease-stained coveralls—go pale and grip the armrest of her chair.

Elara waited, her expression unchanging, until the noise died down.

“The poly-steel used in the dome’s primary support structure was purchased from a supplier who provided substandard materials at below-market rates,” she said. “This decision was made by Commander James Sterling, then the Chief Procurement Officer for Vance Interplanetary. Commander Sterling embezzled nine hundred million credits by pocketing the difference between the contracted price and the actual cost of the materials.”

The holographic display shifted, showing procurement records, financial transactions, and Sterling’s signature on the authorization forms.

“Three weeks ago,” Elara continued, “Marcus Tyrell, Vice President of Atmospheric Engineering, discovered a critical flaw in the dome’s structural integrity. He traced the flaw back to the defective poly-steel and began investigating the original procurement records. When Commander Sterling learned of this investigation, he murdered Mr. Tyrell to prevent the truth from being exposed.”

The room went silent.

Jax watched as the journalists processed the information, saw the moment when shock turned to outrage. This wasn’t just corporate malfeasance. This was murder, conspiracy, and a cover-up that had put two hundred thousand lives at risk.

“Commander Sterling has been arrested and charged with first-degree murder, conspiracy, attempted murder, fraud, embezzlement, and terrorism,” Elara said. “He has confessed to all charges. The Ares Prime Police Department, led by Detective Jax and Officer Chen, conducted a thorough and professional investigation that brought Commander Sterling to justice.”

Jax felt every eye in the room turn toward her. She kept her expression neutral, her arms crossed, refusing to acknowledge the attention.

“However,” Elara continued, her voice hardening, “Commander Sterling’s crimes do not absolve Vance Interplanetary of responsibility. The defective materials were purchased under our company’s name. The dome was built under our supervision. The safety of Sector 4’s residents was our responsibility, and we failed them.”

The holographic display shifted again, showing a detailed schematic of the dome’s structural flaws, the harmonic frequency calculations, and the projected timeline for catastrophic failure.

“If left unaddressed,” Elara said, “the Sector 4 dome would have suffered a catastrophic structural collapse within eighteen months. Two hundred thousand people would have died.”

The Sector 4 resident in the front row let out a choked sob. Jax saw her bury her face in her hands, her shoulders shaking.

“Effective immediately,” Elara said, her voice ringing out across the silent room, “Vance Interplanetary is committing fifty billion credits to a complete retrofit of the Sector 4 dome. We will replace every structural support, every pressure seal, every atmospheric regulator. The work will begin within thirty days and will be completed within two years. During the retrofit, all Sector 4 residents will receive temporary housing in Sectors 2 and 3, with full compensation for relocation costs.”

The journalists erupted again, shouting questions, demanding details. Elara raised a hand, and the noise subsided.

“Additionally,” she continued, “Vance Interplanetary will undergo a complete internal audit of all infrastructure projects completed in the past twenty-five years. Any structural flaws or safety violations will be disclosed to the colonial government and remediated at our expense. We will also implement new transparency protocols, including independent third-party safety inspections and public disclosure of all procurement records.”

She paused, her silver eyes sweeping across the crowd one final time.

“My father built this company on a foundation of innovation and

ambition,” she said quietly. “But he also built it on secrecy, on cutting corners, on prioritizing profit over people. I inherited his legacy, and I take full responsibility for the consequences of his decisions. Vance Interplanetary will do better. We will be better. And we will never again put profit before the lives of the people we serve.”

The room was silent for a long moment.

Then, slowly, the Sector 4 resident in the front row stood. She was crying, tears streaming down her face, but she was also clapping. The sound echoed through the atrium, loud and defiant.

One by one, the other Sector 4 residents stood and joined her. Then some of the journalists. Then the colonial officials.

Within moments, the entire room was on its feet, applauding.

Elara stood at the podium, her expression carefully neutral, but Jax saw the way her hands trembled slightly as she gripped the edges. She saw the way Elara’s eyes found hers across the crowded room, seeking reassurance, seeking strength.

Jax nodded once, a small, private gesture.

You did it, she thought. *You told the truth.*

The applause finally died down, and the journalists surged forward, shouting questions.

“Miss Vance, what will this do to the company’s stock price?”

“How do you respond to accusations that you knew about the defect?”

“Will you resign as CEO?”

Elara held up a hand, silencing them. “I will take three questions.”

A journalist from the Mars Colonial Tribune stepped forward. “Miss Vance, the retrofit will cost fifty billion credits. Can Vance Interplanetary afford that?”

“Yes,” Elara said simply. “We have the capital reserves, and I’m personally guaranteeing the funding. If necessary, I will liquidate my private assets to ensure the project is completed.”

Another journalist, this one from Earth News Network, raised her hand.

“There are rumors that you were romantically involved with the lead detective on this case. Can you comment on that?”

The room went silent, every eye turning to Elara.

Jax felt her stomach drop. She’d known this question was coming, but hearing it out loud made it real, made it dangerous.

Elara’s expression didn’t change. “Detective Jax conducted a thorough, professional, and unbiased investigation. She followed the evidence, arrested the perpetrator, and brought justice for Marcus Tyrell. My personal relationship with her—whatever form it may take—has no bearing on the integrity of her work.”

It wasn’t a denial. It wasn’t a confirmation. It was a perfectly calibrated non-answer that somehow managed to be both honest and evasive.

Jax felt a surge of admiration despite herself.

The final question came from a colonial government official, a stern-looking man in a gray suit. “Miss Vance, the government will be launching a full investigation into Vance Interplanetary’s safety practices. Will you cooperate?”

“Absolutely,” Elara said. “We will provide full access to all records, all personnel, and all facilities. Transparency is not optional—it’s mandatory.”

She stepped back from the podium, nodding once to the crowd. “Thank you for your time.”

As Elara walked off the stage, the journalists erupted again, shouting questions, demanding more information. But Elara didn’t look back. She walked through a side door, flanked by security, and disappeared.

Jax pushed through the crowd, ignoring the journalists who tried to intercept her. She made it to the side corridor just as Captain Graves caught up with her.

“Jax, wait,” Graves said, his voice urgent.

She stopped, turning to face him. “What?”

Graves looked exhausted, dark circles under his eyes, his uniform

rumpled. "The Commissioner wants to see you. Now."

"Why?"

"Because you just solved the biggest case in Martian history, and you're apparently sleeping with the CEO of the company at the center of it," Graves said bluntly. "Internal Affairs is going to have a field day."

Jax felt a cold knot of dread settle in her stomach. "I didn't compromise the investigation."

"I know that," Graves said. "But you need to convince the Commissioner. And you need to do it before the media turns this into a scandal."

Jax looked down the corridor, toward the door where Elara had disappeared. She wanted to go after her, to make sure she was okay, to tell her that she'd been brilliant and brave and everything Jax had hoped she would be.

But duty came first.

"Fine," she said. "Let's get this over with."

As she followed Graves back through the atrium, Jax caught a glimpse of the holographic display. It was showing footage of the Sector 4 dome, the massive structure that had been built on lies and corruption and blood.

But it was also showing the retrofit plans, the new materials, the promise of safety and security for two hundred thousand people.

Marcus Tyrell had died trying to expose the truth.

Elara had risked everything to make it right.

And Jax had made sure the killer paid for his crimes.

It wasn't a perfect ending. It wasn't even a happy one.

But it was justice.

And for now, that was enough.